The Summer After

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/46953136.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Summer Camp, Fluff and Angst, Angst with a Happy Ending, Long-Distance Relationship, Other cast members to have appearances, Just not sure about calling them out yet, Homophobic Language, alcohol reference, Named characters may not show up immediately

Language:
English

Series:
Part 11 of Camp Bright Moon

Stats:
Published: 2023-05-04 Completed: 2023-07-07 Words: 43,825 Chapters: 15/15

The Summer After

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/46953136.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Summer Camp, Fluff and Angst, Angst with a Happy Ending, Long-Distance Relationship, Other cast members to have appearances, Just not sure about calling them out yet, Homophobic Language, alcohol reference, Named characters may not show up immediately

Language:
English

Series:
Part 11 of Camp Bright Moon

Stats:

Published: 2023-05-04 Completed: 2023-07-07 Words: 43,825
Chapters: 15/15

The Summer After

by TheSofterGentlerMe

Summary

It's been almost a year since Adora and Catra started their life together after they both abandoned everything they'd ever known. In that time they've both struggled, as Adora went to college and Catra traveled for work. Now, Adora is returning to the place she thinks of as home now, Camp Bright Moon, to work over the summer there. However, she's found that a long distance relationship, even with someone you love, is a hard thing to maintain and she's beginning to wonder if she can manage it.

Back to Camp

Chapter Summary

Adora heads back to Camp Bright Moon with Bow and Glimmer.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It was the middle of May and Adora was sitting in Bow's minivan as they drove from their college towards Camp Bright Moon. Everything she owned in the world was once again packed away in boxes and in the back of his minivan alongside Glimmer's stuff. Glimmer sat in the front seat, tapping on the dashboard in time to the music, singing her own little tune that could be best summed up as she was going home and she was happy.

For Adora, it was a homecoming as well and it was to a place she'd spent less time at than she had in a college dorm over the last year. Before last summer, she'd never even been in the place and now it fit into the spot in her heart that she called home. It wasn't a perfect fit but it worked. Although the one person that really made it a home wasn't going to be there when they got there.

"Adora, you have that look on your face again," Glimmer said as she glanced over her shoulder.

"Just missing Catra," Adora said.

“I know,” Glimmer said. “Dear sweet God, I know.”

“Come on, cut me some slack,” Adora said. “It’s been, what, almost two months now since I saw her?”

“You don’t have the time memorized down to the minute?” Glimmer said with a raised eyebrow.

Adora didn’t actually, although she did to the day, but she really didn’t want to have that kind of conversation and so she said the technical truth.

“No, I don’t have it memorized down to the minute,” Adora said. “I love her, alright, and I miss her.”

Adora didn’t want to say she was also a bit jealous because Catra was traveling with a farrier, learning the trade, and she’d gone far and wide in her travels. Catra was always talking about the places she’d been and people she’d met when she talked with Adora and she felt a bit miffed about it because she’d been stuck on a college campus grinding away at remedial classes and other basic courses.

Glimmer sighed as she said, “I know. Sorry for giving you such a hard time.”

“It’s alright,” Adora replied.

It was quiet in the car for about a mile when Bow finally asked, “Is it alright though?”

“No, it’s not alright,” Adora said. “It’s not alright and I want my girlfriend with me all the time and what in the heck did I give everything up for if I was only going to never, ever see her?”

“She said she'd be up right before Memorial Day,” Bow said. “That’s not much longer.”

“Bow, I don’t want rational thinking,” Adora said. “I want my girlfriend.”

“I can provide the next best thing,” Glimmer said with a little eyebrow waggle.

“You’re dating Bow,” Adora said, looking a bit shocked.

“Adora, honey, sweetheart,” Glimmer said as she held her hand over her face while she laughed and held her cell phone up in the other hand. “I meant I could call her for you.”

Adora blushed heavily as she said, “Uh, sorry, to, um, imply…”

“That Glimmer was hitting on you?” Bow said with a grin. “In front of me, no less?”

“We are not speaking of this ever again,” Adora said.

“You might never speak of it again,” Glimmer said. “I’m definitely going to tuck this one away to bring out at an appropriate time. Now do you want me to call Catra or not?”

“Yes, please,” Adora said, trying not to look too hard at her two amused friends.

Glimmer dialed and handed Adora the phone. It rang and rang and right when Adora was sure it’d go to voicemail, Catra answered.

“Glimmer, I’m kind of busy right now,” Catra said and Adora could hear what sounded like a crowd of people in the background as well as the sounds of horses.

“I’m sorry, it’s me,” Adora said.

“Oh! Hey, babe! How’s it going?” Catra said.

Adora wanted to say that it wasn't going well at all and she missed her but she tucked that away and put on a smile as she said, "It's going a lot better now that I've heard your voice."

"Ah, thanks," Catra said, her voice going soft. "It's going great for me now too."

"Thanks," Adora said, a goofy smile on her face and there was a moment of silence. Adora was about to say something, to say she should let her go since she said she was busy, when she heard a woman in the background shout.

"Hey, Catra, come on! We got shit to do!"

"Who's that?" Adora said.

Catra laughed as she said, "That's Britt, she works this barn I'm at. Listen, I hate to get off here but I have to get back to it." Adora could hear Britt shouting in the background again and Catra shouted she needed to hold her horses, before she came back. "Gotta go. Love you."

"Love you too," Adora said and then the line went dead.

Adora held the phone back to Glimmer and went to stare out the window.

“Better?” Bow said as he looked in the rear view mirror at Adora.

“Yeah, thanks,” Adora said, her voice kind of flat.

Glimmer and Bow looked at each other but let it go. After some more driving, Adora noticed Bow took a different exit than they normally did, the road rising up over the hills instead of following the river.

“Where are we going?” Adora said. “This isn’t the turn is it?”

Glimmer shook her head as she said, “Nope. Remember? Mom wanted me to grab some yeast, flour, and fruit from the store in Oak Springs.”

Adora had heard of the tiny town that was close to Camp Bright Moon but she’d never actually been there before.

“Oh, yeah, that’s right. I can’t believe we haven’t gone before.”

Glimmer snorted in derision as she said, “Yeah, you’re really missing the thriving community of Oak Springs.”

Adora remembered Glimmer talking about some of the teachers at her grade school treating her differently because of her father and shifted a little uncomfortably in the seat.

"You sure we should go there?" Adora said.

"Yes, it's the nearest place," Glimmer said. "We could go to Rogers but that's like another fifteen miles."

"I mean, you said they gave you a hard time as a kid," Adora said. "And we're…"

"Queer?" Glimmer said. "Listen, not everyone in the sticks is like that."

"I mean, I know. Your parents aren't and your aunt isn't or the people she lives with. I just worry," Adora said.

"Adora, I grew up around here. I promise it's fine," Glimmer said.

"Although there is a good reason I don't have any Pride stickers on the van," Bow said as he navigated a few sharp curves going down hill.

Glimmer rolled her eyes as she said in an exaggerated rural accent, “City slickers.”

“Really? City slicker? That’s what you’re going with?” Bow said with a laugh.

“Hey, cut me some slack,” Glimmer said. “The other options have vague racist undertones I’m not touching with a ten foot pole except to beat them with it.”

Bow suddenly saw the speed limit sign that dropped the speed from 60 to 55 and immediately took his van down to 50.

“Ah, the sure sign of a town, the speed trap,” Bow said as another sign just a couple hundred feet further brought it down to 45. Bow was already down to 40 though and had his speed down to 30 before the next sign that said 35 became visible suddenly around a bend in the road.

Adora was looking out the window expecting quaint little homes but what she saw were homes that might have been maybe considered quaint fifty years before but were now just run down. A few were barely visible through the underbrush surrounding them. One house Adora swore had to have been abandoned because of the busted windows covered with tarps and warped plywood and a collapsing porch surprised her when she saw someone come out a side door and sit down on the precast concrete steps to light up a cigarette.

“What happened?” Adora said as they drove through the town square and she saw most of the shops empty.

“Nothing, it’s just a small town, Adora,” Glimmer said. “It was never big to begin with and then when hardship hits people move away and don’t come back. Enough of those and, well, this.”

Bow pulled into the grocery that sat behind a line of empty shops in the town square. The facade hadn’t been updated since the 1970’s but some care had been taken by keeping it painted so it looked just sort of retro instead of dated. The windows had giant signs advertising deals on food as the three got out. Adora heard someone honk as they drove by and Glimmer waved as she took Bow’s hand and started to the door.

“Did you know them?” Adora said as she walked on the other side of her.

“I didn’t get a good look but probably,” Glimmer said. “If I don’t see at least three people I know in here, I’ll be shocked.”

True to her word, as soon as the three stepped through the front doors, the checkout clerk looked up and smiled as she waved at Glimmer.

“Hey, hon!” she said. “Back from school?”

Glimmer waved back as she walked over to the older woman.

"Hey, Ms. Lori," Glimmer said as she gave the woman a hug. "Yeah, I'm back for the summer. Going to work at the camp with Mom and Dad."

"Who're your friends?" Lori asked.

"This is Bow, he's my boyfriend, and this is my friend, Adora. We room together at college," Glimmer replied.

Bow and Adora said hello and Lori grinned as she said, "Well, hello there to both of you. Seems I may have heard a little something about you, Adora. Last summer?"

Glimmer gave her a little handwave and a laugh as she said, "No, not Adora. She's quiet as the day is long."

Lori took the hint and gave a grin and a sly wink as someone came up to the checkout line as she said, "Must have been someone else then. Well, it's nice to meet you both."

"You as well, ma'am," Adora replied as she made sure to not look away in embarrassment.

They headed towards the produce section and Glimmer grabbed a handbasket by a display of garden seeds as they did.

"Do you think she meant, me, um, you know?" Adora said, referring to her leaving her summer camp in a dramatic display with Catra the year before.

"Maybe not that exactly," Glimmer said as she looked over some apples. "Gossip runs fast but it doesn't exactly run accurate. Since the sheriff got involved, it definitely got talked about but that doesn't mean everyone knows what it's actually about."

Adora found herself blushing hard again as she said, "I can not believe this."

"Believe it," Glimmer said. "My family and I have been the subject of various rumors and gossip for years. You get used to it."

"I doubt it," Adora muttered under her breath.

Glimmer grabbed some more fruit and said hello to another person before they'd even got out of the produce section. She went down a few aisles getting the dried yeast her mother had wanted as well as the flour, had a short chat with someone else she knew, introducing Bow and Adora in the process again. Finally, they put down the handbasket at the check out as Lori started unloading it, deftly scanning and bagging as she chatted.

“You hear about the Bartiks?” she said.

“Maybe,” Glimmer said. “Is it about that failed crop they had?”

“Naw, they got a break on that. Government insurance covered it is what I heard,” Lori said as she finished scanning. “Fifteen twenty-four, hon. No, Greg got his hand mangled working on his tractor. They saved it luckily but he couldn’t really do much with it. What with his two oldest moved out of state and his youngest in rehab, he didn’t really have anyone to help him and couldn’t afford to hire on hands. He finally threw in the towel. Sold out, moved away. He and his wife are going to try and live on the proceeds and their Social Security.”

Glimmer got back her change as she shook her head.

“That’s a damn shame. Bartiks have been here since before statehood,” Glimmer said.

“I know,” Lori said with a sigh. “Story of the town really. Farming’s as hard as it's ever been and pays even less, no jobs around to make up the slack, hell, I don’t blame you kids for leaving. Nothing for you here. Only reason I’m still here is to take care of Mama.”

“Well, I’m here for the summer at least,” Glimmer said with a smile.

“You’re a good kid,” Lori said. “I’ll let you go now before the boss gives me the side eye. Say hello to your folks for me.”

“Can do,” Glimmer said with a wave as they all headed out.

They loaded up in the van again and took the short drive to the camp. As Bow turned onto the road that ran to Camp Bright Moon, Adora felt herself smile. When they pulled in front of Micah and Angella’s home, she almost jumped out of the car before it’d even stopped. Angella came out onto the porch as the three got out and came across the lawn to hug everyone.

“Glad you all made it safely,” Angella said.

“Yeah, Bow’s a real maniac on the road,” Glimmer said.

“You know what I mean,” Angella said as she hugged Adora.

“Where’s Dad?” Glimmer asked as they started to unload Glimmer’s stuff from the van onto the lawn.

“Getting the Cottonwood Cove cabins in shape,” Angella said. “Tossa and Spinne showed up a few days early. Mista was already here and so they’re getting ahead on the to-do list. When you’ve got everything put away, you should go and see if he needs help.”

“OK, Mom,” Glimmer said.

After getting Glimmer’s stuff inside, Bow drove around back and they helped Adora unload her stuff into the small travel trailer that she shared with Catra when she was there. Adora stepped inside to find that while Catra still traveled light since she had few possessions, she’d left a few things behind and seeing a hoodie hanging up in the bedroom or a few hair ties sitting by the tiny bathroom sink Adora felt herself getting sad all over again.

“Come on, Adora, I’m not hauling all this stuff by myself!” Glimmer shouted from outside.

“Sorry! I’ll be right there!” Adora said from the bedroom.

Adora picked up the hoodie sleeve, looked around for a moment, and then took a breath of it. The only thing that came back was the smell of laundry detergent. She dropped the sleeve with a sigh and went on outside to help bring her stuff in.

Chapter End Notes

> Just a note, this will be multiple chapters but I'm not sure of an update schedule. I'll aim for at least once a week though.

OK, Adora seeing Oak Springs is based very much on my experience driving around my state and seeing small towns. Like I said, fifty years ago they may have been what people think of when you think of a small town but most of them are dying or dead now. Jobs, and people, have concentrated in the cities and there's nothing for these places. The few small towns I can think of that have avoided this have done so because they're close enough to a big city that they're essentially bedroom communities and any jobs in the town are in support of the majority of the town that work out of town or they have small universities there (or other government jobs) that keep the town employed. In the end, demographics have cut down the small town of myth.

Honestly, Oak Springs having an actual grocery store, and not some dollar store if it has anything, is a bit of me stretching the truth. A town of its size really wouldn't support it but I wanted that interaction with Lori and it's not completely out of the realm of possibility. It's based on a grocery I know in the county seat of a county in my state with a population density of one person per square mile. Well, actually much less, about half the population lives in the county seat and it's a small town and a big county but that's the average. The grocery survives because the nearest grocery is literally an hour away, minimum, in any direction.

Also, the speed limit signs thing is a personal experience. I drive a lot of back highways that go through small towns and every single one is like that to some degree. When I first started driving through places like that, I got advised to go five miles under the speed limit to avoid any possibility of getting pulled over so Bow, being a cautious driver, does the same. There's one town that's actually well known nationwide among RV folks as being such a notorious speed trap, as well as sticklers for any little thing wrong with the car, that I was advised to actually go miles out of my way to avoid it.

This is probably the second to the last Camp Bright Moon story. I say probably because when writing these I sometimes

get an idea and I have to do it but as of right now, it'll be this one and one more. I'll also say this a few times but this entire series has been so different for me. As of right now, the original story for this series is my third most popular fic I've ever written. The two in front of it are only about a hundred and about two hundred, respectively, hits ahead of it and they've been up at least a year longer or more than Camp Horde for the Lord. Just that alone would make it different. However, what's made this so much different than my other works has been the response. It started as me wanting to write a summer camp AU and thinking, "I'll write one partially off some of my church camp experiences."

A lot of it is kind of me personally navigating old emotions and people responded to it. Strongly. I've had people thank me for letting Adora be both queer and religious as they were as well and they felt it reflected themselves. I've had people who'd left the church talk about how this helped them with their journey. I've had people who didn't fully understand because they weren't raised in the church, at least the Evangelical church, and this gave them some understanding as well. Several comments have brought me to tears. It really drives home what I do with my fic. I write for myself but I post it for everyone. And I'm so glad I did with this series. So thank you for reading these and engaging and I can't wait for you to see what's to come.

Settling In

Chapter Summary

> We follow Bow, Glimmer, and Adora as they walk through camp, fight terrible fights against the local greenery, and Adora tries to ignore how she's feeling.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Once Adora had got her stuff put away, she changed into some shorts and a t-shirt with the name of her college on it. She pulled on the boots she'd brought with her to Camp Horde for the Lord when she'd been head counselor the year before. She'd been through so many things since then, admitted she was a lesbian, got a girlfriend, turned her back on her upbringing and mother, and publicly came out at the top of her voice to her old camp and all of that was just in one evening. She'd then worked at Camp Bright Moon while questioning her religion, learning how to live with another person who she was in a relationship with, gone to college, and dealt with a long term relationship, while trying to catch up on an education she had found was lacking, and deeply interrogated her religious beliefs. As she sat on the edge of the bed and looked down at her boots, scuffed up with the soles wearing down and the shoelaces having been replaced with the cheapest ones she could find so they were bright glitter green because she'd replaced them from a sale right after St. Patrick's Day, she had to admit they sure looked like they'd seen all of that.

She met Bow and Glimmer outside and they started walking to find Micah. Even though Adora was still feeling a bit down from missing Catra, she felt herself cheering up as she walked out of

the yard and into the woods. Camp Bright Moon mostly sat near a river bottom so the trees there were a mix of cottonwoods close to the river and then oak and hickory further back. She'd noticed in the winter when she'd stayed over winter break from school that she could actually get a vague idea of where she was in the camp based on what kind of trees were around her. Now she enjoyed the sunlight filtering down through the leaves as Glimmer trucked on along the trail towards a group of cabins at the far edge of camp that Angella had told them Micah had been at.

"I have missed this," Bow said as he took a deep breath of the late afternoon air.

"Yeah, it's good to be home," Glimmer said. "Of course, I'd prefer a UTV or something like it."

"Come on, it's good for us to take our time," Bow said. "We're back on camp time now."

Adora felt a grin slide onto her face. She'd heard that a lot the year before when she'd been working in the office at Camp Bright Moon. It was a concept she didn't quite get at first because she heard it used in several different ways, both complementary and derogatory. She finally figured out it was the basic concept of "everything in its time and place and it'll happen when it happens so for now, just take it easy."

"Bow, I don't want to get there fast, I just don't want to hike all the way out to the cabins," Glimmer said.

“You say that like it’s the other end of the county,” Bow replied.

“It damn near is the other end of the county,” Glimmer said as she cut through a stand of scrub trees with no path and then suddenly came to a screeching halt as she started cursing. “God damn it!”

Adora could already see the problem. Glimmer had not noticed some greenbriar growing in the leaf litter and it’d lived up to its other name, wait-a-minute vine, because it grabbed you out of nowhere as if to say, “Wait a minute, now!”

Bow went into immediate worried boyfriend mode as he tried to figure out how to get up to her in the tight group of trees.

“Are you alright?” he said.

“No, damn it, I’m not! My ankle is tangled up in some greenbriar!” Glimmer snapped back.

Adora was circling as well and started to work through the trees to Glimmer when she suddenly felt a sharp pain on her upper arm.

“Ouch!”

Glimmer sighed as she said, “Adora, you got tangled up too didn’t you?”

Adora could just see the vine that had caught her t-shirt and then tangled her arm.

“Uh, yeah,” Adora said.

“OK, neither one of you move,” Bow said as he got up to Glimmer. Adora heard a snap as Glimmer pulled a pocket knife open and held it back for Bow.

“I am not cutting near your foot,” Bow said. “I’m going to untangle you.”

“Be careful, doof,” Glimmer said.

“As if this is the first time I’ve had to get you out of this stuff,” Bow said. “I swear you have magic powers to find it.”

“Less talky-talk, more getting me free,” Glimmer said.

Bow carefully worked for a moment and Glimmer was soon stepping back on the trail as Bow went over to Adora.

"Is it bad?" Adora asked.

"No," Bow said as he carefully untangled her. "Just caught up a little."

Adora stepped back on the trail finally and felt her arm where it stung a little from the scratches that had been left. She checked her shirt and let out a sigh of relief that it wasn't torn. She didn't have enough clothes to make it through the summer if she was going to tear them up right off the bat.

"Are you two alright?" Bow said.

"Yeah, I'm doing fine," Glimmer replied.

"I'm alright," Adora said.

"OK, then what have we learned about shortcuts?" Bow said.

"Go out the other side instead of back up when we finally get loose," Glimmer said.

“No,” Bow said.

Glimmer gave him a quick kiss as she said, “Yes.”

Bow gave her goofy grin and Adora looked away as she felt a stab of loneliness. Neither of the two noticed though as they started walking again and Adora fell in behind them on the narrow trail.

They finally got to the group of cabins that made up Cottonwood Cove. It was four cabins, two across from the other two, with a small campfire ring and log benches out between them. The cabins themselves could sleep about ten campers a piece and sat up on stilts so they were about four feet off the ground with stairs going up to a porch out front. One edge of the clearing was lined with cottonwoods that gave the spot its name and it’d flooded before, although never badly. It wasn’t a popular spot, since the nearest bathhouse was a bit of a walk, and Micah had said several times he was going to tear it all down and reuse what he could to build some more in a better place but he never got around to it. Normally it just served as overflow if a camp session happened to be completely full and when it wasn’t that, he used it for storage and the counselors sometimes used it as a place to get away in the evenings. As they walked out of the trees and into the clearing, Adora saw Mista with a fresh green dye job on her hair up on a roof as she helped Spinne finish fixing some loose shingles.

“It’s about time you all made it!” Mista shouted at them as they came in.

“Hey, some of us had things to do!” Glimmer shouted back.

“Don’t refer to Bow as things,” Mista said as they got up to the cabin. Adora blushed heavily at the innuendo and Mista grinned as she raised her hammer up in salute. “Adora, I see college hasn’t changed you a bit.”

“No, I’m fine,” Adora said. She’d worked with Mista in the office the previous summer and the woman was laconic with no filter.

“You’re not but that’s fine, we love you,” Mista said.

“Don’t let her bully you,” Spinne said as she slid down a little. “How’s your other half?”

Adora had received several pieces of advice from Spinne and her girlfriend Tossa about life in general as well as her relationship with Catra and she respected the older women. Her and Tossa’s casual flirting even after having been together for years as well as general air of competence was something Adora aspired towards even if she didn’t fully realize it.

“She’s doing good,” Adora said. “I spoke to her earlier but she’s busy. She’ll be here in a week or so.”

Spinne looked at her for a moment before smiling.

"I know you can't wait," she said.

Adora gave an empathetic nod of her head as Glimmer spoke up, "I hate to cut this short but do you know where Dad got off to?"

"Him and Tossa went to get some cleaning stuff," Mista said. "We're almost done with these."

"Is someone really going to stay here?" Bow asked.

"Oh, you didn't hear," Mista said as she cleared her throat.

"What didn't I hear?" Bow said.

"We're staying here this year," Spinne said.

"Excuse me?" Bow replied. He'd stayed at Cottonwood Cove once when he'd first come to camp and while he didn't hate it, he didn't exactly want to spend an entire summer there.

“This must be what Dad said when he said he was changing things around,” Glimmer replied.

“Yeah, well, you’re cabin staff,” Mista said. “You get to stay at your cabin. Us programs folks have to make do.”

Glimmer rolled her eyes as she said, “Oh, please. Everyone knows programs gets to have more fun.”

“And cabin gets all the glory because you deal with the kids and you’re seen as saints,” Mista replied.

“Am I staying out here?” Adora said. She’d lived in the trailer the year before.

“Far as I know, you got the trailer,” Mista said.

“Spinne, you and Tossa don’t have to stay here, do you?” Adora said.

“We chose to,” Spinne said. “One of the cabins is being turned over to storage and we got to pick which one. We’ll have a space for just the two of us. Really, I think it won’t be bad. We get all four cabins. It’s not like there’s forty of us. We’ll be able to spread out.”

Adora shuffled around, thinking of sitting in the trailer all by herself for weeks at a time while Catra was away and gritted her teeth a little. She didn't notice Spinne slide down to the ladder and watch her before coming down.

"Glimmer, you think I could stay out here with the rest of the programs staff?" Adora said.

"I don't see why not but are you sure?" Glimmer said.

"Yeah," Adora said. "I'll keep most of my stuff at the trailer but I'm going to be by myself there. I'd rather be here."

"Ah, Adora, don't martyr yourself," Mista said.

"It's not martyrdom," Adora replied. "It's just fellowship."

"No verse for that?" Mista said in a teasing tone.

Adora had been prodded by Mista before about her religion, never cruelly but definitely teasing, but Adora was ready this summer.

"Well, fellowship but maybe not with you because as it says in Second Corinthians, 'For what do righteousness and wickedness

have in common?’ So I mean, what do we have in common, Mista?” Adora replied.

Mista blinked once before suddenly bursting out into laughter.

“OK, college did change you after all!” Mista said as she slid to the edge of the roof and then down the ladder. “No way you would have dropped that on me last year. Listen, Righteous, you and I are going to have a hell of a time this summer.”

“You would say hell…, Wicked,” Adora said a bit haltingly as she picked up on the wordplay.

“Not bad. Your first comeback, a solid nine,” Glimmer said. “That one? The judges say a six.”

“Who’s judging this?” Bow said.

“Glimmer, apparently,” Spinne replied. “Come on, let’s get the shutters open on these things so they can air out some.”

They started towards the stairs when they heard a motor as Micah and Tossa returned. Spinne suddenly stopped and said, “You all open up the shutters. Adora and I are going to bring the stuff over.”

“OK, don’t take forever though,” Mista said. “I know you just want to make out with Tossa.”

“That is not your business,” Spinne said. “And don’t make me bring up Sea Hawk.”

“You shut your damn mouth,” Mista said.

“Hey, you’re the one who decided to date him,” Spinne said as she backed up with a laugh. Adora followed her towards the little road that stopped just at the edge of the clearing.

“What’s wrong with you and Catra?” Spinne said as they walked.

“Nothing,” Adora said, suddenly on the defensive. “Why? What have you heard?”

“Well, you saying that, which means you’re nervous,” Spinne said. “Also, how you talked about it and how you mentioned being alone. Are you two having trouble with the long distance thing?”

Adora didn’t really want to talk to her about it, mostly out of a fear of voicing it would make it real but also from not wanting to be a burden, and she just shook her head as she said, “We’re making it work.”

Spinne waved at Tossa as she hopped off the side-by-side UTV that Micah was driving.

"OK, but you know you can talk with us. Any of us," Spinne said. "Well, maybe not Mista. She'd probably just roast you."

Adora laughed as they got up to the UTV and grabbed the cleaning supplies and took them back to get down to work.

Chapter End Notes

Greenbriar is both a menace and a favorite plant of mine. It's an absolute nightmare to deal with because it really does seem to ambush you, and the scratches it leaves are not a lick of fun, but it's also a tenacious little bastard of a plant. Edible as well. I have gotten tangled up in it in the weirdest ways and I'm surprised I don't have scars from those moments. I was walking through tall grass once, not a tree for a hundred feet, and for some reason it was growing there and wrapped around my leg. Honey locust is worse when it comes to thorns but those are trees and thus pretty easy to avoid (and really, really cool looking).

Also, and this has absolutely nothing to do with the story but I just found this out when I was looking up honey locust, I found out that Cherokees may have once cultivated them. A biologist noticed that when he found Cherokee village sites, he'd find stands of honey locust as well. May or may not be related but it's a pretty cool thought.

This chapter may also be the first time I had to go to a sporting goods site for a story because I could not for the life of me remember what a UTV was called. I could only remember ATV but that was not what I was thinking of.

I said on Tumblr today that some people research out of the ordinary things for stories and fall down a rabbit hole. Well, I don't normally do that too badly (although I did a bit with the honey locust thing above) but one of the things I do for a living is work in CAD. So my out of the ordinary thing for this story is that when I was trying to think of how to describe the cabins at Cottonwood Cove, I ended up drawing a cabin in CAD. It's decent enough that with a bit more work, you could probably build the thing. Now I just need a sprawling acreage along a riverfront to put it on.

As always, thank you for reading and I can't wait for you to read more!

Work and Telephone Calls

Chapter Summary

> Adora works hard at Camp Bright Moon, almost hard enough to not be bothered by Catra's absence. Then, a telephone call.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora had been worried about missing Catra too much, especially without school to distract her. She shouldn't have worried. The next week was spent getting the camp ready for the first campers that'd show up on Memorial Day weekend. She got up with the Sun, had breakfast, worked until lunch, had lunch, and then worked all day until late afternoon or early evening when they'd have dinner and then the staff would stagger back to Cottonwood Cove to hang out and go to bed shortly after sundown. They cleared trails, repainted signs, hauled dirt and gravel, worked on cabins and other camp buildings both cleaning them and repairing where needed, and any other thing that came up. Adora thought of Catra but it was usually at night as she lay down and since she was usually fast asleep in minutes, it wasn't long enough to get too lonely.

It wasn't all work and toil though. They took time out to swim in the river, play games, and just generally be young and out in the woods with little contact from the outside world. Adora was one of the few people on staff who didn't have a cell phone but it didn't matter. Cell reception was only reliable up by the road and Micah and Angella's house and then faded pretty quick as you went back onto the camp property and it completely disappeared at Cottonwood Cover. Couple that with the fact that almost none of

the cabins had electricity, and Cottonwood Cove was definitely in that rank, so it wasn't easy to keep a phone charged and Adora really did feel like they lived in an insular world. She thought it must be what a monastery or nunnery would be like. Of course, there probably weren't as many obscenities there.

"Shit god damn!" Adora heard as she finished raking the gravel path that ran down to the dock.

Adora put the rake over her shoulder and went out on the covered dock to see Tossa holding her thumb.

"You alright?" Adora asked.

"No!" Tossa said as she held her thumb carefully sticking out. "I can't believe I missed the goddamn nail!"

Adora sat the rake down and went over to her, kneeling down as she looked at the thumb.

"You want me to get an ice pack?"

"No! Hell no!" Tossa said. "You ever put ice on something like this?"

“Never had something like this happen,” Adora said. “You want me to help with the hammering?”

Tossa nodded as she slid backwards on the boards of the dock as she said, “You know how?”

Adora had already picked up the hammer and was looking at the bent nail sticking out of the board.

“Um… no?” Adora said.

Tossa laughed a little before wincing again as her thumb throbbed and said, “OK, I’ll tell you how, you follow along. Try not to make two casualties.”

Adora fumbled a few times, afraid she’d whack her hand as well, and bent more than a few nails but soon she had the hang of it. While she definitely wasn’t a master carpenter, she could at least put a nail in a board. When she finished up and was walking back towards the main camp with Tossa, she was holding the hammer and as she idly twirled it in her hand, her thoughts drifted to Catra, who worked with hammers every day in her job. She remembered over the winter when she’d seen her and realized just how buff she’d become from working with horses and hammering on metal.

Thinking of that though led to her thinking of how much she missed her. Tossa was saying something about how maybe it was

about time to take a break and all Adora could think about was how she wanted to scoop Catra up and hug her tight while she showered her with kisses.

"Adora."

She was thinking of nuzzling Catra's hair and could just about smell the vague floral scent of the horse shampoo Catra used because it was easy to get a hold of around the stables she worked in and it worked well on top of that.

"Adora."

Catra's hair was really soft…

"Adora!"

"Huh?"

"You alright?" Tossa said as they came to a stop by the arts and crafts pavilion.

"Yeah, I'm fine. You're right, we should take a break," Adora said.

“I said that a couple of minutes ago,” Tossa said. “I was talking about an idea I had for a new game for the kids. Do you remember any of that?”

Adora grimaced as she shook her head.

“No, I’m sorry.”

“You really miss her don’t you?” Tossa said.

“I was just spacing out,” Adora said.

“Sure you were,” Tossa replied. “Spinne told me something was up. Want to talk about it?”

“Nothing's up. I just haven’t seen her in a while. She’ll be here soon though,” Adora replied and then her face lit up. “In fact, I get to talk to her tonight! We made plans so I could call her on the camp phone at seven!”

Tossa smiled at Adora’s response as she said, “That’s good. I know it’s hard to do the long distance thing.”

Adora nodded as she said, “It is and I’m sorry I wasn’t listening to your game idea.”

“It’s alright,” Tossa replied. “I can always tell you again. And just remember, you gotta be sure you two are talking with each other and not at each other. That’s what doomed my long distance relationship.”

“Wait, you were in a long distance relationship?” Adora said.

“Yeah,” Tossa said. “I knew Spinne, from here actually, but we hadn’t dated. I was head over heels with someone. We didn’t ever really talk well though. It was at each other, like I said, not with.”

Adora felt a little dread settle in her stomach. Tossa and Spinne were solid together and she couldn't imagine either of them screwing up a relationship.

If they can screw it up, I really can, Adora thought.

“Well, what’s the difference?” Adora said out loud as they started walking again towards the camp office.

“Listen,” Tossa replied. “Don’t just wait for your turn to talk. Listen to what she has to say.”

“I do that though,” Adora said.

Tossa shrugged as she waved at Bow coming towards the office as well as she said, "Just think about it a bit."

It was almost four in the afternoon when they got to the office and Micah was sitting on the ground out front with Spinne, Bow, Glimmer, Mista, and Kevin.

"I think it's break time, boss," Tossa said as she stepped into the shade of the building.

"I think it's time to call it quits for the day," Micah said to general exaggerated relieved sighs and Mista giving slow applause. "Yeah, I'm a real taskmaster monster, I know, so this will really get you cheered up. We're actually ahead on the schedule. I call tomorrow as a slack day."

It was Glimmer that started the chant of, "Slack day! Slack day! Slack day! Slack day!" and the rest joined in. Adora was chanting right along, feeling a warmth in her chest that she didn't recognize at first but would later recognize as the same feeling she got when she was in church and singing together with a large crowd, and everyone started laughing when Micah started drumming on his legs in time to the chant.

"This has nothing to do with the fact you gotta go out to Aunt Casta's tomorrow does it?" Glimmer said as the laughing and chanting died down.

"It has some to do with that," Micah replied. "We really are ahead though so let's not work ourselves to the bone. Let's get this stuff put away and then I'll see you all at the dining hall for dinner."

Everyone broke up as Adora said hello to Kevin, who'd just showed up that afternoon, and Mista good naturedly gave him grief for taking just long enough to get back to camp until most of the heavy work was done. Adora got her stuff put away and then went off with Bow and Glimmer. As she walked, she could see the fruit of their labors everywhere. Things never looked crummy at Camp Bright Moon but after the cold and ice of the winter and the leaves from fall and finally the heavy rains of spring, things did need a bit of sprucing up and they'd done a good job.

"Bow, you know what we haven't done yet?" Glimmer said as she sat down under the arts and crafts pavilion to get out of the sun.

"Shot archery much this year?" Bow said.

"You're out there almost every evening," Glimmer said.

"And there's morning, afternoon, and night as well," Bow said with a little grin.

Adora had her hand around a metal pole that ran from the concrete floor to the roof and leaned out, slowly spinning around

the pole as she listened.

"But you have other things to do then," Glimmer said with an eyebrow waggle.

"Well, yeah, like paint, sweep, fix squeaky stair treads, and…" Bow said.

"And what?" Glimmer said leaning in.

"Sleeping," Bow whispered to her.

"I'll remember that," Glimmer said as she sat back in a mock huff.

Bow pulled her close and kissed her before he said, "Remember that instead."

"That was the smoothest I've seen you in a while," Glimmer said.

Bow laughed as he said, "Because I had it all set in my mind and it went that way for once."

“You still haven’t said what you want to do,” Adora said as she revolved past.

“It’s not what I want to do. It’s what we haven’t done and I can’t believe we haven’t done it yet,” Glimmer said.

“You going to say or should we start a game of charades?” Bow said.

“What does Adora not have?” Glimmer said.

Adora slowed down to look at Glimmer as Bow said, “This is maybe not the conversation to have.”

“Oh, God, you two. She doesn’t have a camp nickname!” Glimmer said. “I mean, I’m Sparkles, you’re Arrow Bow but we somehow never got Adora one.”

Adora let go of the pole, stumbled a little as her head kept twirling, and managed to sit down beside the other two.

“It’s alright,” Adora said. “I like my name.”

“Nope! It will not stand!” Glimmer said, throwing her hand up in the hair with a finger pointing at the ceiling. “I swear by the

pavilion of my father that before the first camper arrives, we will have you a camp nickname!”

“You know you can’t force it,” Bow said. “Remember when you tried to get everyone to call me Horatio?”

“What?” Adora said, looking at Glimmer in confusion.

“Doesn’t he look like a Horatio to you?” Glimmer asked.

“No,” Adora said.

“Well, everyone else agreed with you,” Glimmer said with a sigh.

“You should know you can’t force a nickname by now. I’m telling you, whatever you have in mind for Adora isn’t going to work out,” Bow replied.

“I don’t have anything in mind… yet,” Glimmer said.

“I’m sure you don’t,” Bow said.

“Really, I don’t!” Glimmer said. “Wait, Mista called you Righteous the other day. How about that?”

“No,” Adora said deadpan.

Glimmer pursed her mouth as she thought and then said, “Adora, do you have anything you’d like to try and get off the ground?”

Adora just shook her head after thinking for a minute.

“It’ll happen. I can feel it in my bones,” Glimmer replied.

“And the pavilion of your father?” Bow said.

“No, silly, I don’t feel anything in that. That’s just for swearing oaths by,” Glimmer said with a grin.

Later, after dinner, Adora sat down at the desk in the small office. She picked up the phone and dialed Catra’s number exactly at seven. It rang twice, each ring like a wrench tightening her stomach, when it was answered right before the third ring.

“Hey, Adora.”

All the tension fled out of Adora as she sighed and said, “Hey there to you. How’re you doing?”

“Oh, three hundred miles from you and wishing you were right here,” Catra said.

“I feel the same way,” Adora said.

“What you been up to?” Catra asked.

“I moved into Cottonwood Cove,” Adora said.

“Those cabins way back at the edge of the property?” Catra said in confusion.

“Yeah,” Adora said. “The rest of the programs staff is staying out there. Since it’s just me in the trailer, I figured I’d stay out there except when you’re at the trailer so I have company.”

“That’s good. I don’t want you to be lonely,” Catra said.

“I don’t want you to be either,” Adora said.

“I’ve got Reggie to keep me company,” Catra said with a laugh and then her voice went soft. “It’s not you though.”

“Ah, I love you,” Adora said.

“I love you too,” Catra said. “Now tell me what else you’ve been up to.”

Adora listed off some of the stuff they’d been working on and Catra made little noises as appropriate as she listened.

“How about you?” Adora said.

Catra told her about working with the horses and how she and Reggie, her boss slash mentor that was teaching her about being a farrier, were getting along and how the place they were at was so ridiculously humid even though it wasn’t even the end of May yet.

“So are you still going to be here Sunday?” Adora said thinking about how it was only two nights and a day away. The silence that echoed down the line was every answer Adora needed. “You’re not.”

Catra could hear the horrible disappointment in Adora’s voice as she sighed and said, “I’m not. It’s going to be Tuesday, probably at night, and then I still need to leave by Thursday morning.”

“We’re only going to get a day at most,” Adora said, trying not to sound as miserable as she felt. “And I have to work on Wednesday.”

“I know but I’ll work with you,” Catra said. “We’ll make the best of it. I can’t miss the weekend. There’s a big horse show this weekend that had a farrier drop out. We can make good money.”

Adora sighed as she wiped at a tear. Catra was already in demand for her work and she knew she was socking money back for the two of them but a little traitorous voice said what was the point if the two of them were never together.

“I get it,” Adora said.

“I’m sorry,” Catra said and Adora could hear it.

“It’s alright,” Adora said, not really meaning it but saying it to avoid an argument.

“It’s not but I’ll try and make it up to you somehow,” Catra said.

“You don’t have to,” Adora said. “Just be here Tuesday.”

“I will,” Catra said and then they were both quiet for a moment. Adora heard a woman’s voice say something close to Catra.

“Who’s that?” Adora asked, suddenly suspicious for some reason.

“Oh, that’s Britt. She’s horse people and she quit her job at that barn I was at the other day. She’s doing traveling grooming services now,” Catra said. “She walked by the awning I’m under and said hello.”

All kinds of images floated unbidden into Adora’s mind about Britt and Catra and she gritted her teeth as she tried not to respond. She managed to say, “Oh, that’s cool.”

“You alright?” Catra said.

“Just sad I can’t see you sooner,” Adora said.

“I feel the same way,” Catra said. “I gotta go though. I’m almost out of minutes on this card and I won’t be able to get to the store tomorrow.”

“OK, I love you,” Adora said.

“I love you too,” Catra said. “See you soon.”

The line went dead and Adora sat in the small office trying not to cry and scream at the same time.

Chapter End Notes

> The horse shampoo thing is no joke. It really does work great. Supposed to be good for people with sensitivities as well from what I’ve heard. I can not speak to it causing you to space out with longing for your partner but it seems reasonable.
>
> Also, it looks like some trouble may be on the horizon. We'll see how that works out.

A Day At The River

Chapter Summary

The Camp Bright Moon staff go for a hike along the river while Adora has unwelcome thoughts pop up.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora hoped the slack day would get her mind off of Catra. Bow talked everyone into going for a hike up a trail along the river that they forbid the kids to take because it was overgrown, went through other people's property, washed out on a regular basis, and they ran into venomous snakes on it three times out of five. It was still a great trail because it also went along under several looming limestone cliffs with little seeps feeding ferns and moss, was overhung with various trees, and one spectacular willow, and ended at Coopers Hole, a slow, lazy pool that had been carved out by the river where stone slabs sat and were overhung by huge old trees that shaded it making it cool on all but the hottest of days.

As they walked along the trail, laughing and joking, Adora did find herself falling into the rhythm and laughing along with the rest. It was a muggy day that would probably turn to rain around dinner but for now it was a good time to be out on the trail. Bow carried a heavy backpack loaded up with lunch and his guitar. Mista wouldn't stop teasing him about it, especially since he seemed to catch it on every bit of overgrowth they walked under. Glimmer came to Bow's defense constantly while Spinne and Tossa kept calling them children and to calm down while laughing. Adora was near the back of the pack and just smiled while Kevin would just sigh and roll his eyes as he brought up the rear.

“Come on, Kevin, keep up!” Glimmer shouted.

“Why do I let you all talk me into these things?” Kevin said.

“Because you love us,” Spinne said.

“Because I don’t have a car and couldn’t go into Rogers,” Kevin replied.

“What in the hell would you do in Rogers?” Glimmer said.

“They have a movie theater,” Kevin said.

“It has two screens,” Glimmer said.

“Then I could see two movies,” Kevin said as he wiped the sweat off his brow and then swatted at a bug. “Inside and in air conditioning I might add.”

“It’s still May. Just going to get hotter,” Adora said with a smile.

“Did Adora just sass me?” Kevin said.

“In her own way, yes,” Mista said. “Now come on. I want to hit the river before lunch and you know Bow won’t let us swim for an hour after eating.”

“You know that’s an old wives tale, right?” Tossa replied.

“There’s still some evidence for it,” Bow said.

“Hey! Water! I’m not in it! Let’s march, people!” Mista said as she started walking.

“Putting her in charge of the dock this year was a good idea,” Bow said as Mista disappeared around a bend in the trail.

“Have you seen her swim?” Glimmer said. “I still don’t know why she’s not gone pro.”

“Less talk, more walk!” Mista shouted from up the trail.

The last bit of the hike to their destination got a little quiet and Adora sank into her mind as she walked. At first, her mind just kept a little “hup, hup” noise in time with her feet as she walked. Then, she’d notice something interesting on a leaf like a gall or a

bug. Then her mind decided to betray her and she thought of Catra and how much fun it'd be to do this with her. Catra wasn't a huge fan of water or swimming but she'd done it with Adora the previous summer.

She found herself thinking about how Catra would be there the next day. Then she remembered the call the night before and that she wouldn't be there until Tuesday. Her pace didn't falter and she didn't cry like she had the night before but her mind drifted to her mother and things she'd said about queer relationships with someone at a dinner party at her house one night several years back.

"You heard that Joseph left his wife for a man?" Janet, one of the people Adora's mother worked with at church, said.

Sharon, Adora's mother, shook her head as she made tsking noises.

"I did. He's a fool. Allison is a good woman and would have treated him right," Sharon said. "He's just feeding his lust. You know how those people are, they can't make any kind of real connection. It's just jumping from person to person."

Janet had nodded agreement as she picked up a little stack of crackers, salami, and cheese and the conversation drifted to something else.

Adora was thinking of that now. Was that all her relationship with Catra had been? Was she really in love? Was she doomed to never really have someone? She looked at Spinne and Tossa as they walked along, Spinne passing a water bottle back to Tossa as they went, and remembered what Tossa had said about her prior relationship falling apart. Were they really going to last or were they just going to break up as well? She once again had a little voice nag her that she'd been damned for daring to love like she did and she fought to get it back down. Then she thought of Britt and her misery shifted to anger.

She's trying to get Catra, Adora thought. *Why else would she quit a job and suddenly be where Catra is at? That… tramp.*

Adora had another word instead of tramp but she wouldn't quite let the word she wanted to use even into her head. Then she actually stopped for a moment as she thought that maybe Catra was the reason. Maybe it was Catra who'd talked her into quitting. It made sense for her to latch onto someone who'd be there, unlike Adora who didn't even have a car to go and see Catra if she wanted.

"Hey, pick up the pace," Kevin said from behind her.

Adora realized she'd slowed down a little and gave Kevin an apologetic smile.

"Sorry, got lost in my head."

“No problem,” Kevin said. “I just almost plowed over you.”

Adora shook her head as she picked up the pace, determined not to think of Catra that way. It wasn’t as if she had a reason to doubt her but the doubt still lingered.

Not much longer and they were walking out onto the stone slabs to two people leaned up against a tree. Adora slowed down a little when she saw they each had a gun leaned against the tree.

“Ah, looks like Bright Moon’s out for a hike,” one man, the older of the two said.

“Hey, Kurt, Jason,” Glimmer said as she walked over to the two. “Whatcha doing?”

Kurt stood up and stretched as he went over to Glimmer. The younger man just gave a little wave.

“Squirrel season just started,” he said. “Figured we’d get out and look around, see what’s what.”

“You’d have better luck off that way,” Glimmer said. “Not a lot of oak down this way.”

“I know,” Jason said. “This is less serious hunting and more a heavily armed walk in the woods with Dad here.”

Glimmer laughed, while the rest of the group stood in varying degrees of discomfort.

“Yeah, that’s a .22 ya got there,” Glimmer said. “I think heavily armed is not quite the phrase to use.”

Jason laughed as well as he said, “Hey, she shoots straight and does the job.”

“Shame you don’t,” Kurt said with a smirk.

“Alright, old man,” Jason said. “We’ll see who gets limit today and who doesn’t.”

“It’s past eleven,” Glimmer said. “I don’t think either one of you is getting your limit sitting around watching the river go past.”

“Well, some things are more important,” Kurt said.

Jason nodded as he said, “Absolutely.”

Kurt looked at the group standing around, gave a little head nod, and said, "Your buddies?"

"Yep," Glimmer said. "This is my boyfriend Bow. You might have seen Spinne and Tossa there around town. That's Mista, she's running the docks this year. In the back there is Kevin, he's in charge of our sports and standing next to him is Adora. She's doing gopher stuff around camp and is my roommate at college. Guys, this is Kurt and Jason. They live a bit that way."

"Yeah, I think I've heard of a few of ya. Nice to meetcha all," Kurt said and Jason echoed the sentiment as the Camp Bright Moon group all said some variation of hello. "So did you come across Jenson's land to get here?"

Glimmer rolled her eyes as she said, "Yes. Is he back on his high horse about that?"

"Did he ever get off it?" Jason said.

"He didn't seem to care last year," Glimmer replied.

"Well he wasn't growing wacky weed again last year," Kurt replied.

"Is that why he's so touchy sometimes?" Glimmer replied.

Kurt laughed as he said, “I guess your folks never told you about that. Yeah, anytime he wants a new truck or something stupid, he tries a crop. Lands going to get seized one day if the Sheriff ever decides to take notice.”

“Well, it’s just that little stretch along the river so I doubt he’ll notice less I run into him,” Glimmer said. “And I’m sure his crop is nothing worse than a certain still I’ve heard about.”

Kurt grinned as he said, “Your aunt telling stories again?”

“Not saying,” Glimmer said.

“Well, I won’t say yes or no but don’t come around asking,” Kurt said. “Your dad would be pissed if I sold to you.”

“What about to me?” Mista said.

Kurt and Jason both laughed as Kurt said, “Sorry. Shops closed to Bright Mooners.”

Mista made a little snapping, aw shucks gesture that got another round of chuckles. Mista’s comment also seemed to have loosened the rest up because Bow took his pack off and the rest started to mingle about.

“You want some lunch?” Bow said. “We should have enough.”

“Naw, thanks, but we really got some squirrels to find for dinner,” Kurt said and Jason took that as a hint to get up. He slung the rifle over his shoulder and carried Kurt’s over to him who did the same.

“Alright,” Glimmer said as she pointed at the trigger on Jason’s rifle. “Just remember, the pointy end goes towards the squirrel and that little thing right there makes it go bang.”

Jason laughed as he said, “I can still outshoot you.”

“You never could but it’s cute you think you can,” Glimmer said.

Kurt chuckled as the two went up the hill and were soon out of sight.

“I am not eating right now,” Mista said as she shucked out of her boots, shorts, and shirt to go running into the river in her swimming suit. “Save me something.”

Kevin followed her and soon most of the group was in the water. Adora sat on the edge of a rock that was partially submerged as she felt the slow current tug at her and watched Spinne and Tossa laugh and splash each other. Bow was pulling food out of the pack

and setting it on the ground as Glimmer stretched out on the stone and looked at the canopy overhead.

"You know how to shoot?" Bow said as he got his guitar and started tuning.

"Yep," Glimmer said. "Guess I never told you."

Bow shook his head as he said, "I didn't even know your parents owned guns."

"They own gun, singular," Glimmer replied. "Dad had it as a kid. It's just a little .22 bolt action. As far as I know it's still wrapped up in an old bedsheet in their closet. I haven't seen it in years. I didn't learn to shoot from them, I learned to shoot in the brief moment I was trying to be popular at school. Jason taught me actually."

"That guy?" Bow said, nodding off towards where Kurt and Jason had gone.

"Yeah," Glimmer said. "He's a few years older than me but small town, everyone hangs out. Before you ask, yes, I wasn't joking. I am the better shot."

"I would never doubt my girl," Bow said as he gave her a kiss.

Bow and Glimmer sat out on the bank while Bow played a few songs and watched the others swim. About an hour later, people started coming in to eat. Mista was the last out of the water, grumbling about having to leave the river, but she still ate the sandwiches that had been made that morning and drank the sun tea that was still nice and cold from the single giant chunk of ice that had been put in the container. Soon they were all laid out on the stone, little damp spots of river water marking where they'd sat at one point or another staining the stone darker, and Adora found herself at peace for a moment.

Everyone was talking, slow and easy, as they waited to go back into the water when the background noise of an outboard motor started to become a bit louder.

"Someone 'bout to pass," Glimmer said slowly.

Mista sat up a little and then groaned as the boat came into view.

"It's Sea Hawk."

Kevin said, "You know, you could just break up with him."

Mista was already on her feet and heading for the water as Sea Hawk's voice came booming across the water and everyone could see him waiving.

“Naw, I think I’ll keep him. For now,” Mista said as she hit the water.

“Looks like he got his hands on a camp boat,” Glimmer said.

“Maybe you should take it back,” Bow said. “I don’t think he’s burned anything lately but why take the chance?”

The boat hadn’t even stopped moving when Mista was already over the side and giving Sea Hawk a kiss, to the assorted hoots and hollers from the bank. She waved back at them, using only one finger, and then helped Sea Hawk get the boat to the shore.

“My fellow staff!” Sea Hawk said as he stepped onto the shore. “I have arrived!”

“What took so long?” Tossa asked.

“Well, it is a long story, best told as an epic poem,” Sea Hawk said as the rest shouted out no. “Perhaps another time but I was delayed.”

“He missed his bus connection and has been hitchhiking is what he told me,” Mista said as she slipped her arms around him.

“You were going to be here three days ago,” Glimmer said.

“It takes a long time to come up from the Gulf,” Sea Hawk said.

“OK, well at least you’re here at least,” Glimmer replied.

“I am,” Sea Hawk said and then shuffled his foot a little as he fiddled with his mustache. “Do you have anything left to eat?”

Bow tossed him a sandwich and he sat down to eat. The conversation started back up again and soon everyone was back in the water, including Bow and Glimmer. They messed around for a few more hours before Mista, Kevin, Tossa and Spinne got into the boat with Sea Hawk and motored up the river back to camp.

“You sure you don’t want me to come back for you?” Sea Hawk said before he left.

“Naw, it’s fine. See you back at camp,” Glimmer said as Adora helped get the boat back into the current.

Twenty minutes later Glimmer, Bow, and Adora were walking back up the trail. Adora was at the back again and was in a great mood that slowly eroded as she watched Glimmer and Bow interact with each other. It wasn’t that they left her out but that she felt like a

third wheel anyway as they held hands on the wider sections of trail or shared little in-jokes back and forth. By the time they got back to Cottonwood Cove, Adora just dumped her pack on her bunk, told Glimmer and Bow she'd catch up, and then went off to the bathhouse in a bad mood as in her head, Catra and Britt laughed and chatted with each other and worse.

Chapter End Notes

> Adora doing the "hup, hup" thing in her head is something I've done on long hikes. When I was a teenager, I did a twenty mile hike in a day (it took about eight hours) and I'm here to tell you, you do a lot of things to keep yourself distracted while you walk and that means sometimes letting your mind just kind of go hup, hup to your pace and just zoning out.
>
> Also, if you don't know what the whole limit thing was about with Glimmer, Kurt, and Jason, it's in reference to how many animals you can take in a day of hunting. There's a daily limit and possession limit. For example, you can take ten squirrels in a day, your daily limit, and then have ten more at home to make twenty total, your possession limit. So basically Jason and Kurt are giving each other grief saying the other isn't a good hunter and the other is better. If you're wondering this came about as one solution to curtail market/commercial hunting, which sold various animal products (meat, skin, feathers, etc) and which drove several species to extinction and threatened many more (it used to be a newspaper worthy event to see a deer in some places). Things like the Migratory Bird Treaty Act is another solution to this.
>
> Also, don't hitchhike. It's not safe but it's Sea Hawk. He's probably confused more than one serial killer into deciding he wasn't worth the trouble.

Spaghetti and Cinnamon Apples

Chapter Summary

> Adora is beginning to question Catra's loyalty as she wonders just who she heard over the phone. Now, by herself, she thinks she knows what's going on.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora spent a long time in the shower at the bathhouse. Aside from the toilets, the whole thing was open to the sky, with the hot water provided by a solar warming array on the roof. Adora stood under the shower head letting the water wash the river silt off and let the heat drive the thoughts out of her head. After a long time, she heard people outside and let out a long sigh as she quickly washed her hair and then shut the shower off and stepped out of the little stall as she wrapped a towel around herself and sat on a bench and brushed her hair as the sun beat down on her.

"Hey, Adora," Mista said as she went back to one of the shower stalls.

"Hey," Adora said back but Mista didn't take notice of anything. Adora finished brushing her hair, put it up in a ponytail as a little part of her brain told her she needed to clean up her undercut, and then got dressed and went back to the cabin. No one was around and she assumed Glimmer and Bow had gone off for some private time and she seethed at the thought and then felt guilty for being upset about her friend's happiness, even while she still seethed at it.

Adora went to her bunk at the back of the room, a little stuffed horse on the bed marking it as hers, and she dropped her shower kit on the floor and shoved her pack to the floor as well before sitting on the side of the bed wiping at her eyes as she hugged the stuffed horse and kicked her boots off. Her eyes flicked up to the top of the night stand with shelves under it that sat by her bed. Her Bible and notebook sat there. She put her stuffed horse down and picked up the Bible before rolling over on her stomach. She remembered a youth pastor who'd talked about a way to try and figure out the Lord's will was to say a little prayer for guidance and then open the Bible at random and read what was there.

"The Lord will guide your hand," she remembered him saying. So she did that.

"Give me guidance please," Adora said as she shut her eyes, put her hands on her Bible and opened it. She opened her eyes to look and noticed she'd opened it to Leviticus. She wasn't sure if it was at that verse but she slammed the book shut anyway without checking. She suddenly had the urge to fling her Bible across the room and was picking it up when she felt shame flow through her. She carefully sat it back on the nightstand and then rolled over to stare at the rafters overhead. She thought about going and calling Catra again but then she thought about what would happen if she heard Britt again in the background. She loved Catra but at the moment she was so mad at her and she knew she was being irrational but she couldn't stop the thought running through her head as she continued to stare at the ceiling.

Then Catra was there at the door. Adora sat up, surprised, as she said, “What are you doing here!? I thought you couldn’t make it until Tuesday!”

“Yeah, about that,” Catra said and Adora wondered why she couldn’t meet her eyes. “I just… it was really shitty of me to say I couldn’t make it. I shouldn’t string you along. I found someone else.”

Adora couldn’t move. She wanted to scream. She wanted to cry and then when she saw a blonde haired woman step up and take Catra’s arm and give her a kiss, she wanted to kill.

Adora started awake, breathing heavily, as she looked around and realized she’d been dreaming.

“Brain, seriously?” Adora muttered as she ground the heels of her hands into her eyes.

Then she went still as she heard a low angry voice outside. She very carefully slid up to the window, peaking over the edge to look through the bug screen to see Spinne and Tossa standing at the foot of the staircase up to their cabin next door. Spinne was shaking her head angrily as she said something Adora couldn’t quite understand but it was obvious they were having an argument. Spinne’s hands were moving back and forth as she argued right back and Tossa scoffed and started up the stairs.

“Are you really just going to walk away?” Spinne said loudly enough for Adora to hear.

“No, I’m going inside,” Tossa responded. “You can stand there being pissy or you know, follow like an adult.”

Spinne stomped up the staircase as Tossa turned and went inside. Adora heard the screen door to their cabin open and then slam shut. She couldn’t see them in the cabin even though their shutters were open and the only thing in the windows were bug screens to allow breezes through but she could hear a voice raised in anger every once in a while.

Adora slid back onto her bunk and curled up as tears ran down her face. She hadn’t realized until that minute just how much Spinne and Tossa being together and happy had meant to her and to see even them fighting sent her into a tailspin. She pulled her stuffed horse to her and rocked back and forth on her bunk as she fought to keep her crying quiet.

An hour later, Adora heard someone coming up the stairs to her cabin. She hadn’t heard the arguing from next door for probably about thirty minutes but she hadn’t bothered to move. She wondered who was coming in but didn’t bother to roll over when she heard Glimmer.

“There you are!” Glimmer shouted as she walked in. “You said you’d catch up with us! You could have said you were going to take a nap.”

Adora was wiping at her eyes where Glimmer couldn't see before she sat up, putting her stuffed horse on her Bible.

"Sorry, I guess I was more worn out than I thought," Adora said with a plastered on smile.

"You alright?" Glimmer said as she got closer. "Your eyes look red and puffy."

"Allergies," Adora said with a shrug.

"Bullshit," Glimmer said. "You've never mentioned allergies before. Have you been crying?"

"I'm fine, really," Adora said as she got up. She leaned over to put on her boots and so Glimmer couldn't get a look at her face.

"Again, I say bull," Glimmer said as she moved around against the back wall so she could see Adora's face. "You've been kind of off today. I didn't think anything of it but I come in here and see you curled up on your bunk hugging your horse? Somethings wrong."

"I'm just, I don't know," Adora said and tried to think of something to say. "I'm homesick, I guess."

“Adora, what home?” Glimmer said and then instantly regretted saying that as Adora glared at her. “Shit, I’m sorry. I… I should have said that better.”

“Yeah, thanks for reminding me of what I’ve lost, I had almost forgotten for a few minutes,” Adora said.

“That’s not what I meant,” Glimmer said. “I meant… damn it, I’m not going to try and say it now, you’re already pissed at me.”

“Don’t try and cheer me up anymore,” Adora said as she stood up and stomped out of the cabin. She barely noticed Bow say hello to her as she blew past him and towards the woods. Glimmer came out onto the raised deck with a sigh as Bow came up.

“What happened?” Bow said.

“She’s upset about something and I screwed up and made it worse,” Glimmer said as she fought to keep the tears in her eyes. “I think she hates me now.”

Bow pulled her close and hugged her as he said, “She doesn’t hate you, she’s just having a hard time.”

“I know,” Glimmer said, her voice muffled from where it was tucked into Bow’s shoulder. “She still hates me.”

“We’ll talk to her when we see her for dinner in a little bit,” Bow said. “I’m sure she’ll be calmed down by then.”

Normally, Bow would be right. Adora calmed down fairly quickly normally but this time, she didn’t. When dinner came, the small group of counselors were in the dining hall passing around a big pot full of spaghetti and a bowl of salad when Adora came in about ten minutes late.

“There you are,” Mista said. “Bow was going to eat your portion but I told him to lay off.”

“I wasn’t going to do any such thing,” Bow said as Adora went to the table, grabbed a bowl, a napkin, and a fork. Then she filled the bowl with spaghetti and left the building. Everyone went silent as they watched her walk across the main camp area towards the arts and crafts pavilion where she sat down by herself. She bowed her head for a moment and then started to eat.

“What the hell was that?” Kevin said.

“I, um, kind of pissed her off earlier,” Glimmer said.

“Her?” Mista said. “She’s the sweetest person I’ve ever met. What did you do? Insult Catra? That’s the only thing I can think of that’d piss her off this bad.”

Bow had his arm around Glimmer as she stared at the table and answered.

“She had been crying and when I was trying to find out what was up, she said she was homesick. Then I kind of accidentally, you know, um… said she didn’t have a home.”

The table was silent for a moment again before Kevin said, “That’s fucked up, Glimmer.”

“That’s not what I meant,” Glimmer hissed. “I was trying to ask her what she meant. Like, was she sad she wasn’t in the trailer? Was she missing school or something? I didn’t word it right, OK!?”

Tossa said, “It’s obvious she’s missing Catra and not doing well about it. She told me this morning that she won’t be here tomorrow and won’t get in until Tuesday.”

“But, they’ve been apart for a while,” Glimmer said and then sighed as she heard herself. “I shouldn’t speak.”

“We just need to let her calm down a little,” Bow said as everyone once again glanced at Adora industriously eating through her

bowl.

"I shall go and speak with her," Sea Hawk said as he stood from the table. "I'll bring her some merriment and take her mind off her misery."

Mista rolled her eyes as she reached up and pulled Sea Hawk back into his seat as she said, "Obviously someone needs to go and speak with her but it's got to be someone with tact."

"So you're out then," Spinne said.

"I am full of tact," Mista said.

"You're full of crap," Kevin replied.

"You want to go and talk to her then?" Mista said.

"Yeah, I will," Kevin said as he stood up.

"Someone pull him down," Glimmer said with a sigh. Spinne touched his arm and Kevin sat back down. "Thanks, Spinne. OK, we gotta pick the person who's best suited to talk to her so we don't make it worse."

“Agreed,” Bow said. “Does anyone have any suggestions?”

The whole room went quiet.

“Why is everyone staring at me?” Bow said.

“Seriously?” Tossa said. “You were her first friend here from what I’ve heard for one.”

Kevin was nodding as he said, “You’re the one I’d go to for anything. You’re a good listener.”

Spinne said, “Bow, you’ve got a kind heart. You’re definitely who I’d pick.”

Bow was shaking his head as he said, “No, come on, any of us can do this. I’m not anything special.”

Glimmer had her hand propped on the table and was leaning into it with a grin on her face as she said, “You really don’t see it do you?”

Bow was about to ask sea what when Sea Hawk struck the table with the flat of his hand, rattling the dishes, as he said, “It’s decided! Friend Bow, you shall go and speak with her and soothe her troubled mind!”

“OK, OK, keep it down,” Bow said, making hush gestures as he glanced over his shoulder to see if Adora had noticed. “I’ll go talk to her.”

Bow stood up from the table while everyone softly tapped the table and quietly chanted, “Bow, Bow, Bow.”

“Hush!” Bow whispered urgently as he went out the door.

Adora had finished her bowl and was just sitting at the table feeling sorry for herself. She knew she needed to take the bowl back to wash, and it was her night to do the dishes, but she just couldn’t bring herself to get up and go see everyone. She could already remember how they’d looked at her when she’d come in to get her bowl, like she was a loser, and she couldn’t face that right at the moment.

“Adora?”

“Go away, Bow,” Adora said, not turning around.

Bow walked over and stood at the end of the table where Adora was sitting.

"Can I sit down?"

Adora looked at him before looking away. Bow caught a glimpse of her swollen eyes and felt his heart break for her.

"I guess," she said.

Bow sat down next to her and tried to think of what to say. He glanced sideways and saw everyone in the dining hall watching him.

"I know you're upset about something," Bow said. "You want to tell me?"

"No," Adora said.

"Why not?" Bow said. "You know you can tell me anything."

Adora looked at him again as she said, "It's just… forget about it."

Bow nodded as he said, “It’s alright. You don’t want to say, I’m not going to push. You mind if I hug you?”

Adora started to say something but couldn’t get it out as a lump formed in her throat and she just nodded.

“That a yes?” Bow said and she nodded again.

Bow wrapped her up in his arms and hugged her tight. Adora had meant for him to just hug her and let it go but she suddenly turned to him and wrapped her arms around him as she buried her face and started crying.

“It’s going to be OK,” Bow said.

“No, it’s not,” Adora said through her crying. “Catra is going to leave me.”

Bow heard her muffled response and said, “What did she say?”

“She didn’t say anything,” Adora said. “I just know she is. She’s got someone else already.”

Bow hugged her a little tighter as the last part came out almost as a wail. He looked up to see Micah and Angella standing stock still

as they came into the main camp on their evening walk. He very slowly shook his head and they nodded and started towards the dining hall instead.

"Did she say that?" Bow said.

"No," Adora said and then her voice went bitter as she went on. "But I've heard that little… I've heard her in the background."

Bow marveled for a moment how Adora could avoid cursing even when she was in misery as he said, "You sure? It's not like Catra has her own place."

Adora pushed back as she said, "I'm not an idiot. This might be my first real relationship but I'm not an idiot."

"No, you're not an idiot," Bow said. "No one thinks that."

"Then you know I'm right," Adora said, the sentence starting out stubborn but ending dejected she sagged on the stool.

Bow took her hands as he said, "No, I just think you're off on this. Look at me please." Adora looked up at him as he gave a little squeeze of her hands. "I'm not saying it's not possible but I'd be shocked if it was. Catra loves you. She's stupid for you. When I picked her up for winter break to come surprise you, she wouldn't stop talking about you for half the ride. When she's around you

she's lit up from the inside, so are you. I bet being away from you is killing her just as much as it seems to be doing to you." Bow touched Adora's hand and ran his finger over the iron ring that Catra had made for Adora. "Look what she gave you. I know it's hard. When I'm away from Glimmer it hurts like a shattered bone. That's just where we are in our lives right now though. I don't know if it's forever, for either of our relationships, but I know if I want it to be, and I do, then we have to go through this. Do you?"

Adora looked down as she nodded and said, "I do. I just… I don't think I'm wrong."

"She's going to be here soon, right?" Bow said.

"Tuesday," Adora said.

"You going to talk to her before then?" Bow said.

"Maybe on Monday," Adora said. "She's working until then and won't have time to talk. Or you know, being with *her."*

"Nope, don't do that," Bow said as he saw Adora get angry. "If she really is with someone then we'll find out but we can't know, so let's not do that, OK?"

Adora nodded as she let go of his hand to wipe away her tears.

“OK, I’ll try,” Adora said.

“You love her right?” Bow said.

“Of course,” Adora replied.

“Then you have to trust her,” Bow said. “Have faith in her.”

Adora looked up at him and gave a sudden chuckle that faded off just as fast but the sorrow had faded a little from her eyes.

“Faith. Yeah, I know faith,” Adora said.

“I know you do,” Bow said. “Come on, let's take your bowl to the wash. We got cinnamon apples for dessert.”

Adora turned red as she said, “No. Just have everyone put their stuff in the kitchen and I’ll clean up when they’ve left.”

“Why?” Bow said.

“Because they probably all think I’m some childish idiot,” Adora said.

“No one thinks anything like that,” Bow said. “They’re all worried about you is all. Come on… cinnamon apples… I know you love them”

Adora snorted a little as she wiped at her eyes again as she said, “I love any dessert and you know that.”

“Adora, I’ve never seen you not eat something,” Bow said. “I’m not sure if there is a food you don’t like.”

Adora sat there for a moment and Bow was trying to think of what to say when she said, “Cloves.”

“What?” Bow said.

“I don’t like cloves in stuff,” Adora said. “I mean, if it’s mixed with a bunch of spices it’s fine but by itself it’s gross.”

“Noted,” Bow said. “This just has stewed apples and red hot candy. Come on. Have dessert with us. No one is going to bother you, I promise.”

Adora finally sighed and nodded as she leaned forward and hugged Bow again.

"Thank you," Adora said. "It really was a blessing running into you out in the woods last summer."

"The blessing is all mine," Bow said.

Chapter End Notes

The verse in Leviticus I referenced is the infamous Leviticus 18:22. If you don't know it, be happy. I'm not repeating it.

Also, credit to The Amazing Devil and songs from The Horror and The Wild to really set the writing mood of this chapter.

Want cinnamon apples? It's a really simple recipe I used to make as a Scout and we won a couple of dessert competitions with it. Warning, it's sticky as hell.

Get some apples, any kind you like and a bag of cinnamon red hots. We never used Granny Smith but I have a feeling it'd really work in this. Core and chop them into slices (an apple slicer works wonders here). You can go one step further and get them into chunks but don't go too small. This isn't applesauce. Line them in an oven safe pot. You can put down foil if you want but if you don't, be aware, it can be a pain in the ass to get cleaned if you let it cool. Now sprinkle a good layer of red hots over everything and put a little bit of water in the bottom (just enough to keep the apples from scorching). Put as many layers as you want, then bake in a 300° F oven for about twenty to thirty minutes (check it about fifteen minutes in, the candy should be melted and the apples soft). What's going to happen is your apples will soften

up and the red hots are going to melt everywhere and imbue them with that sugary cinnamon goodness. Spoon, eat. That’s it. I’ve seen the same with actual sugar and cinnamon but I’ve never tried it so I can’t comment on the difference. I think you could really fancy this up that way and use a blowtorch to give it a crunchy sugar top kinda like creme brulee.

Also, I just wrote the last chapter of Illusions. It's done. Almost fourteen months of writing and it's done. I'm honestly kind of shocked. I just kind of wanted to mention it.

Thank you for reading!

Staff Day

Chapter Summary

Adora wakes up bright and early on the day the rest of the staff is set to arrive at Camp Bright Moon.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora woke up before the Sun the next day. Mista was sprawled out across her bunk with an arm across her face as she slept, the only other person staying in the cabin with Glimmer staying in her room at her parent's house for the moment. Bow and Kevin shared the cabin across the little courtyard from them and she knew they weren't up and moving yet. No one ever was this early on a Sunday. Adora pulled a small stool she'd found out from under her bed and sat it in front of her nightstand. She turned on the tiny little solar powered book light she'd bought and pulled her Bible down.

When she'd been living on campus, she'd tried to go to one of the non-denominational services that went on around campus. She'd originally tried to go every Sunday but after about a month and a half, she found she was completely out of place. Simple questions like, "So where's your home church?" got complicated quickly in her case. She lied and named her old church but her church wasn't small and she was way too nervous to keep doing that for fear that someone would be from there or know someone from there.

The sermons had been awkward as well. The pastor had tailored it to the crowd, a bunch of students living on their own for the first time, and so it was full of preaching against avoiding liquor and drugs and sexual immorality. The pastor seemed to really hit on the part about same sex immorality and Adora felt like every time it came up, way more than it ever had back at her old church she thought, the pastor was staring right at her.

However, she hadn't wanted to stop studying, especially since she was beginning to think she wanted to major in religion somehow, and so she'd set up a Bible study and prayer routine on Sunday mornings for herself. She'd spend a few minutes praying, about fifteen minutes or so reading the chapter she'd selected for herself, and then write about what she thought of it in her journal as well as writing down questions she had that she wanted to try and research. Then she'd close with another prayer.

This morning though, she got through the prayer and was beginning to read Lamentations, because she always felt like she didn't have much experience with the back half of the Old Testament, when she came to a stop. At first she thought it might be the reading itself. She knew that it was a lament for the destruction of Jerusalem and thought maybe it was too depressing for her state of mind but that didn't seem to be it. It wasn't that she was sad, although she was, it was that she just didn't feel like reading.

She stared at her Bible. She'd always been told that not being attentive to the Bible was the Devil trying to distract her but at the moment, she doubted the Devil needed to pay much attention to her if what she'd heard her whole life was true. She finally shut off her light and put her Bible up before quietly getting dressed and heading out the door. She carefully shut the screen door

behind her, giving a quick glance at Spinne and Tossa's cabin, wondering if they had settled their argument from the day before before heading out towards the rest of the camp.

As she went, she passed the bathhouse and then the next set of cabins, Raccoon's Folly. She had no idea why it had been called that and had never thought to ask but the little trail that went off the small road she was following had a wooden sign with the name of the cabins and a carved raccoon face on it. She walked out on the sports field, mostly just an empty grassy field that was pretty flat and had a storage shed at one end for stuff, and stared up at the stars that were fading from the sky as a herald of the coming sunrise.

Adora's feet carried her towards the docks and she soon found herself on the embankment above the docks. The grass was damp from the morning dew but she didn't care about it as she sat down. Across the river was Camp Horde for the Lord and the enormous cross that had been built there since she'd left the camp. Staring at it, not lit up for once, she wondered what was going on there right at the moment. The staff for the camp would have arrived already and would have been doing similar things to what Adora and her friends had recently done for Camp Bright Moon. She thought about the times she'd walked along the high bluff that Camp Horde for the Lord sat on and looked across to the docks at Bright Moon and seen people there and wondered what they were like and what they had been doing. Now she was doing the same in reverse.

She wondered what her life would have been if she'd never chosen Catra, if she'd just been meek and quiet and gone along with what Joshua, the head of the old camp, had told her to do. She'd have finished out the summer and then gone to her first

year at the college she had a full scholarship at, a Christian university. After that she'd have come home to her mother's house where her mother would have said how proud of her she was, Adora thought, but still nitpicked any grades she felt weren't up to snuff before commenting on Adora's appearance in some way. Then she'd have gone back to Camp Horde for the Lord, as head counselor again more than likely, and worked to show more kids the way of God as she thought of it. And she still would have stood on the bluff, looked across the river, and wondered what it was like, all while doubting herself the whole time and trying to ignore the little voice in her head that said, "Liar, liar, liar, liar."

For a moment, she felt like she slipped into another timeline and she was there, looking across at an empty dock at Camp Bright Moon and trying to convince herself she was something other than what she was and it tasted like ash in her mouth. She was shaken out of her thoughts when the Sun rose over the cliff and she closed her eyes with a smile as it warmed her face. Unbidden, a memory came back, sharp and clear, of standing at the campfire ring at Camp Bright Moon after spending all night in contemplation on the winter solstice. The Sun had come up and the warmth of it was a distinct memory from the sharp cold of the night and she remembered the deep peace she'd experienced then and felt it settle on her again. Catra might not be there, she might not know what life would bring coming forward, but she felt at peace. She could figure it out.

She opened her eyes to see someone standing on the bluff, looking at her. Adora couldn't make out a face and wondered if it was someone she knew. The person just stood there, looking across the river, and after a moment Adora did what she felt right. She raised her hand and waved at the person.

The other person hesitated for a moment before raising their hand and waving back before suddenly turning and leaving.

"God bless you," Adora whispered to the figure as it walked out of sight.

She turned up late to breakfast, and could feel the curious eyes on her since she was normally never late to meals and this was the second time in a row, and grinned as she sat down at the table by Glimmer as she said, "I'm fine. I was just sitting down by the dock watching the river go past."

"That's an excellent song," Sea Hawk said.

"Huh?" Adora siad.

"Dock of the Bay, Otis Redding?" Sea Hawk said and Adora just shrugged as she took a plate and started putting scrambled eggs on it. "You don't know it!? Blasphemy! We shall have to introduce it to you! It is a classic and all should know it and I swear with all the strength of my body that I shall make that happen, starting with you!"

"Sea Haw, if you don't calm down, I'm going to ban you from the dining hall during breakfast hours," Glimmer muttered as she drank a cup of coffee. "It's too early for this."

“We should have a music party tonight,” Sea Hawk said. “We can hook a radio up at the arts and crafts pavilion. I shall bring my book of CD’s! I have lots of excellent music burned and ready for listening!”

“That’s not a bad idea,” Bow replied.

“This is a terrible idea,” Mista said. “It will be wall-to-wall shanties.”

“No such thing, my darling, I promise you,” Sea Hawk responded. “It will be to edify Adora in fine music and bring us together in fellowship.”

“I gotta say, it doesn’t sound awful,” Tossa said. “And the rest of the staff should be showing up today. It’d be a good welcome back thing.”

Spinne pointed at Tossa as she said, “That’s right! That is today!”

“You all forgot, didn’t you?” Bow said with a smile as he bit into some toast.

“No!” came back from several different people.

“I know Bow didn’t,” Kevin said. “Since he and I are driving the bus and all to pick some of them up.”

Bow grinned as he gave a little salute to Kevin with his toast.

“Well that and he spends a lot of time in private conference with our illustrious leader,” Mista said as she waggled her eyebrows at Glimmer as she brought up her mug of coffee.

Adora blushed as Glimmer scratched at her eye with her middle finger and took a bite of her sausage.

“Alright, it looks like we’re all attending Sea Hawk’s Camp Bright Moon Music Appreciation Evening,” Glimmer said with a yawn as Sea Hawk pumped his fist. “I expect signage.”

“You shall have it!” Sea Hawk pronounced. “Mista? Shall I have your help?”

“I guess,” Mista responded as she took his hand.

“Alright, one last thing,” Glimmer said. “We all have our little nicknames around here and I think it’s a shame that Adora doesn’t have one yet. Try and think of something.”

“You’re trying to force a nickname again?” Spinne said.

“I’m not trying to force it!” Glimmer said.

“She’s trying to force it,” Bow responded with a wink.

“I’ll take no betrayal from you,” Glimmer said.

“And you’re getting none. Just the truth,” Bow said.

“You really don’t have to do it,” Adora said. “I’m fine with my name as it is.”

“It’s not something that we choose to do, no matter how much Glimmer wills it,” Tossa replied. “It just sort of happens.”

“You make it sound like a natural disaster,” Kevin said.

“Hey, it can be,” Mista said. “They tried to call me Bass.”

“As in the fish?” Adora said.

“As in the fish,” Mista said. “I might have almost accepted it if it had been Catfish. That has potential at least.”

“I don’t want to know,” Bow replied.

Mista gave a little grin before she settled back down.

The rest of breakfast went quickly. Adora went with Mista to the office to go over some invoices that had come in while Bow and Kevin hopped on The Purple Elephant, the camp’s repainted school bus, and headed towards Rogers to pick up the members of staff who had rode in to the small bus station there. Glimmer was standing outside the office as other staff started trickling in, dropped off or parking their cars in a small lot up by the road. Adora could hear the greetings as she worked.

“Carl, good to see you.”

“Necktie! Figured you’d be hiding from us this year!”

“Wasp, it’s about time you got here. Don’t worry, we didn’t do all the work yet, plenty left.”

“Jean, babe, it’s been too long. Can’t wait to see what you got for dance this year.”

“Cookie! You are a sight for sore eyes. No, your kitchen is still in one piece despite our best efforts.”

And so on, all of them as warm as the first. Adora could hear the conversation getting louder and she looked out the window to see a motley group sitting around outside with all manners of luggage.

“You never realize how many there are of us until you see them all in one place,” Mista said.

“No kidding,” Adora said.

Mista slid the last of the invoices into a folder and slapped it down into the filing cabinet.

“There’s enough there for Micah to cut checks,” Mista said. “Let’s go see our fellow reprobates.”

Adora laughed a little as she went out with Mista. Glimmer was sitting at a little folding table with a box full of files sitting next to her helping someone get checked in. The crowd of thirty or so people all looked up and cries of, “Mista!” and “Adora!” along with greetings echoed up at them as they came down the steps.

“Yeah, yeah, you love to see me,” Mista said as she exchanged an elaborate handshake with a woman in a huge droopy hat.

Adora found herself dumbstruck as she just gave a wave. She knew most of the people by sight but she couldn't believe any of them would remember her. As she thought of it after all, it was just her, why would they?

Glimmer stepped onto the steps as Mista and Adora mingled into the group and found a place to sit. She let loose a piercing whistle with her fingers and everyone turned to her.

“Let’s talk lodging and other details!” Glimmer said.

“Hey, could you stand up!?” someone shouted from the crowd to a round of laughs

“Thank you, Label, I didn’t think I’d get a volunteer for bathhouse cleaning so early in the season,” Glimmer said to another round of laughs. “Alright, as usual cabin staff will be with their assigned cabins. Program staff, you’re not at Hideaway this year, you’re all going to be out at Cottonwood Cove.” She was met with a smattering of boos and she made a hurry it up motion with her hand as it died down. “Yeah, yeah, but the advanced staff has been out there and I think you’ll find they haven’t had any problems. Right?”

Glimmer looked at Mista and Adora, the only two of that group who were there at the moment, who nodded.

“It’s nice,” Adora said.

“It’s at least quiet and the cabin staff are too weak to hike out and bother us,” Mista said which led to some heckling.

“OK, OK,” Glimmer said. “You should already have your assignments from the letters we sent out but since that was a while back and all of us are so renowned for our paperwork retention, I assume some of you may have lost it. We’ll go over all of that this evening when we get together for our mandatory staff meeting at the arts and crafts pavilion followed by the voluntary party that we’re calling Sea Hawk’s Camp Bright Moon Music Appreciation Evening.”

“What in the hell is that!?” someone shouted while someone else hollered about sea shanties.

“Sea Hawk has assured us it’s not to be shanties but he’s going to play a selection of music for us to hang out to and get to know each other,” Glimmer said. “Those of you who are new here, don’t listen to the old timers about him. He’s a great guy.”

“Just don’t encourage his shanty obsession,” Mista said.

“And that’s from his girlfriend folks,” Cookie said.

“Yes, thank you,” Glimmer said. “That’s all I have for now. For those who don’t mind, go ahead and hoof it on out to Cottonwood Cove. Otherwise, Dad should be here shortly with a UTV and trailer to start hauling people and luggage. I’m going to grab the other one. See you all at lunch, twelve as always.”

The group started breaking up, some of them hoisting luggage and starting off towards the cabins and some stretching out to wait for a ride. Adora found herself talking with a few people, even laughing, and felt less alone than she had in the prior few days. At least until someone asked about Catra.

“Whatever happened with you and that woman you were bunking with last year?” Necktie asked.

Adora plastered on a smile as she responded to her.

“We’re still seeing each other. Remember how she worked the horse barn? She made friends with the horseshoe guy. She travels now with him. We’re trying to save for a place of our own if we can.”

Adora didn’t know what a place of their own would be like or where it would be but the phrase had been something her and Catra had both said over the prior months. A place of their own, it was like a magic phrase. Anytime it got mentioned between them both it often brought

a shiver to Adora’s spine. Somewhere they could be together, some place that was just for the two of them to be together but

at the moment it felt like the far future that would never show up.

"Ah, that's cool," Necktie said as she adjusted the piece of clothing that gave her the nickname. It sat on top of a t-shirt and Adora had never asked why but the bulky woman made it work. "She going to work here this summer?"

Adora shook her head as she swallowed to get the lump out of her throat as she said, "She'll come through to shoe horses with the guy she's learning from but other than that, she can make better cash on the road."

Necktie clapped her on the upper arm as she said, "Ah, don't worry about it. Things work out like they're supposed to." Micah was pulling up as Necktie picked up a couple of suitcases. "Hey, catch you over at the Cove. Good to see you again!"

Adora waved at her as she trotted over to be first in line to go and Adora found that she couldn't quite talk to anyone else and retired into the office to get some more stuff done.

Chapter End Notes

Not much to say here except I enjoyed coming up with names for the various staff. Hope you're enjoying the story!

Music Appreciation Night

Chapter Summary

It's time for Sea Hawk's Camp Bright Moon Music Appreciation Evening and Adora is in for a surprise.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

To everyone's surprise, Sea Hawk's Camp Bright Moon Music Appreciation Evening went amazingly well. There was a sign, hand painted on poster board, with a boat and the name of the event taped to a pole. The stereo he set up was like something from another time, a huge box the size of a suitcase with detachable speakers that looked like it had seen better days. It was covered in stickers, from bands but also just random places, sayings, and images, and duct tape. Looking at the thing, the duct tape had writing on it and it was obvious that it served the same purpose as the stickers while the stickers also served the same purpose as the duct tape. Sitting next to it were two large CD wallets, the wallets themselves covered in stickers as well.

When people started arriving there was a soft synthesizer song going. At the appointed time, with sunlight streaming in low through the trees, Sea Hawk stood up on a bench and began to speak.

"Greetings, one and all! Tonight I shall entertain and edify you with the finest of musical selections! We shall cover all ranges and genres, all styles and modes, and if, at the end, you do not walk

away with a smile, I promise you shall walk away with a tune in your heart!”

As promised, he avoided shanties and simply went through what turned out to be an amazingly diverse selection of CD’s, announcing each choice and in a few cases giving background on them. There was some weird experimental stuff that got everyone wondering what in the world was up with it but he kept it to a minimum. People sat around on the tables, chairs, and the floor and a small space was cleared in the middle of the floor when Perfuma, who’d arrived with The Purple Elephant, started to dance, drawing in several others.

Adora, who’d walked in moping, found herself drawn in pretty quickly. She’d grown up listening to praise and worship music with exposure to very little secular music and the whole evening was eye opening. A lot of the songs got people singing along to them and she used a trick she’d learned as a kid of how to sing along even if she didn’t know the words. Sea Hawk played Dock of the Bay as the third song, even announcing it was for Adora who’d inspired the evening, and she had to admit, after she finished blushing at everyone paying attention to her, it was a good song. She knew she’d find herself humming it when she was down at the dock.

“I can’t believe you don’t know these,” Glimmer said at one point as Adora heard another song that everyone else seemed to know but Adora didn’t.

“Hey, I can sing you under the table with hymns,” Adora said.

“Different experiences,” Bow said as he hugged Glimmer.

“I know, I know but it just seems so prevalent, you know?” Glimmer said.

“It’s like they say, ‘Love not the world, neither the things that are in the world.’ My upbringing was serious about that,” Adora said.

“That sounds f’d up,” Spinne said.

Adora shrugged as she said, “It had its moments.”

Sea Hawk started up another song that started off with lyrics about praying and being tucked in, although since the guy singing it didn’t seem to be singing a sweet lullaby and was more on the growl end of the singing spectrum, Adora was pretty sure it wasn’t meant to be comforting.

“Can he play something from this decade?” Glimmer said.

“Doubtful,” Tossa said right before singing along with the chorus. “What? Me and my dad used to sing this together.”

The next song was a man singing about how he’d been looking so long at the pictures of you and how he felt like they were almost

real. Adora thought it was well sung but it was sad and not the kind of song she needed to be hearing at that moment. She was happy when Sea Hawk went with something way more upbeat for the followup song.

Later, after the sun had gone down, the evening began to wrap up as people, tired from travel, settling in, and work, started to drift off. Sea Hawk, in a display of social awareness, announced he'd be wrapping it up but he had one last song to see them off.

Adora was sitting against a pole, tired but feeling mellow, when the music started. A soft guitar and simple drum riff set the tone, soothing and quiet. Adora found herself bobbing her head a little as the singer came in, his voice mellow and calm.

"When you were here before…"

Adora heard a few people start quietly singing along.

"Couldn't look you in the eye…"

Adora found herself sitting up a little straighter.

"You're just like an angel, your skin makes me cry…"

More people were joining in and Adora heard Bow beginning to sing as well.

"You float like a feather, in a beautiful world…"

Adora found herself closing her eyes, listening close to the words as the Sea Hawk turned the song up just a little. Not enough to drown anyone out, just enough that the singer of the song and the singers in the crowd seemed to meld together.

"I wish I was special…"

Adora felt goosebumps run up her arms.

"You're so fuckin' special…"

Tears were in Adora's eyes. Then sudden heavy guitar riffs rang out as the singer's voice ramped up and everyone in the crowd sang the chorus loud and proud.

"But I'm a creep, I'm a weirdo, what the hell am I doing here? I don't belong here!"

Adora felt Glimmer and Bow's arms go around her from either side as they both sang. The next verse was about wanting to be

perfect, to be noticed, how the person that was being sung to was special, and damn it, why wasn't the singer? Adora thought of Catra, she thought of how she didn't feel like she belonged anywhere, and she felt like this song screamed that back at her, that the song was written just for her and how she felt at that moment.

She could hear the others singing it around her and it was the loneliest song Adora thought she'd ever heard. The others sang it that way but at the same time, they seemed to sing it as an anthem of who they were. Weirdos, creeps, freaks, they all knew how they felt and how they felt others might see them but it didn't matter. No one would ever know them the way they knew themselves but at the same time, they were united together in this singular moment. Adora felt like there was a spark leaping between everyone and as the chorus came up again, she sang it with the rest, as loud as she could and the rest of the crowd rose to meet her volume, as she put her arms around Bow and Glimmer and for that moment, everything was going to be alright.

The song ended with one last plaintive, "I don't belong here," the crowd singing it with an ache that pulled out like every last goodbye in the history of the world. Everyone went silent as Sea Hawk's CD player stopped and for a brief moment, it was a perfect moment, frozen in time.

Nothing lasts though. Someone shifted a little, someone else let out a sigh of contentment, and then others started to move and the moment was gone, the lost moment ringing in their ears like the silence after loud bells.

"I think you liked that one," Glimmer said as she hugged Adora's shoulder.

"That was *beautiful,"* Adora said, letting out a breath she hadn't realized she'd been holding as she did.

"Yeah, the goosebumps really give it away," Glimmer said, nodding at Adora's arms.

Adora laughed a little as she rubbed at her arms as Sea Hawk came by.

"I hope you found some things you enjoyed," he said with a smile. Adora stood up and surprised him by wrapping him up in a hug.

"I did," Adora said. "Thank you so much for that."

Sea Hawk's face was surprised but his smile was warm as he hugged her back with, for once, nothing to say.

Adora walked along with a smile on her face as they left the arts and crafts pavilion. The lights in the camp were off for the moment and there were a few flashlights strung out in front of them but most of the counselors were navigating by the light of the stars and moon. Adora found herself with her head thrown back most of the time, looking at the stars blazing bright overhead. She could feel the air cooling off as they got close to

the river, a little bit of damp in the air like a soft kiss on the cheek, and she spread her arms wide to do a little twirl in the path.

"Glad to see you in a better mood," Bow said.

"I'm sorry if I've been a pain," Adora said.

"It's alright," Glimmer said. "You've been there for both of us before."

"I know," Adora said as she put her arms around her friends. "Thank you though."

Bow hugged her around her shoulders as they walked and asked, "So, other than the last song, which was your favorite tonight?"

"She's going to say Stairway," Glimmer said.

"Was that the really long one that sounded kind of medievally?" Adora said. "Stairway to Heaven?"

"Yep," Glimmer said.

“No, that wasn’t my favorite,” Adora said, putting on an affronted appearance. “Just because it has heaven in the title doesn’t mean it’s my favorite. For what it’s worth, I don’t know which one I liked the most. They were all pretty great.”

“Safe answer,” Bow said with a laugh. “And as much as I enjoyed that, Sea Hawk has the taste of my middle aged uncle. We’ll have to introduce you to stuff from the last couple years.”

“Or at least the last decade,” Glimmer said.

“I don’t care,” Adora said with another twirl. “I loved it.”

As they got close to the cabins, they could hear people talking and see the glow of a campfire. Soon they could see the kerosene lanterns that lit the cabins inside as well as a few smaller battery powered lights people had sitting on the nightstands as they got settled in.

“Glad I claimed my bunk already,” Glimmer said.

“You sure you want to stay out here?” Bow said.

“Yeah, I need to get used to it again,” Glimmer said. “Besides, it’s good to be with the troops as it were.”

“I noticed it wasn’t good until now,” Bow said with a laugh.

“Yep, but honestly, I did want to spend some time with Mom and Dad before camp got rolling,” Glimmer said.

“I’m glad you’ll be bunking with me,” Adora said. “At least until your cabin shows up.”

“Actually, Mom and Dad said I won’t be in charge of a cabin this year,” Glimmer said. “I’m head counselor, I shouldn’t be tied down they said.”

“I mean, it makes sense,” Bow said. “You had to keep swapping out duties last year to get stuff done.”

“Although if I hadn’t,” Glimmer said, “never would have run into this one out in the woods.”

“Yeah, but you looked like you wanted to murder me the first time you met me,” Adora replied.

“Hey, we’ve been over this. Hitting you with a rock is not the same as murder,” Glimmer said.

“I do not want to hear your justification on that one again,” Adora said with a laugh.

“Because you know I’m right,” Glimmer said.

“Said Cain to God,” Bow said.

That one caused Adora to whoop with laughter, drawing looks from the others as they walked into the little courtyard area between the cabins.

“Someone’s in a good mood,” Wasp said from the fire.

“Aren’t we all?” Glimmer said to a general shouts of agreement. “I’m headed for bed. Try and keep it down and don’t forget, bright and early. I haven’t flipped anyone out of bed this season yet but I’m looking forward to it.”

“I’ll walk you to your door,” Bow said.

“How courteous, my good sir,” Glimmer said.

Adora laughed as Glimmer held her arm out with a little bow and Bow took it and the two began to walk in a slow, exaggerated manner.

“I’ll see you inside,” Adora said as she went on in. Every bunk was full of someone now, Glimmer having claimed a bunk by Adora’s and she said hellos as she went along the row. Mista was starting up a card game with a few people on a little table by the door and the rest were sitting talking or stretched out on their beds.

“I’m going to go to sleep in a few,” Adora said. “Can we kill the lantern?”

Someone said they would and carefully lowered it down by the cable mechanism that kept it above the floor and blew it out. The room went a bit darker, aside from the soft pools of light coming from the few nightstands with lights on them and the little oil lamp at the front table. Adora got changed for bed and as she got under her covers with a contented sigh, she could see shifting shadows from the fire outside casting silhouettes of people on the porch window screens as well as painting the inside in a faint glowing orange. It was to that image that Adora fell asleep, a little smile on her face.

Chapter End Notes

> If you want to know Adora’s trick for singing along, it’s really simple. Now, this only works with a crowd but you basically sing the music (like humming but your mouth is moving) to get the rhythm and pick up the chorus. Then you sing the chorus as best you can as you figure it out (since that repeats). It works pretty well to at least get you involved.
>
> I have to say, I miss those big portable radios. I know you can get better sound out of portable bluetooth speakers but damn, I miss the physicality of them. I also miss physical media, in this case, the giant CD folder. OK, enough old man yelling at clouds, onward.

Sea Hawk shares some of my musical tastes as I too have the musical taste of Bow's middle aged uncle for the most part. Here's the ones I mentioned. The song Sea Hawk is playing as people come in is A Warm Place by Nine Inch Nails. It's on the same album as Closer. It really is a mellow song and I always grin when I think of it because I knew a guy who used to work at a planetarium and he'd play it as the before and after show music. The praying and being tucked in song is Enter Sandman by Metallica. The song afterwards, about the guy looking at pictures, is aptly named Pictures of You by The Cure and yeah, Adora does not need to be listening to it, or pretty much any of The Cure, when she's sad. Although she'd probably love Friday I'm In Love.

As for the song that gave Adora goosebumps, it's Creep by Radiohead if you're not familiar with it. I almost didn't use it at all as I was originally not going to use real songs in this. I was going to rename them and do something different with the lyrics like I did when I changed Veggie Tales to Fruit Fables. However, I know it wouldn't have had the same impact. I wanted that chorus so much and so I went with it. I can 100% see Adora vibing with that song, especially at this moment in her life, and so I needed it in there.

Another Monday

Chapter Summary

Adora tries to keep herself busy as she tries not to think about Catra.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next day was Monday and it was a full day. With almost all of the staff having checked in, the dining hall was full of chatter at breakfast. Adora watched Glimmer pull in on herself as she hunkered over a cup of coffee while trying not to snap at anyone as Bow went from table to table, catching up with people. People were giving Sea Hawk congratulations for the night before and as breakfast started wrapping up, Glimmer went to the tiny raised area at one end of the room that served as a stage.

"Alright, let's get this moving," Glimmer said. "First, Cookie, thank you to you and your staff. We appreciate everything you all do for us."

There was a round of applause while the woman leaned away from the wall she'd been against and gave a little head nod before leaning back.

"Now as for the rest of us, we've still got a lot to prep between now and next Sunday when the first campers show up. Cabins, go over your places, make sure everything is in order. If you have

any issues, usual paperwork on that. Programs, check your areas over as well. Supplies should have already been stocked away but just make sure nothing has been damaged or you're missing anything. Again, usual paperwork if there's issues. The state inspector is supposed to be here sometime this week for the usual. If you see them and they ask you questions, just answer the best you can but don't be a smartass. I don't want to explain to another inspector that no, we don't encourage water moccasins to take up residence under the docks to improve the camper's swimming skills," Glimmer said to a chorus of chuckles. "Remember, if you need help, ask for it. If you have a problem, let's work it out. And if you're not having a good time, well,..."

"We signed up for this," most of the staff said in unison with Glimmer, followed by laughter.

"That's right!" Glimmer said. "Now get going. See you all at lunch."

Adora settled into the office after breakfast. Though she was alone, with the windows open she could hear the comings and goings and didn't feel cut off. Mista had shown her how to do the work the year before and she was on the docks now but Adora still had all the paperwork handled shortly before lunch. Micah came wandering in, covered in dust, about the time Adora was putting away the last of her work. He went straight to the aging orange water cooler that was set up in the corner with a sign on it that said, "Tinkled lately? Drink Some Water!"

After downing a cup of water he let out a contented sigh as he sat down in front of the old desk Adora was behind.

“How much you got left to do?” Micah said.

“I don’t,” Adora said. “I’m glad you’re here, I needed to ask what else I should do.”

“What do you mean you don’t?” Micah said.

Adora felt a little worried as she said, “I went through it all. It’s all either filed or waiting for your review.” Adora pointed at a tray on the desk with some manila folders in it. “That’s for you.”

Micah raised an eyebrow as he picked up one and flipped through it.

“You verified Kitchco’s delivery?” Micah said.

“Yes,” Adora said. “They owe us three bags of onions but everything else was delivered as ordered.”

Micah raised an eyebrow again as he said, “And laundry?”

“Went over the invoice, verified the next pickup, and I think I figured out that extra charge,” Adora said. “I think they applied a

payment late that you'd sent to them on time and charged a late fee and a handling fee. I made a note in the file so you can call them."

"I gotta ask," Micah said with a smile. "Where did you learn all of this?"

"Some from last year but I also took an accounting class as one of my general ed's this semester," Adora said. "I really enjoyed it."

"You know this would have taken Mista way more time," Micah said.

"Did I do something wrong?" Adora said.

Micah laughed as he said, "Nope. I always figured she worked at her own leisurely pace. Which is fine, it suits my pace too but you've got your own as well. I'll get used to it."

"So, um, what do I do now?" Adora said.

"Well, the staff files are a bit wonky and I really should get them in order so I can digitize them sometime, not to mention all my other financial stuff," Micah said. "But that's boring and we have all summer to tackle that so why don't we go outside and see what's going on?"

“I really don’t mind,” Adora said as she stood up. “I can get started on the staff files.”

“Adora, listen, you forget something,” Micah said, holding a hand up to stop her.

Adora grabbed a pad of paper and a pencil off the desk as she said, “What is it? I’ll write it down this time.”

Micah smiled as he stood up and gently took the pad from her hand and set it back on the desk as he said, “You forget that I don’t pay you a ton of money and yes, you’re here to work but you’re working at a summer camp. I expect you to goof off and have fun. So your boss is telling you this, let’s go see what’s going on and maybe scare up some fun in the process.”

“Yes, sir,” Adora said as she sat the pencil down.

Micah chuckled as he said, “I’ve noticed you only call me sir now when you don’t really agree with me.”

Adora hadn’t noticed it but as soon as he said it, she could see the truth in it.

“It’s only with respect,” Adora said as they headed out the door.

“Hey, no worries there,” Micah said.

Adora and Micah walked out to the archery range where Bow had all the equipment out under the awning and sitting on the little tables at each firing station. He looked up and gave a wave as they got close.

“Hello!” Bow said as he set down a longbow that was almost as tall as him.

“Is that the one you had me order?” Micah said.

Bow sat his hand on the gleaming light colored wood as he said, “Yep. I still can’t believe you got this. I’m terrified to know how much this cost you.”

Micah grinned as he picked it up and looked it over for a moment. The maker’s mark, a little hand under a hourglass, was burned into the wood right at the grip with words that read, “Galloway Bois d’Arc 70# @ 26.”

As Micah sat it back down he said, “Well, one of the good things about living out in the country is you meet people who make really cool things. The next cool thing is that you can do favors for each other. In my case, letting a couple of kids come to summer

camp for nothing. On Galloway's side, doing what she was already going to do and make a fine bow for a fine guy."

Bow gave a shy grin as he said, "I still can't believe it's here. I haven't had the chance to shoot it yet."

"You can draw it, right?" Micah said.

Bow kind of gave a sheepish grin as he said, "I think? I mean, seventy pounds with no take up like a compound, that's a lot."

"Ah, you can do it," Micah said. "Come on, let's give it a whirl."

"Alright, let me get the arrows," Bow said as he went into the little storage shed and came back out with a length of PVC pipe full of what were very obviously not the standard Camp Bright Moon arrows.

"You have no idea how happy I am that we have the berm behind the targets," Bow said as he fitted the pipe into a little four legged metal stand that sat low to the ground and held it in place. He started putting on a shooting glove and arm guard.

"Do I want to know why you're saying that?" Adora said.

“These bows,” he said, gesturing at the others with his head as he finished with his gear and gave a little grunt as he strung the bow, “range from fifteen to thirty pounds draw weight. Plenty for the kids. Minimum hunting draw weight for big game is forty pounds.” He took a few of the long arrows out of the pipe and started walking back towards the edge of the clearing and Micah and Adora followed him. “This is almost double that. I could very well shoot this straight through the target.”

“Which is why we’re back here?” Micah said as they stopped by the brush at the back of the little area.

“Which is why we’re back here,” Bow said as he handed the arrows to Adora.

“You know, I don’t mind getting that for you but you gotta at least use it,” Micah said with a grin.

“I will,” Bow said before looking around to make sure no one was in front of him. “Clear on the firing line!”

He looked around again before he nocked the arrow onto the string. It was then Adora noticed that it didn’t have a shelf rest and he had the arrow resting on his hand.

“Uh, Bow, should you be shooting that off your hand?” Adora said.

“Traditional bow,” he replied, as if that explained it, before drawing it back.

Adora had seen Bow shoot before but this was a bit different. It took him a moment to draw it and she actually stepped backwards a bit because the strain seemed like something that a stick of wood couldn’t hold. He held it for just a moment and then let it go, the string making a loud thwack noise as it fired the arrow. A split second letter, they heard it hit the target.

Micah shielded his eyes from the Sun as he said, “I don’t think it went all the way through.”

“Yeah, I can see the fletching sticking out,” Bow said as he windmilled the arm he’d drawn with.

“Is it flush with the target?” Adora said, shielding her own eyes as she looked.

“Let’s go look,” Bow said.

The three walked up to the target and sure enough, the feathers on the back of the arrow were resting up against the target, slightly off center from the bullseye of the target. Micah looked behind it and started laughing.

“I think I see why it didn’t keep going.”

Bow and Adora looked around the back as well and saw the arrow embedded in a 2x4 wood stud that was part of the frame that held up the target.

“Do me a favor,” Micah said.

“Sure,” Bow replied.

“Don’t let a camper fire that thing,” Micah said.

“Yeah, I’d figured that out when I was drawing it,” Bow replied.

“Difficult?” Adora said.

“I’m going to get some muscles this year if I use it enough,” Bow said.

“And I better get some more 2x4’s,” Micah said.

“That seems a prudent course,” Bow said with a laugh.

After a few more shots, in which the other arrows did go through the target, Bow said they might want to buy some sturdier targets as well.

"Yeah, I'll see what we can whip together for you," Micah said. "I'm glad you're enjoying it though."

"I'm going to be sore tomorrow," Bow said. "It's really neat though. Thank you again."

"Hey, you're a great archery teacher, you're a good dude, and you make my daughter happy," Micah said as Bow looked at the ground with a little shy grin. "Glad I could do it."

"Thanks," Bow said.

"No more thanks," Micah said. "You should bow out of that now."

He pronounced bow like an archery bow which caused Bow to laugh. Adora, for her part, was just confused for a moment until she recognized the pun.

"No love?" Micah said.

Adora just shrugged as she said, “I thought you just mispronounced it.”

“Guess you’ll have to take another shot at it,” Bow said to Micah.

“Possibly. Maybe it’ll be a bullseye this time,” Micah said.

“Fletch you can’t do it again,” Bow said.

“Nice,” Micah said.

“I’ll just go do the paperwork,” Adora said as she started to turn around again to general good natured boos and spoil sports from Micah and Bow. She turned back around with a smile and then waved as she saw Glimmer driving up in a UTV.

“Ah, there you are,” Glimmer said. “Been looking for you.”

“Me?” three people said in unison which caused them to all laugh.

“Glad to see you’re all having fun,” Glimmer said with a smile. “Seriously, Dad, I’ve been looking for you.”

“Why didn’t you call on the radio?” Micah said.

“Because I did and you didn’t answer,” Glimmer said.

Micah pulled the little radio off his belt and then sighed as he turned it on.

“Yeah, works better when it’s on, Dad,” Glimmer said with a smirk.

“What did you need?” Micah said.

“Mr. Jensen is at the office. I got Label keeping him company,” Glimmer said. “He wants to complain about someone going across his property. ”

“And did someone go across his property?” Micah said.

“I’d say no but I don’t like lying to you,” Glimmer said.

“Was it at least just that trail along the river?” Micah said.

“Yeah,” Glimmer said.

“Idiot. He’s probably just paranoid about…,” Micah said as he rolled his eyes and then cut himself off.

“I already heard about his illicit growing activities from someone else,” Glimmer said. “Don’t worry, we’re going to avoid it. We’ll just go to Coopers Hole by boat.”

Micah started to say something before grimacing a little and stopped himself. Instead, he said, “OK, can I borrow the UTV?”

“Brought it so you could get up there fast,” Glimmer said as she hopped out of the seat. “Label isn’t going to keep him occupied that long.”

“Alright,” Micah said as he got in. “Chat at you all later.”

Glimmer waved as Micah took off and then gave Bow a kiss. The kiss caught Adora off guard and she took a sudden interest in a bow sitting on a table as she felt the ache of missing Catra settle in.

“You alright?” Bow said.

Adora looked up as she smiled and said, “Yeah, just a bit hot.”

“Tell me about it,” Glimmer said. “I swear it’s hotter this year right now than it was at the end of June last year. Anyway, did Dad get bored of paperwork again?”

Adora shook her head as she said, “No. I guess I got caught up faster than he thought and decided we’d go out and see what was what.”

“And then Bow decided to show off for Dad I’m guessing,” Glimmer said with a grin. “At least you finally shot that thing.”

“Don’t laugh, I’m going to smell like Tiger Balm tomorrow more than likely,” Bow said. “That pull is no joke.”

“Can I see you shoot it?” Glimmer said.

“Alright,” Bow said.

They went back to where Bow had been shooting earlier as Bow said, “Just one more.”

“Aw, fine,” Glimmer said with a laugh.

They stood there as Bow got positioned and started to draw the bow. Adora happened to glance at Glimmer, who was unconsciously biting her lip as she looked at Bow's shoulders flexing in his tank top. Adora looked down as she heard the string twang as the bow was loosed.

"Holy crap, that thing is wild!" Glimmer laughed as she sat a hand on Bow's arm for a moment.

"Yeah, it's pretty great," Bow said as he stepped away to unstring the bow.

Adora shuffled a little as Glimmer and Bow chatted. She felt like an extra wheel flapping loose and frowned as she looked out into the trees.

"Hey, guys, I'm going to go and see if Mista needs my help," Adora said.

"You sure?" Glimmer said, her face confused.

"Yeah, I'm sure," Adora said. "Feels weird to be just standing around and not working. I'll catch up with you."

Adora was already walking backwards and waved at them as she finished up before turning around and heading into the trees.

“Is she alright?” Glimmer said.

“I think she might be uncomfortable with us when we’re, you know, being a couple,” Bow said.

“What do you mean? We were just standing here,” Glimmer said.

“Other than you biting your lip watching me?” Bow said.

“I did not!” Glimmer said and then sighed. “OK, maybe I was but it’s not like we haven’t done that before.”

“I’m not saying we did something wrong,” Bow said. “I’m just saying I think it’s hard for her right now.”

“We gotta get her a phone,” Glimmer said.

“In the place cell service forgot?” Bow said, gesturing around.

“Well, OK, maybe not here but for the future,” Glimmer said.

“She’ll be here tomorrow,” Bow said.

“You sure?” Glimmer said.

“Oh, come on,” Bow said as he put an arm around her. “Don’t put that out there.”

“I’m just saying! It’s not like Catra’s schedule isn’t all over the place,” Glimmer said.

“OK, but just don’t say that in front of Adora,” Bow replied.

“Really? You think?” Glimmer said as she pulled Bow to her.

Meanwhile, Adora found herself on the dock to Mista’s great glee.

“Perfect timing,” she said. “I was about to get in the water and finish the inspection on the supports. Gotta have a swim buddy after all.”

“Let me go get my swimsuit then and I’ll be right back,” Adora replied as she fought to keep herself upbeat as she thought about Catra.

“OK, but first, do you have anything in your pockets?” Mista said.

Adora looked at her confused as she said, “No.”

“Then you’re good to go,” Mista said and body checked Adora into the water. Adora hit the cool water of the river and came back up sputtering as she put a hand on the dock.

“Really!?” Adora said.

“You’re fine,” Mista said as she leaned sideways and fell into the river next to Adora. When she popped back up she was grinning. “See? I did it to myself so you we’re even.”

Adora was starting to laugh as she said, “Oh, we are far from even.”

“Oh my God, Weaver, are you swearing a vendetta!?” Mista said with glee. “I didn’t think you had it in you!”

“Yes, I am,” Adora said. “Sleep with one eye open.”

“It’s so cute when you try to be threatening,” Mista said. “Now come on. Let’s see what new and exciting forms of algae have decided to grow on this thing.”

“Ah, yes, exactly what I imagined for camp this year,” Adora said.

They swam around the dock, Mista making note of any issues that needed attention but it was a fairly easy thing to handle. Adora pointed out a few little water snails she spotted and at one point, something fairly decent sized swam past them.

“What was that!?” Adora said.

Mista shrugged as she said, “Probably a catfish. Could be an alligator gar too.”

“OK, what?” Adora said.

“Why are you acting surprised, you’ve been on this river since you were a kid, you told me yourself,” Mista said.

“Yeah, but we swam in a pool mostly,” Adora said.

Mista was shaking her head with a sigh as she said, “That’s such a shame. No life in those things.”

“That’s not a bad thing,” Adora replied.

Mista snorted but didn’t respond as she kept going.

Afterwards, Adora walked along the path towards the main camp, water squishing in her shoes, humming to herself and realized she could think of Catra for a moment and not be hurt. The rest of the day she spent going from place to place, trying to make herself useful as she did her best to avoid thinking too much.

Chapter End Notes

> If you’re not familiar, Bois d’Arc is another name for the Osage Orange tree. It’s a pretty hard, dense wood that’s rot resistant and so it got planted around a lot of farms so they could be turned into fence posts. The wood also got used for bows by various Native American tribes and is still used today. It’s a pain in the ass to work with, partly because it’s so hard, but also because it can grow pretty crooked and so getting straight bits to make bows out of isn’t the easiest. Getting a bit to make a bow almost six feet long like Micah got for Bow and making it to a seventy pound draw weight? Pretty hard. It’s a fancy bow that really doesn’t have any business being at a summer camp is what I’m trying to get across but Bow is worth it.
>
> And for those wondering, I'll give a little spoiler. Catra shall be here in the next chapter.

Tuesday

Chapter Summary

> The long awaited day has arrived and Catra is going to finally visit. Will the day go well or will it devolve into drama as Adora tries to sort through her feelings?

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora had gone to bed disappointed on Monday night. She'd tried to call Catra and only got her voicemail that said, "You know who you called. If you hear this, I'm probably out of minutes or I don't want to talk to you. Take a stab at which one and leave a message if you think it'll get returned."

She sighed, knowing that Catra was out of minutes but a little voice in the back of her head, that she squashed as fast as she could, said Catra didn't want to talk to her because she was busy with Her. The next morning, she woke up with the thought in her head that it was Tuesday and Catra would be there soon. She'd never got a solid time from Catra because Catra herself didn't know. She wondered when she would get there as she sat up, the dim light of early morning showing the forms of the other staff still asleep except for the outline of one person Adora could see sitting at the little table on the porch. As she wiped at the sleep in her eyes, she saw the person lift a cup and drink. It was at that moment that Adora put together the fluffy ponytail and the coffee cup along with the rest of the dim figure.

Adora's feet were on the floor so fast she almost fell over as she ran for the door, almost going through the screen in her haste to get outside. Catra looked up in surprise for a moment and then set her cup down by the small coffee pot on the table next to her as she got to her feet and opened her arms. Adora collided into her arms and the two kissed, their noises smashing together for a moment until they got oriented. After a few minutes, they finally pulled apart and Adora said, "I thought you weren't going to get here until later!"

"Shhhh, people are sleeping," Catra said in a mischievous voice as she kissed Adora again.

"Fine, I'll whisper," Adora said, her voice dropping. "I thought you weren't going to be here until later."

"Reggie wasn't going to be," Catra said. "I caught a ride with some other people who were coming through and they dropped me off at the gates last night."

"You were here last night!?" Adora said, barely managing to keep her voice down.

Catra made little shushing noises as she tried not to laugh too hard as she said, "Only in the sense it was still dark. It was like 3:30 in the morning. I put my stuff in the trailer, grabbed a quick nap, and then came down to surprise you."

“You should have woke me up,” Adora said.

“You have taken a swing at me for waking you up too early,” Catra said.

“I have not!” Adora said in amused outrage before kissing Catra again.

“You have so,” Catra said after the kiss.

“I don’t know what you’re talking about,” Adora said and then they both suddenly turned when the screen door opened.

“I don’t either but if you give me some of that coffee, I’ll pretend like I wasn’t woken up by you two being disgustingly cute,” Mista said as she walked out onto the porch in boxer shorts and a t-shirt with a giant sparkling whale printed on it. She had a mug in her hand and held it out in front of her.

Catra took the pot off what Adora realized was a tiny stand with a small brass burner in the center, the dim blue flames burning around the rim flickering a little in an early morning breeze. Catra poured one handed, because the other hand was around Adora, and Mista gave a little nod and then wandered off towards the bathhouse without another word.

“How embarrassing,” Adora said as she buried her head in Catra’s shoulder.

“Not nearly as embarrassing as you think,” Wasp said as they came walking out of the cabin with a steel cup in their hand, wearing cut off sweatpants and a baggy orange t-shirt. “Serving up coffee is a good way to say hello, Catra.”

“Wasp, good to see you,” Catra said as she laughed and poured a cup for them. “I meant this to be for me.”

“Then you shouldn’t have brewed a whole pot,” Wasp said as they took a sip. “Oof, that’s rough.”

Wasp took another sip as Catra said, “Notice it doesn’t stop you.”

“It’s hot and caffeine,” Wasp said before they too headed off as Adora pulled her head out of Catra’s shoulder and pulled her in for another kiss.

“I swear, can’t sleep in for crap with all the noise,” Glimmer muttered as she shuffled out the door and took Catra’s mug from her hand.

“Hey!” Catra said, breaking from the kiss with a laugh.

“You’re busy, you don’t need it,” Glimmer replied as she sat down at the table.

“She showed up early!” Adora said to Glimmer as she hugged Catra tight.

“I can see,” Glimmer said as she yawned.

“You’re a ray of sunshine as always,” Catra said as she yawned.

“How long have you been up?” Glimmer said.

“I got a nap when I got in last night,” Catra said.

“My bunk is empty, go lay down,” Glimmer said.

“I’m fine,” Catra said. “If I’m tired I'll go back to the trailer.”

Glimmer grunted, drained Catra’s mug, sat it on the table, and then stood up.

“Don’t make out all day,” Glimmer said. “At least stop for meals.”

Adora blushed hard as Glimmer went down the stairs and headed off towards the bathhouse.

"How many more people are in there?" Catra said as she put her arm around Adora's shoulder and turned to look into the cabin.

"More than I'm comfortable thinking about," Adora said. "Can we go somewhere private?"

"Oh, it's private you want," Catra said, her voice full of insinuation that only made Adora blush harder.

"Not that," Adora said. "OK, maybe that but I just wanted to spend some time where we're not being interrupted constantly."

"I'm fine with that but maybe change?" Catra said, looking at Adora's t-shirt with a giant unicorn on it and green pajama pants. "Not that you're not adorable of course."

Adora felt herself glow at being called adorable and quickly went inside to change as Catra put away her stove and coffee pot into a small backpack. A few minutes later they were headed off, hand in hand, as the two talked. They ended up sitting at the arts and crafts pavilion as Adora told Catra about the music night they'd just had.

“There was a lot of great stuff there!” Adora said. “I can’t wait until we do it again!”

“You know, I tried to get you to listen to some music once and you said that it wasn’t right because it was worldly,” Catra said with a laugh and a nudge.

“Fine, tease your girlfriend you haven’t seen in forever,” Adora said as she leaned in. “I can just not kiss you instead you know.”

Catra leaned in as well as she said, “You’d punish yourself for something I did? That’s good to keep in mind.”

Adora looked away with an embarrassed smile before turning back and kissing Catra really quickly.

“I guess I need to learn a different bluff,” Adora said.

“You’re a terrible bluffer,” Catra said. “Remember when Glimmer taught us poker? I swear, you’re like a golden retriever when you get a good hand.”

“So, did you miss me?” Adora asked.

“I don’t know,” Catra said. “I mean, I did hop a ride with total strangers, get dropped off in the middle of the night, and then only get like two hours of sleep before coming over to surprise you.”

“I’m not hearing a yes,” Adora said, giving her a smirk.

“Oh, you think I didn’t miss you?” Catra said with a raised eyebrow.

Adora felt her stomach clench a little at the words but she ignored it and said, “Maybe.”

A few minutes later, as Catra was answering her with kisses, they both jumped when they heard someone clear their throat loudly. The two set up from the top of the picnic table they’d been on, each a matching shade of red, to see Angella standing there in the early dawn light.

“You know, when I take my little walks when staff is in camp, I never know when I’m going to find a display of young love,” she said.

“Uh, sorry, ma’am,” Adora said, trying not to look her in the eye. “Catra came in early last night and surprised me and we were just… um…”

“We were catching up,” Catra said with a smile.

“I could see,” Angella said, trying to keep a straight face and mostly succeeding. “Catra, are you taking up residence in the trailer again or are you moving out to Cottonwood Cove?”

“I’ll probably be in the trailer,” Catra said. “I crave air conditioning.”

Angella did smile then as she said, “I fully understand. I’ll leave you two for now and could you do me a favor?”

Adora nodded as she sighed a little in relief that Angella running across them hadn’t been more awkward and said, “Of course.”

“Could you not ‘catch up’ on the tables, please?” Angella said before continuing on her walk as Adora buried her burning face in her hands and Catra’s laughter rang from the rafters.

“I am going to go throw myself in the river now,” Adora said, her voice muffled.

“You’re not,” Catra said as she put an arm around her. “You only do that when the river’s flooding.”

“And when someone was clumsy enough to fall in,” Adora said, looking up at her.

“That’s right, mock me at my lowest,” Catra said with a little smirk. Adora suddenly started apologizing and Catra bumped her with her shoulder. “I’m teasing you. It’s alright.”

Adora slipped an arm around Catra as she said, “I’m sorry, I’ve just been a wreck lately.”

“Getting everything ready been that hard?” Catra said.

Adora started to tell her about all her worries and concerns she’d had about the two of them but she looked at Catra and knew she couldn’t just suddenly burden her with all of that when they’d just got together and only had a limited amount of time to spend together before Catra went back out. She swore to herself she’d bring it up later and just smiled as she said, “It wasn’t awful. Just how it goes. I’m glad you’re here though.”

“I’m glad I’m here too,” Catra said. “So, I know you’re working today and tomorrow but you mind if I tag along?”

“You know I actually have to work right?” Adora said as Catra lay her head on Adora’s shoulder and batted her eyes at her. “I can’t just spend it all with you.”

“Yes, I know you have to work,” Catra said with a smile. “I won’t distract you. Much.”

Adora cleared her throat, feeling it suddenly hard to swallow as Catra said the last word in a way that made Adora’s heart beat a little faster.

“OK,” Adora replied.

Catra sat up, put her finger under Adora’s chin and said, “As if you were going to tell me no.”

A little later, the two walked into the dining hall for breakfast to a chorus of hellos. Catra waved and went around talking to people for a few minutes as Adora followed along holding Catra’s hand with a huge smile. Eventually they sat down with Bow and Glimmer with their trays full of food from the little breakfast buffet that Cookie had set out.

“Look at you,” Bow said to Catra. “It has been way too long.”

“It has been,” Catra said. “Don’t let me forget, I have gifts for you two.”

“Ah, you should have,” Glimmer said with a grin.

“I meant Bow and Adora,” Catra said to Glimmer.

“Well screw you too then,” Glimmer replied.

“You know you love me,” Catra said. “I know because you’re unusually chipper for this early.”

“Because someone, I’m not naming names, woke me up too early so I’ve had a chance to get moving,” Glimmer said.

“I’ll name names,” Catra said and then turned towards another table and hollered. “Mista! Glimmer’s mad you woke her up so early!” Mista raised a hand with one finger sticking up at Catra as she listened to whatever it was that Sea Hawk was talking about. “She’s not even repentant about it. Shame.”

“So Adora, I assume you’re going to disappear for a little while?” Glimmer said.

“No!” Adora replied. “I’m going to do my work.”

“I think she’s trying to say it’s alright if you do,” Bow said.

Adora warred with her heart and her brain before finally saying, “It’s alright. We’ll have plenty of time together.”

“Besides, I’m going along with her,” Catra said.

“Oh, great,” Glimmer said. “So she’s going to be *at* work but not, you know, actually, mentally present.”

“I’ll be working,” Adora said and tried not to show that she was irritated by the assumption.

“I’ll let her get her stuff done,” Catra said. “Now, you might not see us tonight.”

Catra had a grin on her face as Adora said low and embarrassed, “Stop it!”

“Alright, alright,” Catra said as she started eating. “Damn. This is so much better than what I get on the road.”

“Cookie does a good spread,” Bow said.

“Yeah, I remember that from last year,” Catra said.

Breakfast was Catra telling stories about her travels while people slowly gathered around until she was in a group of people

listening and asking questions. Adora listened and then Catra said, "Yeah, we were all hanging out under this big awning and this woman, name of Britt, hollered at some guy who was staring at us all. Something about taking a picture or something like that, and he gets all bent out of shape and comes over to say something and Reggie just kind of shifts a little and gives him this *look.* I can't even describe it but I wish I was even a quarter as badass as that look. It was great. Dude just folded and walked off, probably to change his underwear."

Everyone laughed. Everyone but Adora because she'd heard the name Britt and realized that Catra had said she was hanging out with her. Bow saw Adora's face and started to say something when Glimmer spoke up.

"I have to break up our love fest but we got to get stuff done and we got a big group team building this afternoon," Glimmer replied. "I think we should head on."

Everyone groaned and mumbled but they got up and cleaned up the tables before drifting out. Catra gave Adora a kiss as she said, "I gotta go hit the restroom. See you out front?"

Adora smiled at her, the kiss making her feel a little better, as she said, "Sure. See you in a few."

Bow came up to Adora when Catra had left and said, "Is Britt the one you were talking about the other day?"

“Maybe,” Adora said, feeling stubborn all of a sudden.

“Have you talked to her about that?” Bow said.

“Not yet,” Adora said, not looking at him.

“Adora, you gotta talk to her about that,” Bow said. “You can’t let that hang around. I saw your face when she mentioned that.”

“I just don’t want to ruin the time we have,” Adora said. “I’ll talk with her about it, I swear.”

“It’s just going to screw with you even more,” Bow said. “Say something. Really. It’ll be alright.”

“I will, alright?” Adora said. “Just, you know, just let me choose when.”

Bow frowned but nodded as he said, “Alright. I’ll let you decide.”

Catra came out shortly afterwards and Adora started walking away with her. She turned and saw Bow mouthing, “Don’t wait!” to her and Adora just frowned and looked away.

The rest of the day went well though. Adora worked in the office while Catra sat back in a chair and handed her things and they talked about whatever came to mind. That afternoon they played some game that Tossa had come up with. It was supposed to be a team building exercise. It didn't really work out that way as it involved drawing a card with various roles on it and then figuring out who the killer was before they could give a secret tap to various people. It devolved into conspiracy pretty quickly and people trying to stay away from each other but it was a lot of fun, or at least they said so after it was over, even though no one figured out the killer was Bow.

"He's so nice!" someone shouted out when he revealed his identity.

"That has nothing to do with the game," Glimmer said as she laughed and hugged him.

That evening, Catra and Adora went for a little walk through the woods, taking time to kiss under some big cottonwoods and just spend time together. Adora kept thinking she needed to bring up her insecurities but any time she thought to say something, she'd talk herself out of it.

"I missed this," Catra said as they walked into the backyard of Angella and Micha's home. "It's just not the same running around."

"It sounded like you had a really good time," Adora said.

“Ah, don’t put too much into that,” Catra said, making a dismissive hand gesture. “That’s the fun times but that’s not even half of it. Most of it is hard, dirty work while sitting around barns and being sneered at by the rich jackasses that own the horses. Had one guy even call me a servant. Like, fuck you, buddy, I don’t see you wrestling with your overpriced horse to take care of it.”

“I’m sorry,” Adora said as they both leaned against the side of the trailer.

“Thanks,” Catra said. “It’s worth it though. Someday, you and me together you know. That’s what we gotta remember. It’ll be worth it.”

“Someday,” Adora said, gripping Catra’s hand a little tighter. The two went into the trailer as the sun slipped below the horizon and Adora swore she’d talk to Catra about it later but tonight she didn’t want to ruin anything.

Chapter End Notes

> Tossa’s game is basically Werewolf. If you don’t know Werewolf, the basics are you need at least seven or eight people and you draw cards. On two of the cards it says werewolf. On one it says seer. The rest are villagers. I won’t go deep into the rules but the villagers have to basically figure out who the werewolves are and get rid of them and you don’t find out who they are until the game is over. The seer can make guesses about who the werewolves are and get told if they’re right or not. A lot of it is done with eyes closed and in silence. It absolutely breeds distrust. If you’re thinking this sounds a lot like Among Us, that’s because it

was based on rules like this (they're known by other names as well, like Mafia, but it's basically the same thing with different names for the roles).

Also, of course, Adora deflects her emotions and won't talk about what's going on. For those wondering, this is going to end up being longer than the original fic in this series. So buckle up for the angst-coaster.

All the Long Goodbyes

Chapter Summary

> Adora needs to talk to Catra about her feelings but she's finding out that telling someone you love them is only the beginning, not the finish line.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Wednesday slipped past and Adora swore she'd talk to Catra about her worries but she could never bring herself to do it. She almost did as they sat on the steps of the office in the morning, talking in each other's arms. She almost did when they went swimming in the river in the heat of the day, the two hanging onto each other as they bobbed along. Then again, after dark as they sat around a campfire at Cottonwood Cove, she almost pulled her aside to talk to her. Even on the walk back to the trailer in the dark, she almost spoke but it never came about though. Her worry told her that if she spoke it, it'd become true, and she found herself wanting to keep everything happy and content. That night as they went to sleep in the trailer, Adora's head resting on Catra's shoulder as she looked at the ceiling, she knew she had to say something though.

"I hate it when you're away," Adora said.

Catra put a hand on Adora's head as she said, "I hate being away."

“I worry about you,” Adora said.

Silence. Adora waited for Catra to pick up on what she was saying, that she was worried about losing her.

“I probably shouldn’t have told you all those stories about the fighty horses, huh?” Catra said. “It really isn’t that bad.”

“Yeah, that too,” Adora said.

Again, silence.

“You know, you don’t have to worry about me,” Catra said. “I worry about you as well but I know you’ll be alright.”

Adora thought she could maybe see what Catra was trying to say. She rolled over and pushed herself up on her elbows. She could just see Catra’s face in the light of the moon coming in through a window and for a brief moment wanted to reach out and trace the freckles sprinkled across her face before she went on.

“I get it but really, you have nothing to worry about with me,” Adora said. “No danger, I promise.”

Catra lightly pushed a strand of Adora's hair back as she said, "Well, you know, Swift Wind is always a danger."

Adora laughed as she said, "He's not that bad!"

"To you maybe," Catra said. "That horse is a menace. A loveable menace but still a menace."

Adora scooted up until she was on her pillow and then turned to look at Catra, who was looking back at her.

"I just don't want to lose you," Adora said, putting everything she had into saying it so Catra would hear all the hidden things behind it.

"I'm not going anywhere," Catra replied. "You and me, the future, we've got all kinds of things we're going to do, babe. What's bringing this on?"

Adora just shrugged as she said, "Nerves, I guess. I know you're leaving tomorrow."

"It's not here yet," Catra said, running her thumb down Adora's jaw.

“No, it’s not,” Adora said with a soft smile.

Adora was up before the Sun the next day as Catra finished packing up her bags and the two started down the little dirt road that led to the main road that went past the camp. Adora carried one of Catra’s bags and the two held hands as they walked, both silent and lost in thought. Adora could hear the mourning doves starting to coo as the sky lightened and the air was still except for an occasional breeze that barely shook the leaves. All too soon they got to the iron entryway over the road into the camp. An old pickup sat in silence, its cooling engine making little ticking noises in the still morning air.

“Guess Reggie is already here,” Catra said as they both stopped under the arch of the entry sign.

“Guess he is,” Adora said as an older man got out of the truck, stretched and waved.

Catra waved back as she said, “Be right there.”

“No rush,” Reggie said as he crossed the road. “Just going to drop some morning coffee off behind that bush.”

“Can’t he just pour it out on the road?” Adora said and then realized what he meant and blushed.

“I’ll cherish that expression on your face,” Catra said with a grin as they walked up to the truck, opened the camper shell, and tossed the bags in the back. Adora could vaguely see boxes and tools sitting around while the smell of metal, oil, and a vague scent of horse came from the back as the two stood at the tailgate, not sure what to say.

“I’ll call as soon as I top up my minutes,” Catra finally said.

“I think it’ll be easier if I call you,” Adora said. “Tomorrow?”

Catra nodded as she scuffed at the pavement.

“Yeah, eight in the evening,” she said.

The two were silent as Reggie came back from his impromptu bathroom break and headed to the front of the truck, doing his best not to pay attention to the two.

“I hate this,” Adora whispered.

“Me too,” Catra said as she pulled her into a hug. “We’ll be back around in a couple of weeks I think. I’ll let you know for sure tomorrow.”

Adora hugged her back as she sniffled and said, “I love you.”

“I love you too,” Catra said before kissing her. “I better go or we’ll be here all day.”

“Would that be so bad?” Adora said and was met with Catra’s sad smile.

“No, it wouldn’t,” Catra said.

Catra started to pull away and Adora pulled her back and kissed her again as Reggie started up the truck.

“I gotta go,” Catra replied.

“I know,” Adora said but she didn’t let go.

Catra leaned forward and kissed her again as she said, “It won’t be as long this time.”

Adora wasn’t even trying to hold back her tears as she said, “I know.”

Catra hugged her tight, her own tears falling, and then kissed her again as she said, “I’ll try and write as well, OK?”

“I’d like that,” Adora said with a sad smile. “Don’t forget about me.”

“You don’t forget about me either,” Catra said and then kissed her hard for as long as she could before she finally stepped back and out of Adora’s arms. She shut the back of the pickup and started backing up. “I love you.”

“I love you too,” Adora said and then she darted forward and kissed her one last time, doing everything she could to make the kiss hold for all the long time that stood between them and the next time they’d see each other.

Finally, Catra got into the pickup and it pulled away. Adora stood by the side of the road and watched it go out of sight in the early morning light. She walked a little bit back towards the camp and stopped at the side of the road to lean against a tree and cry. She hated how hard it was to stay and hated Catra for having to leave and hated her for even being willing to get into the truck and leave. A part of her told her it was because she was leaving for good, that she had one last little fling and she’d go off now to be with Britt even while the rest of her knew that Catra leaving was something that she had to do. Just like Adora was at camp and school to work towards their future, Catra was doing the same. She kept telling herself that one day they’d be together and then there wouldn’t be goodbyes like that ever again.

However, that wasn't today and she wept.

She didn't go back to the trailer. It wasn't home now that Catra wasn't there. Instead she made her way back to Cottonwood Cove and ran into Glimmer on the way there.

"I was just coming to see you," Glimmer said. She saw her friend's face and took her arm as she steered her off the path. "Yeah, that was what I was worried about. You alright?"

"No," Adora said, as she sniffled a little, her eyes painful and puffy. "I just…"

Adora trailed off and Glimmer hugged her as she said, "I know. I feel the same way whenever I have to say goodbye to Bow."

"Yeah, but he has a car and you see him every few weeks," Adora said as they stopped in a little opening in the trees. Adora sat down on the ground as she pulled her knees to her as she felt incredibly bitter towards her friends all of a sudden. "It's not the same."

"You're going to get ticks doing that," Glimmer said as she knelt down in front of her.

"I don't care," Adora said.

Glimmer shrugged as she said, “I’m not saying that Bow and I have it the same as you two but I have an idea is all I’m saying.”

Adora just looked away. She didn’t feel like being made to feel better and she didn’t want to think at the moment. She wanted to curl up and go to sleep for weeks until Catra was back.

“Can I just go back to the cabin?” Adora finally said.

“Of course,” Glimmer said. “Take the day off if you want. We’re pretty well caught up. We’re probably just going to goof off most of the day.”

Adora didn’t say anything and finally stood up and started back towards the path. Glimmer followed along with her, not saying anything, just being there, and even though Adora didn’t want to be around anyone at the moment, she had to admit that her friend by her side felt a bit better. She got to the cabin and was happy to find that it was mostly empty except for Perfuma who was just leaving.

“Adora…,” she started to say and Glimmer shook her head at her. Adora just gave her a thin smile and went on into the cabin where she lay down on her bed, curled up with her stuffed horse, and was soon asleep. While she was doing this, Perfuma was asking Glimmer if she was alright.

“Catra left today,” Glimmer said softly.

“Oh,” Perfuma said, her face falling.

“Yeah, oh,” Glimmer said with a sigh.

“I really hope they make it. They’ve been through so much,” Perfuma said. “I wish I knew what to do.”

“You still seeing Scorpia, right?” Glimmer said and watched as Perfuma’s face lit up.

“I am!” she said. “We talk all the time.”

Glimmer looked up at the cabin before turning back to Perfuma.

“She knew them both before we ever did,” Glimmer said. “Ask her if there’s something she might think of to help.”

“Of course,” Perfuma said. “I’ll try some divination as well to see what can be told to me.”

“Talk to Scorpia first,” Glimmer said.

“Either is perfectly acceptable,” Perfuma said, a bit put out.

“I’m not saying it isn’t,” Glimmer said. “I just think knowing what you can from Scorpia might help the divination.”

Perfuma perked up as she said, “I hadn’t thought of that! I always thought you didn’t believe in this.”

Glimmer didn’t want to lie so she didn’t as she said, “I don’t actually but I figure, hey, more information either way.”

“You are more in tune with the world than you know,” Perfuma said before heading off.

“Then let me know what to tune to for all of this,” Glimmer muttered under her breath as she went up the stairs to look in on her friend before heading out for the day.

Chapter End Notes

For everyone who thought this was going to be a fight and resolution.... oh, no. I've got more angst to cultivate.

Thank you as always for reading and I hope you're enjoying this!

First Day of Camp

Chapter Summary

Adora is drifting, falling into depression, and Mista sees a chance to try and help.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora went through the next few days in a haze. She wasn't sad, she wasn't happy, she just felt like she was there. She ate, she smiled with no warmth, she slept when she was tired, which felt like it was constantly, and she went along with Glimmer or Bow when they wanted her to go somewhere. Then, Sunday came and the first campers started showing up.

Micah had set up a table and awning by the front entrance for checking in campers and Adora was in charge of it along with Mista while the rest of the counselors were spread out around camp to help guide incoming campers and their families. Micah had borrowed a tractor and flatbed trailer from a neighbor and Angella drove it to shuttle people around. The first campers started showing up around ten a.m. and Adora was there, hair in a ponytail and in her best cargo shorts and Camp Bright Moon shirt, with a smile on her face.

"Welcome to camp!" Adora said to the first family with a boy of about eleven and a girl of about thirteen. "Can I get your name?"

And so it went, as it went from a trickle of people to a line waiting as people parked in a little field next to the entrance and walked over. Mista and Adora greeted people, took paperwork, settled little problems, and finally around one in the afternoon, the crowd let up enough for them to eat the sandwiches and chips that Glimmer had run out to them on one of the UTV's.

"At least the weather is decent," Mista said as she filled up a cup from the big orange water cooler on the table with a sign on it that said, "Remember your last drink? Well that's too long."

Adora looked up at the huge fluffy clouds going past. Dealing with all the people had pulled her out of her shell a bit and she nodded as she said, "Might rain though."

"As long as it doesn't rain now," Mista said before sitting down in her chair. Then she was right back on her feet as another family came in. After she'd processed them in, she stretched a little.

"So you've been pretty quiet lately," Mista said.

Adora shrugged but didn't say anything.

"Nonchalant attitude is my thing," Mista said. "You got something going on you need to get off your chest?"

"I'm fine," Adora replied.

“If you say so,” Mista said and then waved at Bow as he drove the Purple Elephant through the gates with a busload of campers he’d picked up in a town about an hour away called Broken Timber.

Adora waved as well but didn’t say anything more. Mista just looked at her with a raised eyebrow before another wave of people started coming in. They finally wrapped everything up around four and packed up the tables, chairs, and awning into a trailer on a UTV. Adora sat on the back, feeling tired from all the interactions with people but feeling better than she had from all the happy faces she’d seen on the kids who were showing up for camp. That night, the dining hall was packed with campers, from little eight year olds coming for their first time away from home for any length of time all the way up to older teenagers who were going to spend their last summer at camp.

It was looking at the last group that Adora remembered where she had been a year ago and how that was supposed to have gone. As she watched them laugh and talk, she wondered how many of them would be going through huge, life altering changes in the months to come. How many of them would suddenly find themselves questioning their life and the path they’d taken. It didn't bother her for some reason though. She just found herself looking at it clinically. She was shaken out of her thoughts with Glimmer taking the stage.

“Hello everyone!” Glimmer said.

There were calls of hello right back.

“I’m sorry,” Glimmer said. “I said hello!”

She was louder this time and the room responded back with a more cohesive, and louder, hello.

“One last time!” Glimmer said. “Loud enough they can hear you in town! Hello!”

The room shook to the hello that rang back to her.

“There it is!” Glimmer said. “Welcome to your first day at Camp Bright Moon! I’m the head counselor, Glimmer, and we’re going to go over a few things. First things first, I need to remind everyone to be sure and drink plenty of water! There’s water coolers at every activity center and scattered around camp.” Glimmer unclipped a plastic mug that hung off her belt and held it up. “Your counselors are going to have one of these for each of you. Try and carry it around if you can. If you don’t want to, there’s cups at the coolers. Just remember, if your pee looks brown, it’s time to drink the water down!”

That got a round of laughs, especially among the younger kids, and Glimmer waited for it to die down before going on.

“All joking aside, if you feel faint, if you’re not sweating, if you feel sick to your stomach, let someone know and get some water in

you immediately. Heat exhaustion is serious, so avoid it and drink as much water as you can," Glimmer said in the tone of voice of someone who'd had to carry more than one person to the river to get them cooled down while pouring water down their throat.

Glimmer then went on to go over some basic rules and planned activities for the next week. Then she gave up the stage for Perfuma and Wasp to get up and give a little skit about looking out for ticks and how to deal with them. After that Mista got up and talked about water safety and expectations for behavior at the docks. Adora found herself laughing and smiling at the silly jokes in the presentations as she fondly remembered seeing similar presentations at Camp Horde for the Lord all the years she'd gone. The big difference, she noticed, was this one didn't have any Bible verses or other religious references, not to mention it was a bit more risque. Although jokes about brown pee or being bit on the butt by a tick were only risque in comparison.

Finally, Glimmer took the stage again as she applauded Cookie, who'd got up to tell everyone how to properly bring their trays and dishes back to the dish pit window, and said, "We have the welcome campfire tonight at 8:30. Your counselors will be sure you're there on time. All you need to bring is your enthusiasm! Sea Hawk tells me that we're going to have a cheer show off tonight so try to think up a cheer for your cabin between now and then. And with that, we're good to go! Have fun!"

The noise in the room rose as all the campers and staff started talking and moving trays and dishes around. Adora saw Glimmer trying to get her attention and went over to the stage.

"What's up?" Adora said.

“Follow me outside,” Glimmer replied.

Adora did as asked and they walked a little ways from the open windows of the dining hall. The noise inside was just a comforting sound now, happy people moving about, and Glimmer went on.

“Sorry, didn’t want to holler,” Glimmer said. “Alright, can I get your help with something?”

Adora nodded and Glimmer went on.

“So, we’re going to do a little Q&A game after the campfire on the sports field,” Glimmer said. “I need you to slip out a few minutes before the end of the fire. Bow will take you and a few others over and get set up.”

“Sure,” Adora replied. “What am I supposed to do?”

“Basically, each cabin is going to go round some stations and you’re going to hand out candy to those who answer questions on safety and stuff we covered just now and at the campfire,” Glimmer said.

“Oh, yeah, I can do that,” Adora said.

“Great,” Glimmer said and was about to go on when her radio crackled and she heard her name being called. She shook her head as she answered. “Go ahead Hoot, over.”

Adora heard the cabin counselor saying they had an issue at her cabin and could Glimmer come help.

“Yeah, on my way, over,” Glimmer said before clipping the radio back to her belt. “Gotta go.”

“OK, have fun,” Adora said.

“Doubtful,” Glimmer said but she said it with a smile as she headed off towards Rock Iron Cabins.

Adora waved at her as she left and then stood as people moved around her. Some people said hello, while others were busy moving their cabins to one spot or another or trying to get some duty or another done. Adora suddenly felt all alone standing there and headed off towards Cottonwood Cove. After getting her shower bag and taking a quick shower, she settled down on one of the log benches at the firepit in front of the cabins at Cottonwood and picked up a twig to poke at bits of charred wood at the bottom of the firepit.

She thought of the call she'd had with Catra on Friday night. She'd been at some big racetrack and Adora could hear the announcer in the background. They'd talked for about an hour, Catra letting her know she'd be back in about three weeks, when it would be time to do the regular shoeing of the Camp Bright Moon horses. Otherwise, they'd tried to stay on safe topics, topics that didn't hurt like the fact they wouldn't see each other for almost a month and how much they missed each other. Adora at one point had sworn she'd heard Britt in the background but she hadn't said anything.

She didn't know how long she'd sat in front of the firepit, staring into it and not moving, when she heard Mista behind her.

"Hey, Adora, did you hear me?"

Adora jumped a little as she turned around and said, "What? Sorry, I was thinking."

Mista looked at Adora's face and her watery eyes as she said, "I get it. Kind of a big day. You don't realize how quiet it is out here, even with all the staff around, until you suddenly don't have that quiet, you know?"

"Yeah, I guess I got used to the quiet. Just caught me by surprise," Adora said, grasping on to the excuse Mista tossed at her.

“No worries,” Mista said as she sat down next to her. “I’m going to go down to the docks in a few, technically to check it out but really just to watch the river go by. You wanna go along?”

Adora shook her head and Mista gave a long sigh that had Adora looking back up at her.

“I invite you to my quiet time and you say no? Nope, get up,” Mista said as she stood up herself and grabbed Adora’s arm. “You’re accepting my incredibly generous invitation.”

“I’m fine, really,” Adora said but Mista still pulled at her arm.

“I know you ‘re fine,” Mista said. “I just figured we can both sit there in quiet together. Now get up off your ass. Come on.”

“Fine, fine,” Adora said, getting to her feet feeling both irritated at being disturbed but also touched that Mista would care enough to drag her along.

They took a shortcut through the woods that would avoid the main paths so they didn’t run into anyone and were soon walking out onto the docks. As promised, it was quiet down by the river except for the occasional splash of a fish snapping at a bug. Mista sat down on the end of the dock and shoved her sandaled feet into the water while Adora sat cross legged next to her as she noticed a few people moving around on the bluff at Camp Horde for the Lord.

“I wonder if I’m going to get any kid asking me if there’s fish in the river this year,” Mista said after a few minutes.

“Do you really get that?” Adora asked.

“Oh yeah,” Mista said. “Kids don’t know shit about rivers these days. I mean, I don’t want to call them stupid, not their fault really, but still, damn, think a little.”

“Probably just sheltered,” Adora said. “Who knows?”

“Yeah, who knows,” Mista said and the two lapsed into silence as they both saw another little group of people walk past on the bluff. “You know any of them?”

At first Adora thought Mista was talking about some of the kids but then she realized she was talking about the people across the river. She almost didn’t answer but swallowed a little and shrugged.

“I can’t tell from this distance,” Adora said. “If it’s some of the staff, probably. I knew pretty much all of them.”

“Want me to flip them off for you?” Mista replied.

Adora gave her a shocked look as she said, “No!”

“Just saying, I will if you want,” Mista said.

“No, you don’t have to do that,” Adora said. “They’re not bad or anything. They… well, they were my friends although I guess not anymore.”

Adora looked away and Mista watched her for a moment before she said, “Didn’t mean to bum you out. Brought you out here to try and shake that off you.”

“I’m not bummed out,” Adora said.

“Horseshit,” Mista replied and Adora was once again surprised at how Mista could say any curse word and make it sound friendly. “I’ve seen how you’ve been the last few days. I’ll deny it if you ever say anything about this but I just want to help you out.”

“You can’t,” Adora said.

Mista pulled a foot out of the water and gave Adora a little push. Adora wiped at the cool water on her leg as Mista said, “You can though. Listen, it sucks, your girlfriend is gone for now. I know

how it feels and I will drown you if you repeat this but I feel the same way when Sea Hawk isn't around."

"Really?" Adora replied, a bit surprised.

"Yes, really," Mista said. "I love that stupid bastard and I miss him but I'm not going to just crawl in a hole you know."

"This is the first real relationship I've ever had though," Adora said.

"Then it's time to learn how to handle it," Mista said. "Put on the big girl pants and deal."

Adora gave a little snort as she said, "You know, if someone else said that to me, I think I'd be mad."

"Come on, say pissed. Just once. Let some obscenities into your life," Mista said. "And yeah, I know but I'm a special princess who can get away with that kind of thing."

Adora gave a little huffing laugh as she leaned back against the post behind her. She didn't say anything in reply and Mista didn't say anything to her. Adora found herself humming a little and Mista started singing along.

“Sittin’ in the morning sun, I’ll be sitting when the evening comes…,”

“It’s such a good song,” Adora said, as she stopped humming.

“You know it’s about a guy feeling lonely, right?” Mista said.

Adora looked confused as she said, “I guess I didn’t really get that.”

“Yeah, he talks about how he’s lonely and he’s roamed thousands of miles but he’s just going to make that dock his home,” Mista said.

“Huh,” Adora said as she looked back across the river. “Yeah, I guess you’re right. Still pretty.”

“Yeah, he’s lonely but he’s dealing with it,” Mista said and Adora looked back at her with a raised eyebrow. Mista looked back with an innocent expression.

“Really?” Adora said.

“Hey, I saw the opening, I went with it,” Mista said.

They both looked up as they saw Tossa and Spinne walking along the raised bank by the docks and it was obvious they had just stopped talking.

"I think they've been fighting a lot," Adora whispered.

"Yeah, they have," Mista said and Adora felt a chill down her back.

"What about?" Adora said.

"I don't know," Mista said as she waved at the two and the two waved back but didn't stop walking. "They'll be fine. It's not like they haven't done that before."

"But… this much?" Adora said.

Mista shrugged as she said, "Hey, I don't get involved in other people's drama."

"You just got involved in mine," Adora said.

"At least you admit it's drama," Mista replied.

Adora shook her head as she said, "I never got involved with this before. Proverbs 20:3 says, 'It is an honor for a man to cease from strife: but every fool will be meddling.' I mean, good words there."

Mista grinned as she said, "You must be feeling a little better. I hadn't heard you do that lately."

"Do what?" Adora said.

"Quote the Bible at me," Mista said.

"I'm sorry," Adora said. "I know how people feel about that."

"Remember what you said about how I could say that thing and not have you be mad?"

"Yeah."

Mista gave her a little push with her foot again as she said, "You have a way of saying it that doesn't feel condescending or preachy. Like it's just something you think, take it or leave it."

Adora didn't respond at first but after a little bit of quiet she said, "It's my foundation, I guess. I'm changing a lot but that foundation is still going to always be there."

"Yeah, well, you're still cool," Mista said and then fixed her with a look. "I guess."

Adora actually laughed at that as she said, "I'll take it. I guess."

The two sat by the water for a little while longer before finally getting up and heading towards the campfire. Adora found herself getting into the spirit pretty fast. Sea Hawk ran the campfire with an energy that Adora found amazing, running back and forth in front of the log benches as he got people engaged and excited. There were funny little skits, some of which covered stuff they'd talked about at dinner, and some which were just funny. The cabins did their cheers, most of which just consisted of shouting something really loudly, although Adora could see a few cabins had wordsmiths in them from a few of the cheers.

Finally, Micah and Angella got up and talked about the history of the camp towards the end as a way to wind down the campfire. Throughout the whole thing, Adora would randomly remember sitting at the side of the fire there on the night of the winter solstice in silence and she felt like it was only fitting that now, with the Sun setting late, that it be filled with joy and laughter to contrast the silence and contemplation from a little less than six months before. As Micah and Angella talked, Bow came up and quietly gestured for her to follow him. She got up and headed towards the sports field with him and a few other counselors. They stopped on the edge of the field and Bow started talking.

“Alright,” Bow said, handing Adora a few notecards and a bag of candy, “you’re going to go over heat safety. Just ask the three questions. If they answer right, they get a piece of candy. If they don’t answer right, tell them the right answer, and then give them a piece of candy.”

“So, candy no matter what,” Adora said.

“Yes, but only once they’ve heard the answer,” Bow said.

“And how am I supposed to read this?” Adora said with a grin as she held up the notecards in the dark.

“You don’t have your flashlight?” Bow asked.

“I do not,” Adora said.

Wasp rummaged around in their pocket and came back with a tiny little push button LED light.

“Here you go,” they said.

Adora turned it on briefly and was met with a soft red light.

“Why red?” Adora said.

“That’s my stargazing light,” Wasp responded and then patted a bulky flashlight strapped to their hip. “This is my, ‘What is that I hear in the bushes?’ light.”

“I prefer to call it The Beacon,” Bow said.

“It’s not that bright,” Wasp replied.

“You bragged about how you built it with the brightest LED’s you could get your hands on,” Label said. “You said it could spotlight something a mile away.”

“And I’d appreciate it if you didn’t turn it on,” Bow said with a laugh.

“Oh, before the night is over, you shall see it,” Wasp replied.

“I’m good, really,” Bow said and then went on with explaining each person’s job.

The rest of the evening went well. Adora loved handing out candy to the kids and she particularly loved the youngest campers and worked hard to engage them. She could see some of them were still worried about what was probably their first night away from home in their lives and ended up handing out extra candy to those groups. She handed out so much in fact, she began to get worried she wouldn’t have enough for everyone but when the last group went past she found she had one left, a caramel.

When it was obvious no one else was going to come by, Adora lay back on the grass and popped the candy in her mouth as she watched the stars. She didn’t even realize she’d drifted half to sleep until Spinne was shaking her a little to wake her up so they could go back to the cabin.

Chapter End Notes

> I will always love that Mista just doesn't ever want to fully admit her feelings for Sea Hawk. I think it's partly because she's kind of freaked out by both the strength of the emotion and the clarity of it. It'll get better as she gets older.

Mail Call

Chapter Summary

Adora is trying to keep herself busy until a letter arrives that turns her upside down.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora was too busy over the next couple of weeks to stew too much over her relationship. She'd work in the office in the mornings and then in the afternoons she became the unofficial Camp Bright Moon fill in counselor. She did a bit of everything like run errands for staff, she helped teach arts and crafts classes, she assisted in teaching canoeing and boating, she shot archery, and she just talked with the kids. It was good.

What wasn't good were the calls to Catra. They alternated between making her very happy and incredibly depressed. It didn't help that Adora could always hear the mental tick of a clock as she knew Catra only had so many minutes on her phone before it'd run out. They tried to pack everything they could say into the calls but it was never enough. Worse, Adora found herself listening to the background noise, listening for any sign of Britt.

There was one day that did leave Adora walking amongst the clouds. She was sitting in the office when Micah came in with a small bag of mail. He put it on Adora's desk for her to sort through and she put it off for a little bit while she figured out a particularly tricky invoice from a local supplier.

“Having fun with that?” Micah said as he came back out of his office after about fifteen minutes to see Adora still going over prior invoices.

“No,” Adora said with a huff. “This makes no sense whatsoever.”

“That’s the co-op for you,” Micah said as he picked it up and looked at it. “Ah, got it.”

“What? How!?” Adora said as she stood up and looked over his shoulder.

“The hazardous waste removal fee got duplicated,” Micah said, pointing at it on the invoice. “It’s a glitch in their system but I thought it got ironed out. At least that’s what we were assured the last time I went to the co-op meeting and a whole bunch of us pitched a fit about it.”

Adora said, “But it isn’t labeled that!”

“I know,” Micah said, handing it back to her. “That’s the glitch. Sorry, we should probably stick a note in the file about this. Make a note to approve it minus that fee.”

Adora took the paper and sat back down with a sigh.

“That’s a mighty sigh,” Micah said. “You doing alright?”

“I’m fine,” Adora said. “I just spent the last twenty minutes going through prior months trying to find that.”

“Sorry,” Micah said. “If you get hung up again, just ask instead of busting your head against it. Chances are I know.”

“And then I’m going to note it so I don’t have to bug you,” Adora said.

“It’s not bugging me,” Micah said with a smile and then nodded at the pile of mail. “Want help sorting that?”

Adora looked at the small pile and shrugged as she said, “Doesn’t look like much, but sure.”

Micah sat down on the other side of the desk as Adora made a few quick notes and stuck the file away. Micah picked up a handful of mail and started quickly tossing it one way and another on the desk.

“I miss the old days,” Micah said. “Kids used to write back and forth with their parents all the time. It was always really sweet because some parents would decorate the envelopes and we

encouraged the kids to do the same. Course, that was back when we had a month-long residency program as an option. You had time to send correspondence. Now, most kids are here for a week and that's barely enough time to send off something, much less get a response. Even the ones on the two week program don't really do it anymore. We're just not a letter writing society anymore I guess."

Adora picked up some envelopes as she said, "You know, you could maybe have them send themselves a postcard or something halfway through the week. It'd be there waiting for them when they got home. Like have them tell themselves what they're enjoying or something like that."

Micah stopped for a moment as he looked up at her with a slow nod.

"That's a good idea," he said. "I'll get a pack of index cards and the campers can decorate them as their own custom postcards."

By that point they had stopped sorting the mail and Adora said, "You know, Perfuma has been wanting to do some kind of printing, like block printing or sun printing. No reason they couldn't do that with the cards."

Micah was tapping the desk in thought as he nodded and said, "Yes, that could work. I'm going to see what she needs for that."

Micah picked up the envelopes as he kept thinking and shuffled them a little in his hand. Then he looked down at one and pulled it out of the stack as he grinned at Adora.

"What?" she said.

"How about I finish this for you while you take a break?" Micah said as he held the envelope out to her.

Adora looked at the envelope, a plain white one that had a hand sketched image of a horse on the back. She took it from Micah's hand and then flipped it over to see her name on the front and then Catra's name in the return address spot. She felt her heart start to pound as she held it and resisted the urge to smell it.

"Go on," Micah said.

"OKI'llbebacklaterthankyouverymuch," Adora replied or something close to that as it took Micah a moment to process and by the time he pieced it together, she was already out the door.

She thought of going to the trailer, then she thought of Cottonwood Cove, and then finally she decided on going to a little secluded spot behind the campfire ring. She settled down onto the little bench that sat there and held the letter, suddenly afraid to open it.

"It's not bad news," Adora said, taking a deep breath as she carefully opened the letter.

Hey Adora,

I said I'd write and now I don't know what to put here. Reggie and I are at some dude ranch in Colorado right now. I wish you could see this. I wake up every morning, roll out of my cot, and there's this view that is just unbelievable. I mean, it's June and the mountains still have snow on them. Can you believe that? I mean, I know I've seen pictures and stuff but it's one thing to hear. It's another to see. Of course, then I go and stick my head under a horse for the rest of the day but you gotta make the most you know?

Have you ever been out here before? Colorado, I mean. I can't remember if you said you had or not but I know me, the kid who never took a vacation in her life, hasn't and it's just unreal. We gotta go together. I'd love it. You and me. There's plenty of national parks and stuff we could park at and sleep in the car, eat off a stove like that one I had when I came down. Just you and me, the open road and these mountains. I know you like to hike and that's all over the place up here! You'd have to see these dunes I saw driving through with Reggie. Sand dunes big as mountains, it was so cool! We didn't get to stop but you could see them for miles along the road we drove down. I think you'd love it.

I do that a lot, you know, think about us. I got a lot of time to do that in the evenings. Reggie is a good guy but he's a quiet guy. I liked that at first but it's lonely honestly. Not like those couple of days we had together. I don't want to be all sappy or anything,

you better not tease me about this, but I think about those a lot and they hold me over. I plan a lot in my head, what I want the future to be like. Like the trip I was just talking about. I have this whole thing in my head of what it's like but in the end I don't care what it's like, just as long as you're there.

Speaking of that trip, and the whole sleep in the car thing, Reggie said that he used to know climbers when he was younger who'd do that, sleep out on the ground, eat nothing but beans and rice, hold down jobs just long enough to get the money for their next climbing gear purchase and gas to get where they wanted to climb. All they cared about was climbing. He said they were called dirtbags, from sleeping on the ground in dirty sleeping bags, and they wore it like a badge of honor and didn't give a shit what anyone thought of them.

I know we don't sleep on the ground, well, you don't, mostly, lol, but that's you and me, dirtbags. We didn't care what others thought in the end. We did our own thing. We struck out away from what we knew and made it our own. And it's been so hard, I know but as I lay down at night, I think about those guys, those dirtbags, and they probably thought the same thing, probably a lot. Like when it rained and they had to sleep under a picnic table or cram into a car or when they got tired of like the tenth day of rice and beans and they probably got pissed and mad at themselves and wondered what the fuck they were doing. I know you felt that way, I know you have. It's alright. I have too but you know what? When I see you, it's worth it. Every bit. Every shitty night out on the ground, every horse pissing on me (yes! Really! It's nasty!), every shitty overprivileged douche who thinks Reggie and I are shit servants to be ordered around, it's worth it because I get to see you and hold you and kiss you and be with you. You're mine and I'm yours and we're dirtbags together.

You know what I want for the future? We've kind of talked about our own place but you know what I want? I want you to do this thing where you're figuring out religion and I want to work metal and make art with it. I want us to have a place where I can have a big shop and we'll build a house behind it and you can have a big office where you can put up all your diplomas and books and stuff. It'll be ours and we can have our friends over and I'll wake up next to you every day. We can sit out on the porch and watch the clouds and have dinner together and maybe a little fire on the patio, like Micah and Angella have. You and me.

OK, I stopped writing for a minute but I'm back. I know, you don't know that because this is written but I wanted you to know anyway. I started off saying I didn't know what to write and now I've written almost four pages of stuff. I love you. I just want you to know that. I'm going to close this with something I saw in a book Reggie has. It's a bunch of poems and quotes and stuff and he's always flipping through it and I read it and saw this. It's us.

A moment of happiness,

you and I sitting on the verandah,

apparently two, but one in soul, you and I.

We feel the flowing water of life here,

you and I, with the garden's beauty

and the birds singing.

The stars will be watching us,

and we will show them

what it is to be a thin crescent moon.

You and I unselfed, will be together,

indifferent to idle speculation, you and I.

The parrots of heaven will be cracking sugar

as we laugh together, you and I.

In one form upon this earth,

and in another form in a timeless sweet land.

- Rumi

I don't know poetry but isn't that great? You and I, a thin crescent moon. I don't know what it means but I just get a chill thinking of it with you.

I love you,

Catra

Adora sat there with the pages in her hand, wiping at the tears in her eyes. Catra was always so casual and relaxed and never really talked about her feelings much but it felt like she'd just poured them out onto the page. Adora read the letter twice more, savoring the words, laughing with joy at the image of the two of them as dirtbags who just didn't care about anything but each other, and then savoring the image of the two of them as a thin crescent moon. She agreed with Catra, she wasn't sure what it meant but there it was, a little chill. She carefully folded the letter back up and put it back in the envelope and then went to her cabin. It was early afternoon and it was empty as she went back to her bunk. She pulled her notebook down, the one she wrote

her thoughts in during her Bible study and tucked the letter into it so it would be in a good safe place and walked on air for the rest of the day.

Chapter End Notes

I find it funny that I'm talking about traveling in the letter and I just got back from a trip myself. My wife and I celebrated our anniversary and for that, we went to a few places we'd been meaning to go forever. One of them was the ocean. She'd never been before and we went and stood on the beach and stared off into the vastness and it was absolutely fantastic. I have a photo of her from where she stepped into the water for the first time and it's one of my favorite photos of her now.

Now about the fic. The sand dunes Catra talked about are in Great Sand Dunes National Park in Colorado, cover many square miles, and they really are amazing. They get up to 750 feet tall and there's a creek that runs along the eastern edge that you can park by and play in like a day at the beach except at about 7,000 feet elevation. There's a mountain, Sisnaajini (also known as Blanca Peak, 14351 feet high or 365 meters), sits on the edge of the park and is one of the four sacred peaks of the Navajo. The place is really something else.

The poem Catra quotes is from a collection of Rumi's poems called Divan-i Shams-i Tabrizi. If you don't know Rumi, I highly suggest you read him. Be aware, his poems sometimes don't have the best translations so be leery of what you see online and try to search out a solid book. His work is known for being love poetry but they're also deeply tied to his Sufi beliefs and there's layers of meaning in a lot of his work. The one that stands out as an example of this, that I've seen people quote as love poetry, is Put This Design in Your Carpet. I won't quote the whole thing but it has one of the most beautiful examples of the nature of the Divine in poetry that I've come across.

You're water. We're the millstone.
You're wind. We're dust blown up into shapes.
You're spirit. We're the opening and closing of our hands.
You're the clarity. We're this language that tries to say it.
You're joy. We're all the different kinds of laughing.

I came across that in a Humanities course over ten years ago and I've never stopped thinking about it since. I've talked before about how I see my concept of God in the nature of love in the world and between that, this, and the opening of the Tao Te Ching (The Tao that can be trodden is not the enduring and unchanging Tao/The name that can be named is not the enduring and unchanging name) really shapes my belief these days. Hey, this started as a church camp AU. There's going to be some thoughts on religion in it. :)

Also, I want to say, especially since I'm using brief quotes, that any time you see something like this, it's good to enjoy but if you really want to have a good understanding, go and read as much of the surrounding text as you can. Context really can be everything. My favorite example of this is the time I saw an inspirational Christian calendar with a verse a day and on one day the verse was Matthew 4:9. It just said: "All this I will give you," he said, "if you will bow down and worship me." Oh, nice, a promise for worshiping God you might think. Except, um, that's not what that verse is about. Here's the verse immediately before and immediately after as well as verse 9.

8 Again, the Devil took him to a very high mountain and showed him all the kingdoms of the world and their splendor.
9 "All this I will give you," he said, "if you will bow down and worship me."
10 Jesus said to him, "Away from me, Satan! For it is written: 'Worship the Lord your God, and serve him only.'"

So yeah, context is everything. Love whatever cool quote you want but get the context of it especially since people so love to pull stuff out of context and throw it around to try and

back their position. No, I don’t know why I decided to suddenly talk about context but there it is. As always, thank you so much for reading and I hope you enjoyed this chapter!

Down the River

Chapter Summary

> Adora needs a chance to get out of her head. Glimmer gives her the chance with a trip down river.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The happiness didn't last. Perfuma had talked with Scorpia but nothing had come of it, at least in the way of information on how to help Adora. Catra would be back soon and Adora was trying not to count the literal minutes. They hardly got to talk anymore as Catra was having issues getting minutes for her phone and she hadn't had a chance to write another letter. Adora knew it was because she was working hard but the little voice in her head told her it was because she was too busy with her new girlfriend, Britt.

Adora hadn't heard her and Catra hadn't mentioned her but Adora just knew that was what was going on. She fought herself to keep from thinking about it and even prayed one night that God bless Britt but that He bless her with someone else so she'd leave Catra alone. She'd always heard about praying for one's enemies but this was incredibly difficult to do because what she wanted to pray for was Britt's death but that didn't feel right to put into prayer.

Then one Monday, when Catra was supposed to be back the following Friday, Glimmer came up to Adora after breakfast.

“Hey, I need to ask a favor of you,” Glimmer said, a bit hesitant.

“Sure,” Adora replied. “What’s going on?”

“I need you to go on an overnight,” Glimmer said. “Dela is going tomorrow night and I was going along with Wasp but I can’t go. I figured you might not mind a camp out.”

“Sure, where is she going?” Adora said.

“Remember where we met?” Glimmer said.

Adora immediately knew what she was talking about, a little put in for canoes with pit toilets and primitive campsites. The parking lot was dirt and the road into it was a barely maintained dirt road out to the main county road. It was also the site of many campouts she’d been on when she’d been a camper at Camp Horde for the Lord.

“Yeah, that was the look I expected,” Glimmer said.

“I didn’t have a look,” Adora said.

“You had a look,” Glimmer replied.

“I’m fine,” Adora said. “I can go. It’ll be nice to see the place again.”

“Alright,” Glimmer said. “Wasp is going to drive the Purple Elephant with the canoes and put you in upriver then drive down to meet you with your camping stuff. You and Dela will go down in the boats with the campers.”

“I’ve never actually gone overnight in a canoe before,” Adora said.

“It’s no different than canoeing during the day,” Glimmer said. “Just don’t miss the landing or you’ll get to carry those heavy ass things back to the campsite. Dela’s done it before, you’ll be fine.”

“OK,” Adora said. “What’s the weather supposed to be?”

“It’s supposed to be clear and hot,” Glimmer said. “I’d still toss a poncho into your stuff just to be safe.”

“Alright,” Adora said.

That night, Adora got to talk to Catra. It wasn’t much of a talk. Catra sounded exhausted and Adora asked her about it.

“It’s this heat,” Catra said. “I mean, it’s dry, it’s a desert, I always thought that was bullshit but it’s true. It doesn’t feel that rough, especially in the shade. Then all of a sudden you feel like you’re going to pass out. Toss in I’m working next to a gas forge around 2,000 degrees and yeah, it’s miserable.”

“I’m sorry,” Adora said. “We’ll have to hit the water more when you’re here.”

“Damn, I never thought I’d crave that river,” Catra said with a tired laugh. Then there was a moment where Catra’s voice was quieter, like she was muffling the phone, and Adora heard her say, “Yeah, I’m on the phone. Naw, later. OK.”

“What was that?” Adora said as she heard Catra bring the phone back up.

“Someone coming by to see if we wanted to come hang out right now,” Catra said. “Guess someone’s throwing a fancy shindig.”

“Really? Who?” Adora said, trying not to let her mind run away from her.

“Who’s throwing the party? Someone with more money than sense probably,” Catra said.

“I mean who was inviting you,” Adora said.

“Oh! You wouldn’t know them,” Catra said and then paused. “Wait, yeah, you would. I mentioned her a while back. It’s that Britt girl.”

Adora seethed as she heard the name and did her best not to start a fight.

“Oh, yeah, I remember that name,” Adora said, doing her best nonchalant response.

“You alright?” Catra asked. “You mad that I got invited to a party?”

“No, of course not,” Adora said, while she wanted to say of course she didn’t care if Catra went to a party, she just cared if she went to a party with that blonde haired tramp or even be near said tramp.

“You sure sounded like it there,” Catra said.

“No, really, it’s fine,” Adora said, putting on her best happy voice, the voice she used to use on her mother when her mother was upset with Adora and Adora had to pretend to be fine.

Catra could hear something wasn't right but she didn't want to push it so she just let it go.

"Alright," Catra replied. "Listen, I need to get off her so I have a few minutes left to call you later. Love you."

"I love you too," Adora said and the call ended a few seconds later. Adora sat in the office, trying not to grind her teeth, thinking about how Catra had jumped off the call awful fast. She knew that Catra had to watch her minutes but at the moment Adora felt like that only came up when Catra wanted an out from the conversation.

She wandered back to Cottonwood Cove, trying to keep a cheerful face in the early evening light. She felt like she was getting way too good at that as no one commented on it when she sat down with some of the other program counselors at the campfire they had going in front of the cabins. One of them, the nature counselor named Salamander, was messing around with what looked like a row of rectangular rocks laid out in front of her. Adora sat down as the crowd, some of them leaning on the porches on the cabins as well, listened in silence to the soft tones that came off the stones as she struck them with what looked like two small mallets. When she finished, someone asked, "You called it a what?"

"Lithophone," Salamander replied. "It's just old scraps from a granite countertop. I cut them a bit to make them more uniform. I made the mallets from some scrap wood and rawhide chew toys I pulled apart"

“So it’s a xylophone?” Bow said.

Salamander shrugged as she said, “I mean, kinda. That’s metal though. This is different.”

Tossa sat back in Spinne’s arms as she said, “What was the name of the song?”

Salamander said, “It didn’t have one. I was just kinda screwing around and playing what sounded good.”

“It worked,” Spinne said as Tossa nodded. Adora sat down next to the two, not realizing she was looking closely at them, trying to figure out just how they were. They seemed happy but Adora couldn’t get the image of them arguing out of her head.

Perfuma sat down in the circle, a small goblet shaped drum in her hand. She looked around as she said, “Are we done drumming already?”

Salamander laughed as she said, “We don’t have to be. Play?”

Perfuma tucked the drum up under her arm and looked expectantly at Salamander who began a slow rhythm on the lithophone that Perfuma picked up. After about a minute, she began to improvise and after another minute, Salamander responded by improvising off what Perfuma was playing. Adora

sat and listened as the two went back and forth, their instruments seeming to almost anticipate the others' changes after a while.

As she sat, she wondered what Catra was doing at that moment. Had she gone to the party? Was she lonely? Was with Her? Was she just talking with Reggie? The thoughts spun around Adora's head and finally she stood to her feet and left the fire. She went up the stairs and into the cabin, hiding her feelings.

When she came in, Mista looked up from where she sat at the inside table with Sea Hawk, playing dominoes. They both saw her expression and Sea Hawk looked at Mista who just gave a little head shake before saying, "Need us to kill the light?"

"No, I'm fine," Adora said as she sat down on the bed and kicked her boots off.

"Truly, it is not a problem," Sea Hawk said. Adora didn't respond and just lay down on the bed. Mista let out a quiet sigh and the two went back to their game.

In the morning, Adora felt alright as she met with Dela and her cabin, a bunch of ten year olds who all looked at Adora like she was something exotic. Adora didn't realize most of these kids had been at camp last year and the stories that had got passed around about who she was and where she'd come from had gotten pretty exaggerated. Adora had her backpack over her shoulder as they all climbed on board the Purple Elephant right after breakfast. She'd seen the weather board outside the dining hall calling for hot and sunny for the day but she couldn't help but

look towards the west and see the clouds starting to form. Nothing too bad yet but she'd seen gentle, fluffy clouds turn ugly fast before.

Wasp finished checking the trailer with the canoes strapped to it as the kids stacked their overnight bags in the back of the bus. The smell of canvas was strong in the bus from the tents that were stacked in the back seats as well with their poles bungee corded to the seat pillars. Dela got everyone seated as Wasp got on the bus and gave a short safety lecture about staying seated before they got the bus going. Adora didn't have time to dwell in her head as she began to sing songs with the kids as they rolled down the road.

It took about thirty minutes to get to where they were going, a place called Skunkard Public Access Point. It was a spot by the river with a dirt parking lot and a stretch of sand and gravel beach. When they got there Adora, Wasp, and Dela started to unload the canoes from the trailer. The kids were all excited and hopping around as Adora had to keep laughing and telling them to wait as they took the canoes down. As they got it off, Dela would call out a number and two kids would come forward, put paddles and life jackets into the bottom and then lift it with a grunt and move it forward a little off the parking area and onto the beach.

"Take it to the waterline but do not put them in!" Dela said more than once.

Adora was a bit worried that the kids wouldn't listen but the canoes weren't light, being made of aluminum, and with their size made for ungainly movement. By the time they got the sixth, and

final, canoe down the rest were just getting lined up along the shore.

"On two?" Dela said to Adora who nodded at her. "One and *two!"*

They both lifted on two and walked the canoe down to the water. Once there, Dela started getting everyone ready to go while Adora went back to grab their lunch. When she got back, one of the kids, a girl named Tyler, was asking questions.

"Are we sure our bags will be alright?" Tyler asked.

"Safe as can be," Dela said. "Wasp is going to take the trailer back and then meet us at the campsite. Your stuff will be fine."

"But what if they break down?" Tyler asked and Adora could see the anxiety starting to etch into the girl like acid. "What if they get sidetracked or in an accident? What'll we do if they're not there?"

Dela started to answer when Adora spoke up.

"You know, the only thing that's really our worry is what if they're not there. And you know what happens then?"

Tyler shook her head.

"We'll get in our canoes and we'll keep on going back to camp," Adora said. "Then we'll worry about what's happened. Alright?"

Tyler thought for a moment and said, "Isn't it a really long way back to camp?"

"Not so much we couldn't do it all today if we had to," Adora said. "It'd be an adventure. Doesn't matter though. That's the future and we've planned the best we can for it. Let's just enjoy the river for now."

Tyler gave a slow nod and Adora could see the girl's worries hadn't gone away but she'd managed to push them down a little. She waited to see if she'd say anything else but nothing was forthcoming so Adora just nodded back.

After a little back and forth, they got the kids sorted out into their canoes, Dela going with Tyler, and they finally got pushed out into the gentle current. As they floated along, Adora could feel her face getting hot. She had on plenty of sunblock and a wide brimmed hat but the surface of the river acted like a mirror and she knew she had better keep on her sunblock game or she'd be crispy by the end of the day and made sure to call it out to the others so they'd have it in mind.

The first few hundred yards was a bit fraught as the kids got settled into the canoes and then finally began to paddle. The kid in Adora's canoe, named Mia, couldn't quite seem to get her paddle figured out at first and Adora spent most of the first few hundred yards adjusting the canoe from the back to keep its bow straight as Mia flailed a little with her paddle.

"Mia, try to keep the paddle straight when it hits the water," Adora said. "Watch me."

Mia turned a little, being very careful as she did, and watched as Adora dipped her paddle into the water and pulled.

"Just like that," Adora said.

"I can't get it straight like that," Mia said and Adora noticed then that the paddle she had was a bit too big for her.

"No worries. Try the best you can," Adora said. "Just try and don't yank too hard and we'll see if we can swap out paddles for something more your size."

Mia nodded and after a little trial and error found something that worked. Adora got her canoe to the back of the pack, while Dela took the front and the trip turned into a pleasant day out on the water. They moved at a leisurely pace, stopping on a gravel bar in the middle of the river to eat lunch and let the kids swim. Adora

sat on the bar as lifeguard as she watched the kids splash in the water and laugh and she let out a long contented sigh.

Dela sat down on the shore next to Adora as she said, "You sound like you're having a good time."

"I am," Adora said. "I needed this. Get out, exercise, a chance to get out of my head."

"I know what you mean," Dela said. "Mind if I ask you a personal question?"

Adora shrugged and nodded her head.

"I'm going assume that means you don't mind," Dela said before she went on without a pause for a response. "I don't really know you, I mean, I know you but… you know what I mean. I guess I gotta ask, you really a Jesus freak?"

Adora leaned back from Dela a little. She'd always been raised to answer yes to that question, proudly, but she'd heard it enough to know by now exactly what kind of person that other people called that. She finally said, "That's… yes, it's my religion but I wouldn't say freak."

"OK, sorry, I shouldn't have asked," Dela said, holding her hands up. "I just, I've seen the Bible on your shelf, and I've heard the

stories and you didn't seem the type. It just confused the hell out of me."

"What stories?" Adora asked.

"Kim! Get back in closer to shore!" Dela shouted to one of the kids before she responded to Adora. "Nothing bad. Just that you'd come from the camp across the way and we've all heard stories about that place."

Adora went from a little offended to actually kind of amused as she said, "You know, I heard stories about Bright Moon all the time as well. Kind of funny that it's going on here as well, although I never heard any about Horde for the Lord from anyone here."

"It's not like we're sitting around gossiping," Dela said. "That said, I can see no one bringing it up with you though."

"What was said?" Adora said. "I know we used to say that it was all co-ed cabins and devil worship over here."

Dela snorted as she said, "I can't imagine devil worship. Too much work. Gotta find a goat and everything you know?"

Adora gave a little uncomfortable chuckle and Dela noticed.

“Sorry, you’re not real comfortable with that are you?” Dela said.

“No, I’m not,” Adora replied. “It’s just, it’s not something I’d joke about.”

Dela nodded as she gave Kim a thumbs up when she asked if she was in the right place now and said, “Gotcha. I do, all the time. I grew up in a suburb where the only thing to do was drink, party, and go to church and people did all three. My parents weren’t religious and I had to grow up with people pestering me about it. Got old so, devil worshiping jokes.”

“Would it have mattered if I’d say I was a Jesus freak?” Adora asked.

“Yes,” Dela said without hesitation. “I mean, you’ve been cool and all and your girlfriend is awesome but I’d always wonder when you were going to give me both barrels of the ol’ John 3:16.”

Adora actually chuckled a little and Dela raised an eyebrow.

“Oh, God, did you lie to me?” Dela said, her voice actually amused at the concept.

Adora shook her head as she said, "My religion is very important to me but I'm the last person to try and convert anyone since I have all kinds of doubts about it myself. Besides, John 3:16 is so not what I would have gone with."

Dela said, "Alright, hit me with it then. What would you convert me with?"

Adora shook her head again as she said, "No, I don't want to make you uncomfortable."

Dela replied, "I had a person I thought of as a good friend make out with me and then try to tell me that I was going to Hell for what we had just done and he needed to pray with me and save my soul. You are not going to make me uncomfortable."

"Yeah, now I'm uncomfortable," Adora quipped but she smiled when she said it. "I'm sorry that happened."

"Meh, it's what it is," Dela said. "Now come on. Give me your spiel."

Adora shook her head as she said, "Naw, I don't want to but I would say that I always preferred 2 Corinthians 5:17 'Therefore if any man be in Christ, he is a new creature: old things are passed away; behold, all things are become new.' I like that idea, old things going away and a new start."

Dela watched the kids in silence for a moment before she nodded and said, "Yeah, I can see that, a new start. Better than a guilt trip about sending your son to die."

"So, are we weird now?" Adora said.

Dela grinned as she said, "Oh, we're weird alright but it's a good kind of weird."

Adora smiled as she said, "It's like that song Sea Hawk played. Creeps and weirdos."

Dela laughed as she said, "Yeah! You get it."

Adora grinned as she picked up a chunk of chert from the stones under her and fiddled with it for a moment before tossing it aside.

"I guess I do," Adora said before glancing at the sun overhead. The clouds she'd been worried about had thickened up a little but were behaving for the moment. "Think we should get going?"

Dela shrugged as she said, "We've only got a few more miles. Wasp will take their sweet time getting to the campground and I don't want Tyler to freak out if we get there before them."

“She does seem nervous,” Adora said, noticing Tyler sitting not too far away, sorting rocks.

“She didn’t want to come to camp,” Dela said. “She’s got anxiety and they put her in my cabin because I do too. I asked Glimmer to do it so I could be there for her.”

Adora looked at Dela as she said, “You always seem so mellow.”

Dela just shrugged as she said, “Because I mask it well. I’ve had years to learn and I’m medicated. I figure the least I can do is be there for her. I saw how you stepped up for her too. Don’t think I didn’t notice that, J-Freak, it was really kind of you.”

“That is not going to be my nickname,” Adora said.

Dela gave a wicked grin as she said, “It might be.”

Shortly afterwards, they got everyone rounded up and back into the canoes. The sun was disappearing behind the clouds more often than not and down on the river, it made the heavily wooded bottomland they floated past seem dark and almost mysterious. There were a few looming cliffs as well but as Dela had said, the second leg didn’t take that long and she was soon gesturing at Adora to start towards the east side of the river.

Adora saw the little cleared spot in the trees that served as a put in and she held back to make sure all the kids would be able to make it. She didn't have to worry though, all of them got up to the landing with no problem. Adora and Mia almost didn't though as she'd held off long enough that she had to paddle hard to get in.

"Alright, get them lined up here," Dela said as she pointed to a spot out of sight of the river along the little rutted single lane track that ran down to the put in. Adora walked up the path after everything was stowed away and had a moment of deja vu. It'd been just over a year since she'd been at this spot, watching Glimmer and her group of campers coming up, not knowing what was to come. The Purple Elephant was parked in the same place that Bow had put it in the year before. The only thing missing was the Camp Horde for the Lord van in the little dirt parking lot. Adora was shaken out of her remembrance when she heard Tyler let out an audible sigh of relief.

"See? Not so bad," Adora said.

Tyler just nodded as she followed the rest of the girls over. The next hour was taken up by getting the tents out of the bus, getting them set up, introducing the girls to the dubious wonders that were pit toilets, and then sending the girls off on a scavenger hunt in the woods. Wasp sat down on a stool they had hauled along and started fiddling with the little campfire ring, picking out half-burned garbage from it.

"You'd think they'd learn," Wasp said, looking at a half melted beer can before tossing it into a trash bag.

“Learn what?” Adora said as she crouched down on her heels.

“They toss it in, thinking it’ll burn up,” Wasp said. “And a campfire can get hot enough to burn up aluminum but whoever was here was three sheets to the wind and they weren’t keeping the fire hot enough. So, half burned trash.” Wasp wrinkled their nose as they pushed some half burned sticks out of the way and pulled out melted lump of plastic. “Don’t even get me started on trying to burn plastic.”

Adora was about to offer to help when she heard some singing coming across the clearing. The singing was a song she hadn’t heard in about a year, except maybe when she’d occasionally hummed it to herself.

“Onward Christian soldiers… marching as to war…”

“Well hell,” Wasp said as they stood up and walked over to where the bus was parked. “I was hoping we wouldn’t have neighbors tonight.”

Adora followed them and watched across the clearing as a string of kids came walking in carrying small backpacks. Walking at the head of them was a counselor she knew named Anne.

“You know her?” Wasp asked as they made the connection of who it was and saw Adora’s face.

“I know her,” Adora said.

“This going to be a problem?” Wasp said as they looked over at Anne.

“I doubt it,” Adora said. “She probably won’t even come over here.”

“Better not,” Wasp said, spitting on the ground.

“You know, she’s not a bad person,” Adora said.

“Has nothing to do with her,” Wasp said. “Just don’t like new people that much.”

“Really?” Adora said.

“Why do you think I got the name?” Wasp replied. “I get a bit too aggressive with people. Not like fighty, just… I don’t know, bitchy, I guess. I just want things to go smoothly for the kids.”

Adora nodded as she watched the group of kids drop their packs by the trees where she'd camped the year before. Anne started getting people organized, along with another counselor Adora thought she recognized named Kylee.

"Well let's not stare at them then," Adora said and went back toward their camp.

The kids got back from their scavenger hunt and Adora tried to shake off the thought of going over and seeing how Anne and Kylee were doing. When she'd been a counselor at Camp Horde for the Lord, she'd been friends with everyone. At Camp Bright Moon though, she'd never quite got that same feeling of camaraderie. She still thought of them as friends but it was hard sometimes as they were people she didn't share a common framework with and so she often felt awkward and out of place among them. When Catra was with her, it had been different. At least that had been someone who had understood her.

Adora was pretty quiet for the rest of the evening. Clouds had moved in and the air had gone still but it never did rain. The humidity skyrocketed and the campfire was a bust as no one wanted to sit around a hot fire in the still, stifling air. The kids were worn out from canoeing, swimming, running around, and so it ended up being an early night as everyone settled down to a restless sleep. Adora was the last one to bed, looking across the clearing in the dark to where Anne and Kylee led the kids in several songs. As the kids sang, Adora felt a stab of remorse as she remembered doing the same thing with Catra when they were kids. Then, camp had been a moment of affirming her life, showing her how right she was in her beliefs, and life seemed so much easier. Now, everything seemed like nothing but endless rounds of doubt and pain.

Chapter End Notes

The lithophone is one hundred percent a real thing and I heard one played once in person at a drum circle. It was quiet, although I've heard them louder on videos, and I remember everyone there sat in attentive silence as the guy who brought it played out a simple tune. It was absolutely mesmerizing. Also, in case you haven't noticed from this or other fics, I'm very much a hand drum person. I have the drum Perfuma is playing. It's an aluminum darbuka and it is a blast to play although it has a sharp rim that hungers for inattentive fingers.

I almost made the kids on the trip older but then I remembered that I canoed a river with a Boy Scout troop when I was eleven and did fifty miles in five days. Fantastic trip, even if I did get a fish hook in my neck (it was small, it didn't really hurt, and it makes for a great story).

Not much else to say at this time. Thank you as always for reading! We're pretty close to wrapping this up in the next few chapters I believe. Then I've got one story already done and ready for this series, a short one, and then the final story, called Graduation.

Like Lightning on a Sunny Day

Chapter Summary

> Adora is relaxing in camp one evening when Catra shows up unexpectedly as a surprise. However, all the things that have been happening look like they're about to come to a boil.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Kids had come and kids had gone as several weeks of camp went past. Some days Adora was nothing more than a shadow trying to get through the day but other days she was amped up and engaged and the day flew past. Adora got two more letters from Catra but they were short and Catra talked about how tired she was from working constantly. They'd talk every few days but those were short and to the point as well. Adora couldn't help but think it was because Catra was starting to pull away and once again Britt would run rampant through her brain before she'd have to fight to shake it out. She did try to take Mista's advice to just kind of roll with it and deal but it wasn't so easy as all of that.

Every other Saturday was a full night off for the staff as the one week and the two week campers would be gone at the same time. Some of the staff would pile into someone's car and drive into either Oak Springs or Rogers for a change of scenery while the rest turned into campers themselves, it felt like, as they'd take the time to do one of the many activities the camp had without having to watch out for kids. The evening would always find whoever was in camp under the arts and crafts pavilion chatting and laughing.

That night, Adora was sitting backwards on a chair in front of Glimmer, who was seated on a picnic table bench pulled up close to Adora while Glimmer fiddled with Adora's hair. She put it up into ponytails, braided it, combed it, but mostly she was just messing around as a way to pass time. Bow was sitting behind Glimmer on the table itself and was doing the same thing with Glimmer's hair.

The first hint to Adora that something was different was the conversation dying down. She tried to look around but couldn't move her head much though as Glimmer was in the middle of some elaborate braid project when she heard Catra.

"Don't you look comfy?"

"Catra!?" Adora said in joy as she struggled to her feet while Glimmer gave her good natured grief for messing up the braid. Adora saw Catra standing at the edge of the pavilion, leaning against a post, and ran over to her. She was used to the woos and other heckling when she kissed Catra, well, not used to exactly but she was kissing Catra so it faded away, and she did that for a few minutes before Kevin threatened them with a hose.

"Don't be jealous," Catra said with a laugh as she hooked an arm over Adora's shoulder and started playing with her hair. Adora immediately blushed as she put an arm around Catra's waist.

“What are you doing here?” Adora said. “I thought you weren’t going to be here for a few more days.”

“Yeah, well, Reggie got kicked by a horse…,” Catra started to say, way too nonchalantly, and Adora immediately cut her off.

“He got kicked by a horse!?”

“Not badly,” Catra said. “Just you know, a little nudge.”

“How much is a little nudge?” Bow said, who’d come over to them at that point.

Catra started to talk a few times but stopped herself and Adora gave her a little shake as she said, “That is not reassuring.”

“OK, so he’s got his ribs taped up,” Catra replied.

“And I’m guessing you’re here early because he had to go home to rest?” Glimmer said.

“Yeah,” Catra said.

“Are you sure he’s not dying?” Glimmer said with a snort.

“What!? No!” Catra said laughing.

“I’m actually not 100% kidding,” Glimmer said. “Old farmers like him, they don’t stop working for anything unless it’s life threatening.”

“OK, I’ve heard that as well but seriously, he’s alright,” Catra said. “I said I’d check in on him in a day or so but he’s just having trouble bending right now and said we both needed the break anyway.”

“Well I know I’m glad to see you,” Bow said.

Catra reached out and chucked Bow on the shoulder as she said, “Ah, I missed you too, buddy. I’m sure Adora here has been too busy getting her hair done to miss me though.”

“Stop it,” Adora said as she hugged her one-armed. “You know I missed you.”

“Did you though?” Catra said with a little smile that Adora didn’t entirely like.

“I’ll show you how much I miss you,” Adora said and then turned beet red as a few people who overheard her made loud wooing noises. “Not like that! I meant later, when I have a chance to talk with her more.”

“Is talking what they’re calling it these days!?” Mista shouted at her.

Adora covered her face with her hand as she said, “Sheesh.”

“You walked into that one, babe,” Catra said with a laugh.

“Can we change the subject now, please?” Adora said. “How long are you going to be here?”

“Looks like a while,” Catra said. “Reggie said he was going to get some stuff done around the house he’s been putting off and to consider it a vacation.”

“Sweet!” Bow said before Adora could respond. “We gotta take you to Coopers Hole if we get a chance.”

“Aunt Casta might be down in the next few days, I know she was asking about you the last time she was here,” Glimmer said.

“We shall go boating!” Sea Hawk shouted.

“You’re still banned from the boats!” Glimmer shouted back.

“OK, everyone take a breath. I get her for as long as I can,” Adora said as she pulled Catra in tight to her, possessiveness in her eyes, before suddenly pointing at Mista. “Don’t you dare woo!”

“I was going to shout ‘Hell, yes!’ thank you very much,” Mista said.

“Listen, I’m just going to go have some private time with my girlfriend,” Adora said as she pointed at several people and shook her head no at them, “and we will be back later to hang out.”

“Ten bucks says you don’t!” Dela shouted.

“I’ll get in on that action,” Mista said.

“Twenty says you’re wrong,” Catra said with a grin.

“Hey, you can’t participate!” Necktie shouted.

“It’s alright to be chicken,” Catra said.

“Can we just go?” Adora said with a shake of her head.

“Alright, we’ll be back, have your money ready,” Catra said, pointing around the pavilion.

They walked away to general jeers and laughter. After they got around the corner of the dining hall, Catra grabbed Adora for a more serious kiss that left them both giggling after a few minutes.

“You trying to lose your bet?” Adora said.

“It’d be worth it,” Catra replied.

“I’m surprised you’re here,” Adora said.

“What? Why? Do you not want me to be here?” Catra said and Adora shook her head in confusion.

“No! Of course I want you to be here; I just wasn’t expecting you,” Adora replied.

“OK, yeah, I guess,” Catra said.

“Is something wrong?” Adora asked.

“No,” Catra said as she looked away.

“Hey, really, is something wrong?” Adora said.

“No,” Catra said, looking back as she pulled Adora in closer. “Come on, let’s go for a walk.”

Adora started to open her mouth to ask what was wrong but nothing came out as she followed Catra. Even though Adora had been at the camp when no one else but her, Bow, Catra, and Glimmer and her family had been there, the camp felt even more empty at the moment. She squeezed Catra’s hand, just to get a squeeze back in return, and took a deep breath as they passed a group of empty cabins.

The two didn’t talk and with every step, Adora felt more and more uncomfortable. She found herself thinking of how her mother used to behave when she was upset, not saying anything, expecting Adora to just know what the problem was and for her to either apologize or correct it immediately. With that thought in mind, the further they walked in silence, the madder Adora got. Everything that had been in her head over the last month drove the anger that came boiling out all at once.

“OK, where are we going?” Adora said as she stopped and yanked her hand out of Catra’s hand.

“What the hell?” Catra said, snapping around to face Adora.

“You’re the one that showed up and acted all happy until you got me out of sight!” Adora said.

“Well I was happy until about five seconds ago when you started acting like an ass,” Catra said.

“What!? I just asked where we’re going because we’ve been walking in dead silence!” Adora said.

“You yanked your hand away and asked real shitty where we were going,” Catra said.

“I just asked,” Adora said, rolling her eyes.

“What the hell, man? I haven’t seen you in for-fucking-ever and this is how you act when I get here?” Catra said.

“Maybe if you talked to me for more than a few minutes at a time when you’re away, it wouldn’t be so bad,” Adora said.

“I can’t afford the minutes and you damn well know that!” Catra responded.

“You could have used the money you’ve been saving to get more!” Adora said.

“Why do you care about this all of a sudden!? We agreed on this!” Catra said. “I’ve even been writing!”

Adora felt a little guilty as she knew Catra had and had even re-read the first letter several times but then the image of Britt flashed across her mind and she got angry all over again.

“Yeah, I guess,” Adora said, turning her back on Catra.

“What do you mean, you guess?” Catra said.

“I just know you’ve been busy,” Adora said and the emphasis she put on busy clanged like a dropped wrench on concrete.

“OK, what the hell does that mean?” Catra said.

“Nothing,” Adora said. “You’ve been busy, I get it.”

Catra came around so she was facing Adora again as she said, “No, you said it weird.”

“I didn’t say it any which way,” Adora said. “You’re the one reading things into how I’m talking.”

Adora didn’t realize she was mimicking her mother’s method of arguing at that point as Catra said, “Don’t tell me I’m making up how you sounded.”

“I’m just saying, I didn’t say it any special way,” Adora said, crossing her arms.

“No, fuck this,” Catra said. “I show up early as a surprise and you get all bent out of shape at it!? I’m busting my ass all day, every day, saving money for us, and you act like some entitled princess because I haven’t been talking to you all the damn time!? That’s bullshit!”

“I don’t want you talking all the time! Just longer than like two minutes a night!” Adora said.

“It hasn’t been that short!” Catra replied.

“I know, you’ve got to be careful,” Adora said, pausing for a moment before she went on to say, “with money.”

“I don’t know what the hell that was supposed to mean but yeah, I do,” Catra said. “Remember our plan? The one you fucking agreed to? Or now that you’re just sitting around in people’s laps getting your hair done, is it not so important anymore? Is that how it is?”

“Hey! I’ve been working too!” Adora said. “Just because I have a night off doesn’t mean I haven’t!”

“Yeah, you looked real exhausted giggling while Glimmer played with your hair,” Catra said.

Adora suddenly flushed hot, not sure why, as she said, “I wasn’t giggling!”

“You were giggling,” Catra said, her voice snide.

“Why does this even matter?” Adora said, shaking her head. “It shouldn’t be a thing if Glimmer is messing with my hair.”

“Yeah, I’m sure,” Catra replied. “I’m sure you don’t mind *at all* .”

“Well who’s been playing with your hair!?” Adora snapped out. “Maybe it matters to me.”

“What the hell are you talking about?” Catra said. “I don’t have it all easy like you do!”

“Easy! I bust my behind here! I work in the office…,” Adora was about to say that she would then go and run around the camp and do anything that was available for her but she never finished before Catra cut her off.

“Oh, the office,” Catra sneered. “Real hard in the air conditioning with a seat.”

Adora started and stopped half a dozen replies, trying to find just the thing to say as she felt herself shaking in anger at Catra and how she’d dismissed her when she finally shouted out, “Well, I can’t be Britt now, can I, and get all sweaty in the barn with you!”

At that Adora twisted on her heel and stomped into the trees.

“What the fuck are you talking about!?” Catra shouted at her. “Get back here, God damn it!”

Adora had already disappeared into the undergrowth, wiping at her eyes as tears fell. She heard Catra try to follow her and then curse loudly but Adora just kept going because she just knew it was over. She knew it in her soul and she had no idea what to do.

Chapter End Notes

> This was going to be the end chapter originally but I figured I'd rather split it. Anyway, I hope you enjoyed this and thank you for reading!

A Friend In Need

Chapter Summary

When you find your friends in distress, it's time to help save them from themselves.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“I told you, I heard shouting,” Bow said as he walked through the woods with Glimmer, looking around.

“Bow, they haven’t seen each other in forever, maybe we shouldn’t be trying to find their ‘shouting’ you know?” Glimmer said.

“Not that kind of shouting,” Bow said. “I know I heard Catra yelling like she was mad and I think I heard Adora doing it as well.”

“What would they have to be mad about?” Glimmer said.

“I don’t know,” Bow said as he stopped at a trail intersection and let out a long sigh. “Could be anything, you know?”

Glimmer was about to say something when she saw someone coming up the trail. Bow played his flashlight around their feet, so he wouldn't blind whoever it was, and saw it was Catra, alone and stomping up the trail.

"Catra, you alright?" Bow asked.

"Get the fuck out of my way, right the fuck now!" Catra shouted and Glimmer stepped right into her path.

"Oh, fuck no, you're not talking to him like that!" Glimmer shouted right back.

Catra stopped at the last second before she collided with Glimmer and Bow could see both of them had their fists clenched.

"OK, hang on! It's alright!" Bow said.

"Move, both of you!" Catra said.

"You apologize to Bow right the fuck now and I will," Glimmer replied.

"Shorty, I will knock you right on your ass if you don't get out of my way," Catra said, her voice a low growl.

“You wanna dance, is that it?” Glimmer shot back. “I’ll kick your ass!”

“That is enough!” Bow said, putting his hand between the two so they couldn’t see each other’s faces. They both looked at him and he could feel the anger pouring off both of them. “What is going on here!?”

“Like you don’t know,” Catra snorted.

“I don’t. That’s why I’m asking,” Bow said, his voice level and calm even though his whole body language screamed at how uncomfortable he felt at the confrontation.

“Just get out of my way,” Catra said as Bow carefully got between her and Glimmer.

“Sure,” Bow replied. “You need something?”

Catra crossed her arms as Glimmer looked around Bow to seeth at Catra.

“I just got to go get my stuff, alright?”

“Why?” Bow said.

“Because I’m leaving, alright!? You made me say it, are you fucking happy now?” Catra said.

“No, because I don’t want you to leave,” Bow said and Catra looked up at him. In the dim light of the flashlight, she could see that his face actually looked sad.

She let out a long sigh as she said, “Listen, I don’t want to either but I know when I’m not wanted. Just… just move, OK?”

Catra had intended the last bit to be a little more forceful but it was hard to say it that way when she was fighting back tears. Glimmer looked at her and let out a long sigh as she said, “Listen, you know we’re not going to just move on. We’re your friends, remember?”

“Some friend, you were just telling me you were going to kick my ass,” Catra said as she wiped at her eyes.

“I still can if you don’t tell us what’s going on,” Glimmer said.

Catra shook her head as she said, “I’m just going to do the right thing and let Adora be happy, alright? You all can be happy and I’ll just go, I don’t know, figure something out.”

Catra muttered the last part as she took a step back and shrugged as she looked at the ground.

"What do you mean, all of us be happy?" Bow said. "Why can't you be happy with us as well?"

"Don't make me say that," Catra said, her voice suddenly bitter. "Don't."

Bow stepped forward and Catra stepped back as he said, "Hey, I want you to be happy as well."

"You want to maybe not sit there and mope and actually talk to us?" Glimmer said. "I swear to God, you and Adora needed to have a talk months ago about her problems and obviously yours as well."

"Jesus, just shut the hell up, OK!? You get Adora, why do you care how I feel!?" Catra said.

"Wait… do you think…," Bow started to stammer as his face went hot. Glimmer though, just started laughing.

"Are you fucking kidding me!? You're going to laugh in my face!?" Catra said.

“Do you think Adora is cheating on you with me!?” Glimmer said, her sentence punctuated with snorts of laughter and didn’t wait for an answer before going on. “She thinks you’re cheating on her with someone named Britt!”

Catra’s face went through several different emotions before it settled on confusion as she said, “What?”

Glimmer was leaning against a tree now as she said, “Yeah, I guess you work with someone named Britt or something? I don’t know, you never mention her.”

Catra was looking back down the trail as she remembered the last thing that Adora had said before she’d stormed off.

“She… she really thinks I was cheating on her,” Catra said and her shoulders sagging as she said it.

“Well, you thought she was too,” Glimmer said as she stepped up beside Catra.

Catra glared at her as she said, “What was I supposed to think when I walk in and see her all cozy in your lap?”

“The same thing you did when she was back in December? Or you know, when you were and I was fiddling with your hair? Or is that different somehow?” Glimmer shot back. “You two being apart has made you both stupid, I swear.”

Catra started to open her mouth, shut it, cursed under her breath and took a few steps back before turning around and coming back.

“God damn it,” she replied.

“It’s still fixable,” Bow said.

“No, it’s not,” Catra said. “She thinks I’m cheating, I thought she was, we’re both so fucked up, I’m surprised it lasted this long.”

“Oh, Jesus, can you not with the melodrama? This is stupid and you know it,” Glimmer said.

“We hardly ever see each other! It’s…,” Catra started to trail off as Bow spoke up.

“For the best? You don’t think that, do you?” Bow said.

“Don’t tell me what I think,” Catra snapped at him before sighing. “Fine, no, I don’t think that. I love her.”

“Do you want to go and find her?” Bow said as he stepped up and put an arm around Catra’s shoulder and gave her a hug. Catra looked at him and let out another sigh.

Meanwhile, Adora had got back to a trail, managing to avoid some greenbriar by a narrow margin on her little shortcut through the brush, and was heading back to Cottonwood Cove. That was her plan at least. What had ended up happening was she had got a little ways down the trail towards the cabins when she’d stopped, leaned against a tree, and tried not to cry too loud. After a few minutes, she went from leaning against the tree to sitting on the ground beside the trail and thought about just becoming a permanent fixture there as she stared out into the dark.

“Here sits Adora, she messed up everything,” she muttered to herself.

For a moment, she thought she heard someone answer her and then realized she was hearing someone coming down the trail and talking. The voices were low but seemed to be arguing a bit.

“How many times are we going to hash this out?” she heard a voice she recognized as Tossa say.

“As many times as it takes I guess,” Spinne responded as they came around a curve in the trail. “I mean… hello? Is someone there?”

“Uh, hi,” Adora said, sniffling.

“Adora? What are you doing sitting out here?” Tossa said as she walked up to her.

“Nothing,” Adora said.

“You’re just sitting under a tree crying for fun?” Spinne asked.

“I’m not crying,” Adora said.

“You’re a terrible liar,” Tossa said. “What’s going on?”

Adora shook her head as she said, “Everything is wrong. Just… nothing. I don’t want to talk about it.”

Spinne sat down in the dust in front of her as she said, “Come on, you can tell us.”

“No, I really don’t want to,” Adora said. “Both of you have your own issues.”

“What issues?” Tossa said as she sat down beside Spinne.

“You two have been arguing all summer it feels like,” Adora said. “I just… I don’t want to pile more on that.”

“No, we haven’t,” Spinne said.

“I heard you two arguing one of the first weeks we were here,” Adora said. “You went into your cabin while you were doing it.” Spinne and Tossa looked at each other as Adora went on. “Just now, it sounded like you were arguing. Lately you seem so… I don’t know, serious.”

Tossa took Spinne’s hand as she said, “Yeah, I guess we have been bickering a bit. It’s for a good reason though.”

“What do you mean? It’s never a good reason,” Adora said.

“People argue, Adora,” Spinne said. “You just got to talk it out. Besides, she means it’s a good reason because of what we’re arguing about.”

“I’m lost,” Adora said.

“No, you’re not,” Spinne said and pointed as she went on. “Archery is just around the corner here and the campfire ring is that way.”

Adora shook her head with a little bit of irritation as she said, “That’s not what I meant.”

“Yeah, I know,” Spinne said and looked at Tossa who nodded at her. “We haven’t told anyone but we’re arguing more because we’re arguing about our wedding.”

Adora didn’t know what to say at first. First it was just imagining a wedding between two women, something she knew was legal but had never really thought about. Then it was trying to imagine why someone would ever argue over a wedding, something she’d been raised to believe was the happiest moment in a woman’s life and the only thing to pursue. She’d never really cared about that before because when she’d thought of marrying some guy, it’d never really sparked any kind of interest. Then the next part that kept her from responding was she was suddenly thinking of marrying Catra and she was too flustered to even speak at first and then she started quietly crying again.

“You broke her,” Tossa said.

Adora shook her head as she wiped at her eyes and forced herself to get her tears under control as she said, “Hang on, you’ve been arguing over a wedding?”

“Over our wedding, yes,” Spinne said.

“That makes no sense,” Adora said. “Why would you argue over a wedding? You’re not even engaged.”

“Haven't been involved with a lot of weddings, have you?” Tossa said. “And we are but no one knows yet, remember? We’re keeping it under wraps for the moment.”

“Well, I have been involved in a lot of weddings and we’re arguing because you have to be right all the time,” Spinne said.

Tossa rolled her eyes as she said, “No, I don’t, I just point out when there’s something that needs to be pointed out.”

“So you’re not about to break up?” Adora said.

“No,” Spinne and Tossa both responded.

“But you’re arguing all the time!” Adora said.

“Couples argue,” Spinne said. “OK, not all the time and yeah, we’ve been arguing more lately but still, sometimes arguments happen. It’s part of a relationship.”

“I never saw you argue last summer,” Adora said.

Tossa snorted as she said, “Adora, we don’t argue in front of you. We try not to argue in front of anyone.”

“Seems we’ve failed on that front,” Spinne responded.

Tossa nodded as she said, “Still, we don’t argue in front of people. That’s private and we’re away from the whole point of why we stopped here. Why are you sitting out in the woods crying?”

“Catra and I had a fight,” Adora said. “I think… I think we…”

She started crying again, hating herself for doing it in front of Spinne and Tossa, as she couldn’t bring herself to say she thought they had broken up. Spinne got up beside Adora and put an arm around her shoulder as Adora leaned in and tried to control her tears.

“You think you broke up?” Tossa said gently and Adora nodded as she cried a little harder.

Spinne hugged her as she said, “You know this for sure or you just think so?”

“I know it,” Adora said, her voice miserable.

“You sure?” Tossa asked.

Adora snapped, “Yes! She’s cheating on me!”

Tossa and Spinne looked at each other before looking back at Adora as Tossa said, “How do you know?”

“I just know,” Adora said, sitting up from Spinne as furiously wiped at her eyes, her anger taking over from her sorrow.

“OK, so you really want to toss away your relationship on a, ‘I just know’? Is that how you want to handle that?” Tossa said.

“Listen, I know the signs,” Adora said.

“Then tell me,” Tossa said. “Come on, maybe you’ll feel better.”

Adora shook her head but then started talking. Tossa and Spinne listened as Adora started off slow but then started talking about how she knew that Britt had stolen Catra from her. How Catra had talked about her all the time and how Britt had quit a job to go on the road and follow Catra around and how Catra was always going to parties with Britt and after a while, Adora kind of wound down into misery as she took a tissue that Tossa handed her and wiped at her nose.

"And then she got mad at me tonight for no good reason and I confronted her with it and left," Adora said.

"Sounds pretty damning," Spinne said and something in her face had Adora trying to read her face in the darkness.

"You don't believe me," Adora said.

"Didn't say that," Spinne said.

"How do you know she quit her job to follow Catra?" Tossa said.

"Because it happened right when Catra was working there," Adora said.

"So you don't actually know from her own mouth. Did Catra say it?" Tossa said.

“No,” Adora said, feeling muleish.

“And the parties, how do you know Catra has been doing that?” Tossa said.

“Because I heard her get invited to one when I was on the phone,” Adora said.

“And she went?” Spinne said.

“Well, no, not then,” Adora said. “But she’s getting invited! Listen, you just don’t get it!”

Tossa laughed as she said, “My mom always said my kids would say that to me one day. Didn’t think I’d hear it this soon.”

“It’s not funny,” Adora said as she stood up.

“No, it’s not, I’m sorry for laughing,” Tossa said. “Listen, maybe Catra is leaving you for this Britt person and you’re totally right…”

“I am,” Adora said, crossing her arms.

“Or maybe you need to go and tell her everything you just told us and talk it out,” Tossa said.

“Yeah, I think you two really screwed up on the communications front,” Spinne replied.

“No!” Adora said. “We talk all the time!”

“Listen,” Tossa said. “Do you want to break up with her?”

“No, but if she’s cheating on me, what's the point?” Adora said.

“I think you need to go and talk with her,” Tossa said. “You both need to sit down, take a deep breath, and try not to yell at each other. Don’t accuse, don’t blame, and don’t read into stuff. Just listen to what the other person is saying.”

“We do that,” Adora said but she didn’t say it with any conviction as she knew she’d avoided having hard talks with Catra. Tossa just raised an eyebrow.

“Alright, you talk but I bet you don’t *talk.* You need to actually listen to what is being said and not make stuff up in your head. Do you know the I statement thing?” Spinne said.

“No,” Adora said, looking down at the ground.

“Try to start statements with an ‘I feel like blah blah blah.’ It’s less confrontational,” Spinne said.

“That works?” Adora said.

“It helps,” Tossa said.

“Maybe I’ll wait until tomorrow,” Adora said as she kicked at the dirt.

“Nope,” Tossa said, taking Adora’s arm. “We’re going to find her right now.”

“But what if she’s still mad?” Adora said, her voice small.

“Then you get to learn how to de-escalate as well,” Tossa said. “Come on. For all you know she’s packing her bags right now.”

Adora suddenly had an image of Catra walking out the gates of Camp Bright Moon, her bag over her shoulder, and she started up

the trail at a hard walk that had Spinne and Tossa struggling to catch up.

Bow, Glimmer, and Catra were by the dock, wondering exactly where Adora could be. Bow and Glimmer were trying to think of the next place to look as Catra glared at the big cross on the hill across the river at Camp Horde for the Lord and responded with snippy answers.

"You know, you could try and be a bit more helpful and less of a pain in the ass," Glimmer snapped at Catra.

"You know the camp better than I do," Catra said. "I'm just tagging along so she can yell at me when we see her."

"OK, see, that's not the attitude you need right now," Bow said. "You were pretty positive just a few minutes ago."

"Yeah, well, I thought she'd be here," Catra said as she flopped down on the ground with a grunt. "I can't do anything right."

Bow sat down next to her as he said, "Listen, I don't know what's going to happen but I know that you can do things right. You're not a screwup, alright?"

"I didn't say screwup," Catra said. "That's your word."

“That’s not what…,” Bow started to stutter when Catra gave him a little push.

“I’m just trying to make a joke,” Catra said with a little grin before it left her face and she sighed again.

Glimmer sat down next to her as she said, “Could you not antagonize my boyfriend, please?”

“Yeah, I guess,” Catra said and then stared across the water for a moment. “You know what’s fucked up? I miss that place sometimes.”

“God, why?” Glimmer said.

“Because it was familiar,” Catra said. “Adora and I used to race between our cabin and the dining hall. We’d stay up late whispering about stuff. The rest of my year sucked but for a week I got to see Adora. Then I got to be staff and I got to see her for a couple of months and…”

Catra trailed off as she pulled her knees to her chest and buried her face in her arms. It was obvious she was crying but she was doing everything she could to keep quiet about it. Bow gently laid a hand on her shoulder and she flinched away for a moment before settling into it.

"We'll find her," Bow said.

It was a few minutes after he said that, as they sat in quiet to let Catra compose herself, that they heard voices coming down the path. Glimmer stood up and saw Tossa, Spinne, and Adora walking towards them.

"Uh, Catra, she's coming this way," Glimmer replied.

Catra was on her feet in a moment and looking down the path. She saw the three coming their way by the light of the flashlight in Spinne's hand.

"Go talk to her," Bow said.

"I… um…, OK, yeah, I'll go," Catra said but she didn't take a step forward until Glimmer reached over and gave her a little push. "Jesus, you don't have to push, I'm going!"

"No, you weren't," Glimmer said, flapping her hands at her to get going as Catra finally started down the path.

Glimmer and Bow saw the two stop a little way away from each other on the path. Spinne and Tossa stood there for a few moments before moving down to stand by Glimmer and Bow. All

four could see the two awkwardly standing but everyone was pretty sure they were talking.

"At least they're not yelling, that's a plus," Tossa said.

"Should we be staring at them?" Bow said.

"Meh, it's fine," Glimmer said.

At the same time, Spinne said, "We shouldn't."

There was a little chuckle from all of them and Bow led them down to the docks, where they couldn't see the two. The four sat down at the end, the sound of the river burbling past a little undertone to their conversation. After a few minutes of back and forth about what was going on, Tossa spoke up.

"Well, change of subject. Since we spilled the beans to Adora we might as well tell everyone. Spinne and I are engaged."

"That's fantastic!" Bow said. "Congratulations!"

The four chatted about that and then the conversation drifted to other things. After about forty-five minutes, Glimmer said, "You think we should check on them?"

“I don’t want to bother them,” Bow said.

“One of us should at least go and make sure they don’t need anything,” Tossa said.

“They’ll come get us if they do,” Spinne said.

“Will they though?” Glimmer said. Everyone looked at Glimmer before all eyes turned to Bow.

“OK, yeah, I get it. I’ll just go take a look real quick,” Bow said.

He was gone for about five minutes and when he came back, Catra and Adora were walking just behind him, hand in hand.

“Look who I found,” Bow said as they all walked to the end of the dock.

Both of their faces were puffy from crying but they were both smiling as they stood a little back from the group.

“Just needed to talk it out?” Tossa said.

They both nodded as Adora said, “I’m sorry for putting you all through this.”

“You should be,” Glimmer said with a laugh as Catra flipped her off. “Seriously, it’s alright. Although I do believe we told you to do this weeks ago.”

“You knew about this weeks ago?” Catra replied.

“Yeah, and I told her to talk about it weeks ago,” Glimmer said. “Keep up.”

“Everything’s settled though?” Spinne said.

“Yeah,” Adora said as she hugged Catra. “I’m an idiot.”

“Don’t say that about yourself,” Bow said as everyone sat down.

“No, I am,” Adora said. “The person I was all worried about, I shouldn’t have been.”

Catra started laughing as she said, “Yeah, that Britt she was worried about? Super Christian and incredibly straight. Like has all

her future kids' names picked out and wears a purity ring straight.”

“You know you just described Adora like a year or so ago,” Glimmer replied.

“Hey!” Adora replied.

“Is she wrong?” Tossa said.

“Well, I wasn’t incredibly straight,” Adora said.

“You dated Kyle,” Catra said with a snicker.

“That was camp dating, that doesn’t count,” Adora said.

“Does this imply you have your future kid names decided though?” Bow said.

Adora didn’t hesitate as she said, “Ruth for the first girl and Finn for the first boy.”

“After that it’s Mary for the next girl and Paul for the next boy,” Catra said with a grin.

“You remembered!?” Adora said, her face full of love as she looked at Catra.

“Because you kept bringing it up when you’d talk about how we’d be friends for life and everything,” Catra said with a little nudge of her shoulder and a smile.

“So are things worked out then? No more drama?” Spinne asked.

“Yeah, we’re still together,” Catra said. “Made a promise to be more open and talk better.”

“That’s all you need,” Glimmer said.

“No, it’s not,” Tossa replied. “It certainly helps though.”

“Well, at the very least, I’m hoping to make it to another summer,” Adora said.

“Me too,” Catra said as she leaned over and kissed her.

Chapter End Notes

Not much to say on this one. I’m just about done with this series, although I have two more stories at least to go. One is a short story and will go up soon. The other is the final story and will go up in chapters. I did realize that I never did give Adora her nickname. I had several but never did really settle on one. I'll say that the one that I really liked was Dorable. It was a mix of durable and Adora. In the end though, I think Glimmer failed in her quest to get her a nickname.

Anyway, I hope you enjoyed this and I thank you as always for reading!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!